CONSTITUTIONS
AND
DIRECTORY OF SPIRITUALITY

INSTITUTE OF THE INCARNATE WORD

CONSTITUTIONS AND DIRECTORY OF SPIRITUALITY



New York - 2013

Translated by members of the Religious Family of the Incarnate Word from the Spanish editions, "Constituciones del Instituto del Verbo Encarnado" and "Directorio de Espiritualidad del Instituto del Verbo Encarnado." Editorial assistance/support provided by Come Alive Communications, Inc., West Grove, PA.

Cover Design
© IVE Press

Cover Art
© IVE Press

Text
© Institute of the Incarnate Word, Inc.

All rights reserved.

Manufactured in the United States of America.

IVE Press
113 East 117th Street
New York, NY 10035

Ph. (646) 470–9590
Fax (855) 483–2665

orders@ivepress.org
www.ivepress.org

ISBN 1-939018-27-4
ISBN 13 978-1-939018-27-4

Library of Congress Control Number: 2013901946

Printed in the United States of America ∞

The present text of the Constitutions of the Institute of the Incarnate Word is approved by His Excellency Andrea Maria Erba on May 8th, 2004, and subsequently amended by the Fifth General Chapter of the Institute, held in Segni (Italy) in July 2007.

All amendments introduced in the text are found in "Alegato n. 1" of the letter for approval dated November 21st, 2007 and addressed to His Excellency Vicenzo Apicella, Bishop of Velletri-Segni, except with regard to paragraphs nn. 70 and 283. As per the Sacred Congregation for Institutes of Consecrated Life and Societies of Apostolic Life, paragraph n. 283 has not been amended, and paragraph 70 has been rewritten.

Two hard-bound copies of the entire text were presented to His Excellency Vicenzo Apicella for approval.

Segni, February 14th, 2009, Feast of Sts. Cyril and Methodius.

Rev. Father Carlos Miguel Buela, IVE
Superior General

Rev. Father Gonzalo Ruiz Freites, IVE
General Secretary

***

Vidimus et approbamus
ad normam Codicis Iuris Canonici (can. 595,1)

His Excellency Vicenzo Apicella
Bishop of Velletri-Segni



CONSTITUTIONS

CONTENTS

PART 1 INTRODUCTION 13

PART 2 NATURE AND PURPOSE OF THE INSTITUTE 23

PART 3 SPIRITUALITY 31

PART 4 CONSECRATED LIFE 37

PART 5 COMMUNITY LIFE 57

PART 6 APOSTOLATE 89

PART 7 FORMATION OF MEMBERS 105

PART 8 GOVERNMENT OF THE INSTITUTE 141

PART 9 ADMINISTRATION OF GOODS 181

PART 10 SEPARATION FROM THE INSTITUTE 185

PART 11 OBLIGATION TO OBSERVE THE CONSTITUTIONS 189

PART 1

INTRODUCTION

OUR RELIGIOUS FAMILY: GENERAL PRINCIPLES OR OUR "WAY" (CF. ACTS 9:2)

1. [Intention] We profess that God is the Lord and Father of all things, the beginning and end of everything; that His Son, Our Lord Jesus Christ, was made flesh, died, and rose from the dead to save all men; and that the Holy Spirit is the Lord and giver of life. For the glory of the Holy Trinity, for a greater manifestation of the Incarnate Word, and for the honor of the Church founded by Christ which "subsists in the Catholic Church which is governed by the successor of Peter and by the bishops in communion with him,"[1] we want to give "testimony that the world can neither be transfigured nor offered to God without the spirit of the beatitudes."[2] We ask the Blessed Virgin Mary to grant us the grace to persevere in this purpose until death.

2. We want to live in a state that "constitutes a closer imitation and an abiding re-enactment in the Church of the way of life embraced by God's Son when he came into the world..."[3] by the practice of the evangelical counsels, thus contributing to the revelation of "the variegated nature and the multiple dynamism of the Incarnate Word of God."[4]

---

[1] LG 8.
[2] LG 31.
[3] LG 44.
[4] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to members of the Council of the Union of Superiors General, November 26, 1979.

3. [Name] We want our Religious Family to be known as and called "**the Incarnate Word**" as we approach the 2,000th anniversary of the Incarnation, an unsurpassable event greater than the creation of the world.

4. [Universal Purpose] Our objective is twofold. First, we seek the glory of God and the salvation of our own souls, and those of our brethren. We do this especially by practicing those virtues that allow us to share more fully in Christ's emptying of Himself.[5]

5. [Specific Purpose] Secondly, we specifically pledge all our strength to inculturate the Gospel, that is, to extend the Incarnation "to all men, in the whole man, and in all of the manifestations of man,"[6] in accordance with the teachings of the Magisterium of the Church.[7] In this respect, His Holiness Blessed John Paul II teaches: "The term 'acculturation,' or 'inculturization' may well be a neologism, but it expresses very well one of the elements of the great mystery of the Incarnation."[8]

6. [Consecration by Means of Vows] In order to achieve greater perfection in our service to God and His people, we take three vows: **chastity**, *for the sake of the Kingdom of Heaven* (Mt 19:12); **poverty**, *sell what you have* (Mk 10:21); and **obedience**, which *is better than sacrifice* (1 Sm 15:22). We do this in order to more closely imitate the chastity, poverty, and obedience of the Incarnate Word.

---

[5] Cf. Phil 2:7-8; PC 5.

[6] Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Meeting with men and women of culture and entrepreneurs in the Seminary of San Toribio in Lima, n. 5 (5/15/1988) (*a todo el hombre y a todas las manifestaciones del hombre*) (Translation is ours).

[7] Especially: GS 53-62, EN 20, CT 53, etc.

[8] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Pontifical Biblical Commission on Biblical Science and Magisterium of the Church, April 26, 1979. OR (04/24/1979) Spanish Edition.

7. [Foundation] We want to always be rooted in Jesus Christ, and only in Christ, who *has come in the flesh* (1 Jn 4:2) and lives forever. We want the fullness of Christ in everything and everybody, for *no one can lay any other foundation* (1 Cor 3:11) than Christ, *the Rock*.[9] We want to love and serve Jesus Christ – His Body and His Spirit – and to help others love and serve Him. We want to love and serve the physical Body of Christ, the Eucharist, as well as His Mystical Body, the Church. His Church consists of us – who must become "other Christs" through the holiness of our lives – and of all men in whom we see Christ himself, especially the poor, the sinners, and enemies. We want to be "like another humanity of Christ."[10] We want to be chalices full of Christ, chalices that allow the superabundance of His grace to overflow upon others. We want to show by our lives that Christ is alive, and that His Spirit is the soul of the Church, because *anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him* (Rom 8:9).

8. [Spirituality] In this respect, we believe that our spirituality must be profoundly marked by all aspects of the mystery of the Incarnation, namely: a) the origin of the Incarnation; b) Christ's two Natures (Human and Divine); c) the union of these Natures; d) the purpose of the Incarnation.

9. a) The Origin of the Incarnation. We must have a deep and firmly-rooted devotion to the Most Holy Trinity, the active principle of the Incarnation, and to the Persons of the Most Holy Trinity to Whom the work of the Incarnation is appropriated, that is, to the Father, insofar as He is the Principle of the Son – *For I proceeded and came forth from God* (Jn 8:42), and to the Holy Spirit, insofar as He is the personal Love from Whom all divine works proceed – "by the Holy Spirit [He] was incarnate…".[11] The primacy of the spiritual derived from this devotion must permeate

[9] Cf. 1 Cor 10:4.
[10] BLESSED ELIZABETH OF THE TRINITY, *Elevation* 34.
[11] Apostle's Creed.

our thoughts, feelings, and actions since it is God *at work in us, both to will and to work for his good pleasure* (Phil 2:13). The teaching of the Incarnate Word in this respect is clear: *seek **first** his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things shall be yours as well* (Mt 6:33). Our devotion to the Most Holy Trinity must also produce a total abandonment to God's "will of good pleasure" for us, following the example of the Virgin Mary who said: *I am the handmaid of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word* (Lk 1:38).

10. b) The Two Natures of Christ: Human and Divine. We want to fervently practice the transcendent virtues of faith, hope and charity, in order to be *the salt*... and *the light* (Mt 5:13ff) and thus not to be of the world.[12] To do this, we must *pray without ceasing* (1 Thes 5:17), and we must go through the active and passive purification of the senses and of the spirit *for unless you repent you will all likewise perish* (Lk 13:3).

11. We want to fervently practice the virtues of self-denial: humility, justice, sacrifice, poverty, suffering, obedience, and merciful love…; more succinctly, we simply want to take up our cross.[13] We must be in the world[14] and, in Christ, assume all that is human, since "what is not assumed is not redeemed,"[15] but rather "becomes a new idol replete with all the old malicious cunning."[16] As priests, working as spiritual directors, we must enlighten the temporal order and form lay people so that they can "direct temporal matters according to the plan of God."[17] We must not take on "matter" that is not worthy to be assumed, such as sin, error, lies, evil: *abstain from every form of evil* (1 Thes 5:22).

---

[12] Cf. Jn 17:16.
[13] Cf. Mt 16:24.
[14] Cf. Jn 17:11.
[15] SAINT IRENAEUS, quoted in DP 400.
[16] DP 400, 469.
[17] LG 31.

12. c) The Union of the Natures. The center of our life must be **Jesus Christ**, true God and true man, who unites both natures in one, unique, divine Person. We profess that truly *the Word became flesh* (Jn 1:14), and He is the *one mediator between God and men* (1 Tm 2:5); He is the only one who has the words of eternal life.[18] Among the Persons of the Most Blessed Trinity, He is the Person who proceeds as the term of the Incarnation. In a particular way, our devotion to Jesus Christ must be made manifest in the imitation of: His emptying of Himself, namely, in the mystery of the Incarnation; His second emptying of Himself in the mystery of the Passion – the supreme priestly action – that, by way of contrast, makes us admire the *kenosis*[19] of the Incarnation even more deeply; The mystery of His Second Coming which constitutes the fullness of His First. Intimately united to *the mystery of our religion, [that] He was manifested in the flesh* (1 Tm 3:16), and therefore also united to our love, are the "three white things of the Church": the **Eucharist**, which perpetuates the Incarnation under the species of bread and wine by the action of the Catholic priesthood; the **Most Holy Virgin Mary**, who gave her yes so that from her flesh and blood the Word was made flesh;[20] the **Pope**, in whom the Truth, the Will, and the Sanctity of Christ become flesh.

13. We must embrace the practice of those virtues which are seemingly opposed, and we do so against all false dialectics; we must respect the essence of the virtues without confusing them. We must avoid all false duality by practicing truthfulness, fidelity, coherence and authenticity of life, against all falsehood, infidelity, pretense and hypocrisy; we must restore entirely all things in Christ, *for he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet* (1 Cor 15:25), and thus take possession of the entire universe for

[18] Cf. Jn 6:68.
[19] Cf. Phil 2:7.
[20] Cf. Jn 1:14.

Christ, by uniting *all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth* (Eph 1:10).

14. d) The Purpose of the Incarnation. In Christ we want to seek the glory of God and the overall well-being of man. By introducing His firstborn Son into the world,[21] the Father manifested His glory: *we have beheld his glory* (Jn 1:14); it follows that we want always to have the right intention: *whatever you do, do all to the glory of God* (1 Cor 10:31).

15. Since "every individual human being is the way for the Church,"[22] and since "it is only in the mystery of the Incarnate Word that the mystery of man truly becomes clear,"[23] we want to work for man's overall well-being by showing him his nature, dignity, vocation, inalienable rights, freedom, and eternal destiny and thus achieve the goal of faith, which is the salvation of souls.[24] We will earnestly focus our attention and apostolic activity on all things until we see *Christ being formed*[25] in all men.

16. [Apostolate] In a special way, we will be devoted to preaching the Word of God, *sharper than any two-edged sword* (Heb 4:12), in all its forms by: studying and teaching Sacred Scripture, theology, the Church Fathers, liturgy, catechesis, ecumenism, etc.; conducting outreach missions and preaching the Spiritual Exercises of Saint Ignatius of Loyola; focusing on the education and Christian formation of children and young people; preaching through works of charity especially in the service of the most needy (abandoned children, the handicapped, the sick, the elderly); searching for and forming suitable ministers of the Word through the publication of journals, treatises, books, etc. We want to spread the Word through verbal and written communication.

---

[21] Cf. Heb 1:6.
[22] DM 1; cf. RH 13.
[23] GS 22.
[24] Cf. 1 Pt 1:9.
[25] Cf. Gal 4:19.

17. [Marian Slavery] We want to manifest our love and gratitude to the Blessed Virgin by making a fourth vow of slavery to Mary according to the spirituality of Saint Louis-Marie Grignion de Montfort. This will secure her indispensable help in perpetuating the Incarnation in all things. We do not want our Religious Family to be guided by any spirit other than the Holy Spirit. If our Religious Family is led by another spirit at any time or in any place, we beg our Lord to eliminate it from the face of the Church.

18. [Fidelity to the Holy Spirit] Only with absolute fidelity to the Holy Spirit can we skillfully use the *sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God* (Eph 6:17). Our feeble breath is only fertile and irresistible when it communes with the Wind of Pentecost.

19. In order to achieve the best total and unrestricted docility to the Holy Spirit, the Spirit of Christ,[26] we need the Holy Virgin Mary to be the form, mold, and guide of all our actions. In this way, we can say with our entire soul and heart, now and forever, "Totus tuus, Maria!"[27]

[26] Cf. Rom 8:9.

[27] SAINT BONAVENTURE, (inter opera) *Psalt Maius*, Canticum ad Instar illius, Is 12 (*Opera Omnia* – Vives, Paris 1868) Vol. 14, 221 a.b.; SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNON DE MONFORT, *TD* 216; Episcopal motto of Blessed John Paul II.

PART 2

NATURE AND PURPOSE OF THE INSTITUTE

ARTICLE 1: NATURE

20. In the name of Christ, we desire to be a Religious Family: whose members are willing to radically live the demands of the Incarnation, the Cross, the Sermon on the Mount, and the Last Supper; wherein the humiliations of Nazareth and Calvary can be imitated; wherein one can enter the secrets of Tabor and Gethsemane; wherein it is possible to experience the Father's paternity, the brotherhood of the Son, and the indwelling of the Holy Spirit, so that we can love each other as sons of the same Father, brothers of the same Son, and temples of the same Holy Spirit, forming *one heart and soul* (Acts 4:32).

21. We desire to consecrate ourselves to God by the public profession of the evangelical counsels, forming a religious institute. We will live a fraternal life in common, separated from the world in a way befitting religious, so that all our members may tend to perfection in accord with their consecrated state.[28] Harmoniously integrated into our Religious Family, we also include religious who may not be priests, and associations of the faithful who want to live in a genuine spirit of family according to their lay vocation.[29]

22. Imitating "Christ proclaiming the Kingdom of God,"[30] we want to dedicate ourselves to apostolic work under the direction of clerics, thus assuming the exercise of Sacred Orders.[31] Some members of our Institute have an exclusively contemplative life, either monastic or eremitic. Likewise, it is possible that some members of the apostolic branch could live a more contemplative type of life for a predetermined time, since "a pause for true wor-

[28] Cf. CIC, c. 598, §2.
[29] Cf. CIC, c. 677.
[30] Cf. CIC, c. 577.
[31] Cf. CIC, c. 588, §2.

ship has a greater value and spiritual fruit than the most intense activity, were it apostolic activity itself."[32]

ARTICLE 2: COMMON, PROPER, AND SPECIFIC END

23. Like all institutes of consecrated life, religious as well as secular,[33] we have a **universal** and **common** end – often called *vocation* – by which we want to follow Christ more closely under the action of the Holy Spirit. We want to dedicate ourselves totally to God as our supreme Love, so that, dedicated by a new and special title to his glory, for the edification of the Church and for the salvation of the world, we may achieve the perfection of charity. Through this charity, to which we are led by the profession of the evangelical counsels of poverty, chastity, and obedience, we want to be united in a special way to the Church and her mystery.[34]

24. Likewise, we tend to the **proper** end of all institutes of religious life, which is the total consecration of our person, manifesting the admirable betrothal established by God in the Church, the sign of heavenly life. In this way we will accomplish the full offering of ourselves as a sacrifice acceptable to God by which our entire existence becomes continuous worship to Him in charity.

25. This consecration is manifested by forming a Religious Family, professing vows publicly, and living a fraternal life in

[32] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Superiors Generals of Orders and Religious Congregations, n. 4, (09/24/1978). OR (12/3/1978) Spanish Edition.

[33] Cf. CIC, Norms Common to All Institutes of Consecrated Life, cc. 573-606.

[34] Cf. CIC, c. 573.

common.[35] The public testimony we must give includes detachment from the world.[36] To live according to the Holy Spirit, we must separate ourselves from the spirit of the world: … *the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees him nor knows him* (Jn 14:17).

26. Finally, as our **specific** and **singular** end, we want to dedicate ourselves to evangelization of the culture – to work, "through the power of the Gospel, to transform:

- mankind's criteria of judgment,
- determining values,
- points of interest,
- lines of thought,
- sources of inspiration,
- models of life."[37]

We want to do this so that the "very power of the Gospel should permeate:

- thought patterns,
- standards of judgment,
- and norms of behavior."[38]

We cannot forget what the Second Vatican Council pointed out: "One of the gravest errors of our time is the dichotomy between the faith which many profess, and the practice of their daily lives."[39] In large part, this is because the world "in recent times has come to the point of separating and detaching itself from the

[35] Cf. CIC, c. 607-709.
[36] Cf. CIC, c. 607.
[37] EN 19.
[38] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, *Sapientia Christiana*, 1. OR (6/3/1979), 7, Spanish Edition.
[39] GS 43.

Christian foundations of its culture,"[40] leading to the de-Christianization of the culture.

27. To permeate cultures with the Gospel, we regard the following elements as fundamental: the teachings of the Second Vatican Council's *Pastoral Constitution on the Church in the Modern World* (*Gaudium et Spes*),[41] the Apostolic Exhortations *Evangelii Nuntiandi*[42] and *Catechesi Tradendae*,[43] Blessed John Paul II's speech to UNESCO[44] and others on the same subject,[45] the Puebla Document,[46] the Encyclical Letter *Slavorum Apostoli*, the Encyclical letter *Redemptoris Missio*, the Post-Synodal Apostolic Exhortation *Pastores Dabo Vobis*, n. 55, c, and any forthcoming directives, orientations and teachings of the Magisterium of the Church that may be issued regarding the specific purpose of our small Religious Family.

28. We wish to form the most filial and fraternal bond with the Pontifical Council for Culture to achieve a more widespread and better accomplishment of the Institute's aim.

ARTICLE 3: CHARACTER

29. We believe that one of the most important ways to attain the Institute's purpose is through work focused on key areas of culture, namely: families, education (especially in seminaries, uni-

---

[40] ES 14.

[41] Second part, chapter 2,53-62.

[42] Cf. EN 20.

[43] Cf. CT 53.

[44] Discourse to the U.N.O. for Education, Science, and Culture, (June 2, 1980); OR (06/15/1980) Spanish Edition.

[45] Cf. Speech to the Bishops of Zaire in Kinshasa (May 3, 1980) 4-6; OR (5/11/1980) Spanish Edition; Discourse at the Episcopal Conference in Kenya, Nairobi (May 7, 1980), 6; OR (5/18/1980), Spanish Edition; Speech to the Bishops at the cathedral in Delhi, India (February 1, 1986), 5; OR (2/9/1986) Spanish Edition; Speech to the congregation at the celebration of the Word Chambacu, Cartagena, Colombia (July 6, 1986), 7-8; OR (7/20/1986) Spanish Edition.

[46] Cf. 385-443.

versities, and colleges), mass media, and thinkers or intellectuals. Regarding the latter, we will work in the calling, development, discernment, formation, consolidation, accompaniment, and further exercise of a vocation to the intellectual apostolate.

ARTICLE 4: CHARISM

30. The specific charism of our Institute requires all its members to work in supreme docility to the Holy Spirit and according to the example of the Virgin Mary, so that Jesus Christ will be the Lord of all that is truly human, even in the most difficult situations and under the most adverse conditions.

31. This charism is the grace to know how to work concretely so as to extend the presence of Christ in families, education, the mass media, the scholarly, and in all other legitimate manifestations of human life. It is the gift of making each person "like a new Incarnation of the Word,"[47] thus fulfilling our essential call to be missionaries and Marian.

ARTICLE 5: MISSION

32. The mission, received from the founder and submitted to the Church for approval, is to bring to fullness the effects of the Incarnation of the Word, "the epitome and root of all good";[48] this is to be done especially in the vast world of culture, i.e., the "manifestation of man as an individual, as a community, as a people, as a nation."[49]

---

[47] BLESSED ELIZABETH OF THE TRINITY, *Elevation* 33.

[48] SAINT JOHN CHRYSOSTOM, *Homilies on St. Matthew*, 2,3.

[49] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Men of the Culture on the Occasion of the Jubilee of Redemption, December 12, 1983. OR (12/25/1983) Spanish Edition.

ARTICLE 6: SPIRIT

33. The spirit which has animated our Institute from its beginning, and which must determine its own identity within the Church, is the spirit of faith and love. All members must live the mystery of the Incarnate Word and its relationship with every creature in this spirit: "The Word is expressive not only of the Father, but of all creatures... (and as regards to creatures) He is both expressive and operative."[50]

34. This spirit is to live and to make others live under the action of the Holy Spirit, without coercion of any kind; this must be done by scrupulously respecting each individual's conscience, promoting healthy pluralism, bringing others to fully live the freedom of God's children,[51] because *where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom* (2 Cor 3:17). At the same time, we must operate while never forgetting *that the kingdom of God is… righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit* (Rom 14:17).

35. There is no point in extending ourselves to many countries or having numerous members if we lose our spirit. Infallibility and indefectibility are only promised to the Catholic Church, in the person of Peter and his successors. We will not lose our spirit as long as we are faithful to the Church and observe the will and intentions of the founder in everything related to the patrimony of the Institute.[52]

[50] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST I*, 34, 3.
[51] Cf. Rom 8:21.
[52] Cf. CIC, c 578.

PART 3

SPIRITUALITY

36. [Introduction] We seek to be anchored in the sacrosanct mystery of the Incarnation – the mystery of the Word made flesh in the womb of the Blessed Virgin Mary. We can say that our spirituality is derived from the Person of the Word and His Mother, so that, in the Holy Spirit, we may become united to the Father. All the principles of our Institute's spiritual life, as stated in the Directory of Spirituality, stem from the elucidation of the mystery of the Incarnate Word.

37. [The Primacy of Jesus Christ] "[T]he name, the teaching, the life, the promises, the kingdom and the mystery of Jesus of Nazareth, the Son of God"[53] must take priority in our lives and actions, so that we do not put anything before His love.

38. [Pre-existence of the Person of the Word] In confessing the eternity, distinction and divinity of the Second Person of the Holy Trinity, we wish to nurture our desire to abandon ourselves completely to God's "will of good pleasure," to our love for the Trinity, and to the people created by God in His image and likeness.[54]

39. [The Mystery of the Incarnate Word]

His **First Coming**, accomplished by the Holy Spirit in Mary's womb, must lead us to a total docility to the same Spirit and to a deep love for Mary, Jesus' mother and ours. Based on the mystery of the Incarnation, the work of the Spirit in the Virgin Mary, we should always sing the mercies of God[55] since "the immortality of blessedness becomes credible from the Incarnation of the Son of God."[56] We must understand clearly that without Jesus Christ we

[53] EN 22.
[54] Cf. Gen 1:26.
[55] Cf. Ps 89:1.
[56] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Holy Trinity*, 13,9.

can do nothing,[57] and that we must always tend to grow in virtue with all our strength.

40. Jesus is the "Way" to the Father, and nobody goes to the Father except through Him.[58] He has the only name *by which we are to be saved* (Acts 4:12). He is the One who makes the Church a "sacrament, that is, a sign and instrument of communion with God and of unity among all men."[59] He is the One who sustains all Church dogmas since He is "the truth that contains all others."[60] He is the One who shows us the primacy and weight of eternity over all temporal reality. To know that Jesus is true God must move us to practice the transcendental virtues: faith, hope and charity. It must move us to give an irreplaceable importance to a life of prayer, and to the need for active and passive purifications of the senses and the spirit. Becoming man is "the first and fundamental mystery of Jesus,"[61] and "God had never been so close to man – and man had never been so close to God – as in that precise moment: in the instant of the mystery of the Incarnation!"[62] To know that Jesus is true man must make us realize that nothing authentically human is foreign to us provided we know how to assume it;[63] it must make us love, in Him, every human being in his or her totality, and to practice the mortifying virtues of self-denial. To know that both natures become indissoluble in Him must move us to recognize the double reality of grace and nature, without creating an erroneous fusion; we must be moved to practice seemingly opposing virtues, without falling into false

[57] Cf. Jn 15:5.

[58] Cf. Jn 14:6.

[59] LG 1.

[60] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Speech to professors and students at Antonianum Pontifical Athenaeum in Rome (January 16, 1982), 5; OR (1/31/1982) Spanish Edition.

[61] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Angelus Message (September 6, 1981), 1; OR (9/13/1981) Spanish Edition.

[62] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Angelus Message (August 2, 1981), 2; OR (8/9/1981) Spanish Edition.

[63] "What has not been taken has not been redeemed"; cf. AG 3, footnote 15.

dualisms. Thus, the superior must assume the inferior, always seeking God's greater glory and the salvation of humankind, which is the goal of the Incarnation.

41. His Earthly Life. From the instant of the Incarnation, He gives us an example of a priestly surrender to the Father which we must imitate. In Mary's womb, we are already present through the principle of *koinonia*, which teaches us to depend completely on His mother. In His hidden life, He teaches us to grow, to work, to be silent, to be *subjected*[64] and to live with *festive* joy.[65] All of His words and actions nurture our spirituality.

42. His Departure from This World. In a special way, our Lord's Paschal mystery is an inexhaustible source of spirituality. His Passion, Death, descent into hell and Resurrection must always illuminate our lives. We must be experts in the wisdom of the cross, in the love of the cross, and in the joy of the cross.

43. His Glorious Life. The splendid fact that Christ rose from the dead should lead us to live as a resurrected people, to live the freedom of God's children, the characteristic of a New Man, in accordance with the New Law – the Holy Spirit. We should do so with immense joy, especially on Sunday, by knowing how to celebrate and by carefully dedicating ourselves to our mission.

44. His Mystical Life. It is the wonder of the Church, Christ's Body, nurtured by God's Word, One, Holy, Catholic (missionary and ecumenical) and Apostolic, enriched and founded on the "three white things."

45. His Second Coming. We are certain that the Lord is coming and that we are walking toward Him. One day He will

[64] Cf. Lk 2:51.
[65] Cf. Lk 2:42.

return in power and majesty; He will raise the dead and preside over the final judgment and the renewal of the universe.

46. All other parts of the Constitutions are inspired by the Directory of Spirituality and must be understood in light of it. We have sought to give absolute precedence to the section on spirituality because we understand that this is the requirement of our charism. As such, the Directory of Spirituality must be regarded as a doctrinal text that serves as the foundation for the constitutional articles, as a point of reference for possible modifications that the future might require, and for the application of the Constitutions to new circumstances.

47. We can synthesize our spirituality as follows:

Not Jesus or Mary; not Mary or Jesus.
Neither Jesus without Mary; nor Mary without Jesus.
Neither only Jesus, but also Mary; not only Mary, but also Jesus.
Always Jesus and Mary; always Mary and Jesus.
To Mary through Jesus: *Behold, your mother!* (Jn 19:27).
To Jesus through Mary: *Do whatever he tells you* (Jn 2:5).
First Jesus, the God man; then Mary, the Mother of God.
He, the Head; She, the Neck; we, the Body.

Everything through Jesus and through Mary;
with Jesus and with Mary;
in Jesus and in Mary;
for Jesus and for Mary.

In short, simply: Jesus and Mary; Mary and Jesus.

And through Christ, to the Father, in the Holy Spirit.

PART 4

CONSECRATED LIFE

ARTICLE 1: GENERAL PRINCIPLES

48. Religious life, through which we surrender ourselves totally to the service of God, the source of perfection, consists mainly of fulfilling three vows: chastity, poverty and obedience, spurred by charity.

49. The profession of vows has the following nature:

- First, it fulfills our baptismal grace most effectively. It removes the obstacles that may separate us from the fervor of charity and the perfection of divine worship, and consecrates us more intimately to the service of God.[66] Consecration by the three vows is rooted in baptismal consecration and is its most perfect expression. The person who consecrates his life to God in this way fulfills Baptism's call to perfection: *We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death* (Rom 6:4).

50. - Second, it resembles martyrdom since the religious possesses the same will as a martyr. Both accept their death to this world in order to unite themselves totally to Christ and partake of His kingdom: "Even when persecution is lacking, peace has its martyrdom; although we do not submit our flesh to iron, we destroy in the soul the passions of our flesh with the spiritual sword."[67]

51. - Third, the religious profession constitutes a true holocaust of oneself, since in light of the vows, the religious offers himself and his possessions wholly and without reserve to God. Through the vow of chastity, he offers the good of his body;

---

[66] Cf. LG 44.

[67] SAINT GREGORY THE GREAT, *Homilies on the Gospels*, 1,3.

through the vow of poverty, he offers the good of external things. Through the vow of obedience, he offers the good of his soul.[68]

52. - Finally, the religious profession is a true consecration through which the religious becomes something sacred, destined for divine worship; the religious becomes the property of God.

53. With the profession of vows, we strive to uproot the threefold concupiscence from within us; this concupiscence, which is incompatible with the Father's charity, includes: *the lust of the flesh* (disorder in eating, drinking, and goods of the senses); *the lust of the eyes* (eagerness to see everything, to possess it all); *the pride of life* (disorder in honors, ostentation, boastfulness, self-sufficiency).[69] These correspond precisely to the temptations with which the devil tried to seduce our Lord: Gluttony: *If you are the Son of God, command these stones to become loaves of bread* (Mt 4:3). Vainglory: *If you are the Son of God, throw yourself down* (Mt 4:6). Pride: *All these I will give you, if you will fall down and worship me* (Mt 4:9). "The matter of all sins" is found in these three temptations "because the causes of temptations are the same as those of greed: the delight of the flesh, the hope for glory and the ambition for power."[70] This is the ruse the father of lies used with Adam and Eve when he tempted them to taste the forbidden fruit, as it *was good for food, and… it was a delight to the eyes, and… was to be desired to make one wise* (Gen 3:6).

54. For this reason, Christ provides three weapons against these snares, summarized in the three vows of the religious. Poverty corresponds to the command of giving alms,[71] which includes everything done out of love for one's neighbor, and the rejection of wealth and ambition. Chastity corresponds to fasting,[72] which

[68] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 186, 7.
[69] Cf. 1 Jn 2:16.
[70] SAINT AMBROSE, *Exposition of the Gospel of Saint Luke*, 4, 35.
[71] Cf. Mt 6:1-4.
[72] Cf. Mt 6:16-18.

includes everything that the religious does to restrain concupiscence. Obedience corresponds to prayer,[73] through which "man shows reverence to God… insofar as he subjects himself to Him, and by praying and confessing that he needs Him as the author of his goods."[74] Herein lies everything that the religious does to give proper worship to God; therefore, the vow of obedience, stemming from this worship of God, constitutes the essence of the religious life.

ARTICLE 2: THE VOW OF CHASTITY

55. By the vow of chastity and in imitation of Jesus Christ …*having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end* (Jn 13:1), we want to offer God a holocaust of our body and our natural affections, living "the obligation of perfect continence observed in celibacy."[75] This vow implies a preferential choice of an exclusive love for God since we have freely chosen to be like *eunuchs who have made themselves eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom of heaven* (Mt 19:12).

56. Virginity, which is primarily of the heart, flows from, and is oriented to, charity so as to fulfill the supreme commandment to its maximum perfection: *You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your mind* (Mt 22:37). Thus, the vow of chastity enables the religious to be completely free to tend to God, since he *is anxious about the affairs of the Lord, how to please the Lord* (1 Cor 7:32), offering his body *as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God* (Rom 12:1). The vow of chastity, fully lived, constitutes triumphant purity which tends with all its strength toward God. The religious joyfully sacrifices his carnal affections, surrendering himself to Jesus Christ and directing all

[73] Cf. Mt 6:5-13.
[74] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 83, 3.
[75] Cf. CIC, c. 599.

his love to Him. The fruit of this consecration is dominion over everything, together with a free will that is quick to please God alone.

57. This vow gives great spiritual fruitfulness to the religious, since it is God who makes fertile and vivifies the heart of the one who, through virginity, resembles the angels and the resurrected who *neither marry nor are given in marriage… being sons of the resurrection* (Lk 20:35-36).

58. "Only the love of God calls in a decisive way to religious chastity. Moreover, this love makes so uncompromising a demand for fraternal charity that the religious will live more profoundly with his contemporaries in the heart of Christ. Chastity witnesses to preferential love for the Lord and symbolizes in the most eminent and absolute way the mystery of the union of the Mystical Body with its Head, the union of the Bride with her eternal Bridegroom. Finally, it reaches, transforms and imbues man's being in its most hidden depths with a mysterious likeness to Christ."[76]

59. We should always desire a triumphantly victorious chastity. This victory can be attained in various degrees: *substantial*, eliminating grave sins; *perfect*, eliminating even minor sins; *triumphant*, the most perfect, which not only obtains the elimination of the most subtle of sins perceived by a delicate conscience, but also goes beyond the mere avoidance of sin. This can be done through *promptness* (eliminating every discussion or any cooperation with temptation, which leads to an immediate and radical victory) or in regards to *totality* (immolation of the heart and negation of the passion, even in indirect aspects – vain beauty, natural love, etc. – that are related to the senses and to sex but that are not strictly sinful by themselves). This superior path of refinement, promptness, and above all, of total self-denial in the sexual sphere is characteristic of the religious form of chastity in relation to the

[76] ET 13.

natural tendency (a tendency whose existence is acknowledged, but that is not given expression in a merely natural way). This surrender of the will can be classified in two ways: *negative*: painfully endured mortification, *positive*: joyful and desired sacrifice to obtain union with God, characterized, according to Saint Paul, by a spiritual and virginal matrimony.[77] This matrimony is proper to religious life. The heart is not suffocated but offered and made sacred. This attitude alone is worthy of the religious state. The loving surrender it implies must be joyful, in order to immerse oneself in the spiritual realm of divine love, which is the ultimate purpose of virginity.

ARTICLE 3: THE VOW OF POVERTY

60. Our Lord is the Way we must follow[78] and the example we must imitate:[79] *Though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that by his poverty you might become rich* (2 Cor 8:9). In His preaching, Christ teaches us: *Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven* (Mt 5:3), and He invites whoever wishes to attain perfection: *if you would be perfect, go, sell what you possess and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me* (Mt 19:21).

61. Evangelical poverty consists of the voluntary surrender of material riches and the external goods of this world with the aim to seek only God. In Saint Jerome's words, it means "to follow the naked Christ being ourselves naked."[80]

62. The perfection of evangelical poverty does not consist of the mere lack of riches or material goods (effective poverty), but in the detachment and voluntary renunciation of them (affective poverty): *Indeed I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of*

[77] Cf. 1 Cor 7.
[78] Cf. Jn 14:6.
[79] Cf. 1 Pt 2:21.
[80] SAINT JEROME, *Letter to Rusticus*, 125. ML 22,1085.

knowing Christ Jesus my Lord. For his sake I have suffered the loss of all things, and count them as refuse, in order that I may gain Christ (Phil 3:8).

63. The evangelical counsel of poverty implies a life poor both in act and in spirit, following the example of Christ. Such a life is eagerly restrained and detached from earthly riches, and as such, it implies dependency and a limitation on the use and disposal of goods, according to the Constitutions. Thanks to this renunciation of temporal goods, the vow of poverty[81] becomes endless worship of Divine Providence since the religious is certain that "bodily danger does not threaten those who with the intention of following Christ, abandon all their possessions and entrust themselves to Divine Providence."[82] The Father, full of goodness, who takes care of the birds and the flowers of the field,[83] will not abandon those who confidently surrender their lives to Him.

64. Practicing this vow is the utmost sign of humility: "In one who, like Christ, is poor willingly, poverty itself is a sign of maximum humility."[84]

65. Poverty assumed for the sake of Christ increases the freedom of the noble spirit which the religious must possess because of his consecration: "Poverty is good and contains within itself all the good things in the world. It is a great dominion – I mean that he who cares nothing for the good things of the world has dominion over them all."[85]

66. Therefore, the religious, in his desire to always live poverty, must not regard anything as his own, or attach his heart to anything; he must not dispose of anything himself without the Superior's permission. Thus, he will better imitate Jesus Christ

---

[81] Cf. CIC, c. 600.
[82] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 186, 3, ad 2.
[83] Cf. Mt 6:25-34.
[84] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 40, 3, ad 3.
[85] SAINT TERESA OF AVILA, *The Way of Perfection*, 2, 5.

who was "poor in his birth, even poorer in his life, and utterly poor on the Cross."[86]

67. Our Lord Jesus teaches: *Sell your possessions…provide yourselves with moneybags that do not grow old, with a treasure in the heavens that does not fail… for where your treasure is, there will be your heart also* (Lk 12:33-34). On one particular day, these words resounded in our heart, and we decided by the grace of the Holy Spirit to follow Christ, who Himself was poor on earth, through the vow of poverty. Religious poverty can be exercised with greater or lesser perfection. There are four main degrees:

1. To abstain from possessing something as one's own or from accomplishing an act of ownership without the Superior's permission. This is the obligatory matter of the vow. Its non-fulfillment, even in small matters, is always a sin that is either grave or venial, depending on the case.

2. To deprive oneself of the superfluous (and even of the appearance of riches and luxury), being content with simply what is necessary, and with the heart detached from it. Its non-fulfillment will not break the vow, but rather the virtue of poverty.

3. To prefer for one's own use, and to choose whenever possible, that of least value, that which is least pleasant or least comfortable. In actions, it means to gladly accept, and even to ask for, the lowest offices, the most difficult assignments, anything that makes us most like the poor. The perfection of poverty begins here.

4. To accept with joy, for the love of God, privations of necessary things for the sake of holy poverty. It means to boast as Saint Paul *through hunger and thirst, through frequent fasting, through cold and exposure* (2 Cor 11:27). It was said of Saint Francis of Assisi that

[86] SAINT BERNARD, *The Mystical Vine*, 2, 3.

"no one was as ambitious for gold as was he zealous for poverty."[87] This degree constitutes the perfection of poverty.

68. We can practice the fourth degree of poverty even more intensely and so gain total detachment not only from material goods (which is the proper object of the virtue of poverty), but also from everything that is not God Himself. This will result in the perfection of charity and a complete, consummated holiness. As Saint John of the Cross expressed, "To love is to labor to divest and deprive oneself for God of all that is not God."[88] The soul will not concern itself with:

- the esteem and good opinion of men,
- health and corporal strength,
- the charges and offices that will be given to or taken from him,
- the events of prosperity or adversity that may happen,
- dying young or old.

"Live as though only God and yourself were in this world, so that your heart is not controlled by anything human."[89] And: "Nothing, nothing until only the skin remains, and the rest for Christ"[90]; "…when with self love I did not want it, it was all given to me, not going after it… after I have come to nothing, I have found that I lack nothing."[91] Conclusively, we have to love everything that God wants us to love, without being slaves to our affections for creatures. This means to love without being chained, to possess without remaining imprisoned, to use without selfish pleasure, to keep absolute independence and to look for God's glory in everything and for everything.

---

[87] TOMÁS DE CELANO, *Vida de San Francisco*, Vida Segunda, Ed. BAC, Madrid 1975, 375. (Translation is ours).

[88] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Ascent of Mount Carmel*, 2, 5, 7.

[89] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Sayings of Light and Love*, 144.

[90] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Maxims and Spiritual Sentences*, 68, 4.

[91] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Mount of Perfection*, 74.

69. We take to heart the instruction given by Friar Francisco de los Ángeles to the twelve apostles of Mexico, when he warns them that they will go "to the vineyard not hired for pay, as some others, but as true sons of so great a Father, seeking not your own things, but those of Jesus Christ…who wished to be made the last and the least of men and who desired that you, his true children, will be the last as well, trampling underfoot the glory of the world, dejected through disgrace, possessing a very deep poverty, and being such that the world will scorn you and will judge your life as foolishness and your end as without honor. Thus, by being made foolish to the world you may convert that same world with the foolishness of your preaching. And do not be troubled, for you are not hired for a price but sent without promise of pay."[92]

70. Regarding personal goods, the following is established:[93]

- Those with temporal vows retain the capacity to possess patrimonial goods, but not to administer them. Therefore, before making the first profession, they must relinquish the administration of the same and freely dispose of their use and usufruct.

- Everything that a religious earns by his own work or by means of the Institute, as well as what he receives by way of pension, subsidy, or insurance, he acquires for the Institute.

- Before the perpetual profession, every religious of the Institute will make a last will and testament according to civil law.

- The religious of the Institute must aspire to live poverty to the maximum and absolute degree to more perfectly and more radically imitate Christ in His poverty. Therefore, every religious, immediately before or after perpetual profession, can voluntarily renounce his present and future goods. If possible, this total re-

[92] FRAY JERÓNIMO DE MENDIETA, *Historia Eclesiástica Indiana*, Mexico 1945, 3, 9.

[93] Cf. CIC, c. 668.

nunciation is made so as to be valid in civil law as well. The professed who has renounced all his goods loses his capacity to acquire and possess, and so his actions contrary to the vow of poverty are null. Whatever he acquires after the renunciation belongs to the Institute.

71. The Institute must provide its members with all necessary means according to the Constitutions, in order to reach the goal of their vocation.[94]

ARTICLE 4: THE VOW OF OBEDIENCE

72. Following the example of the Incarnate Word, members of the Institute surrender themselves totally to God and give up their will by their vow of obedience.

73. *He learned obedience through what he suffered* (Heb 5:8). "Sacred Scripture says, 'He learned obedience,' that is, how serious it is to obey, because He himself obeyed in the most difficult and serious things, until death on the cross.[95] He thus shows how difficult obedience is. Because those who are not expert in obedience and have not learned it in the most difficult things think that obedience is very easy. But for you to know what obedience is, it is necessary that you learn to obey in the most difficult things. Those who do not learn through obedience to be subject, will never know how to command well when they should command."[96] Therefore, let the subjects obey, and the one who commands will be good.

74. With the vow of obedience, the religious obligates himself to submit his will to his legitimate superiors, who act on behalf of God when they command according to the Constitu-

[94] Cf. CIC, c. 670.
[95] Cf. Phil 2:8.
[96] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on Hebrews*, 5, 8; 2, 259.

tions.[97] The religious pledges to obey his superiors in everything that relates to religious and apostolic life, imitating Jesus Christ, who *became obedient unto death, even death on a cross* (Phil 2:8). In this way, the religious becomes docile to the Holy Spirit, and his soul is constantly ready for whatever God determines: *We beseech you, brethren, to respect those who labor among you and are over you in the Lord and admonish you, and to esteem them very highly in love because of their work* (1 Thes 5: 12-13).

75. The religious must see in his superior someone who acts as Christ, as Scripture teaches us: *Obey your leaders and defer to them, for they keep watch over you and will have to give an account, that they may fulfill their task with joy and not with sorrow, for that would be of no advantage to you* (Heb 13:17). Such obedience is the essential element of religious life since the religious state is a learning and training process to reach perfection. This learning process requires submission to the direction of another. This vow offers the most excellent of all goods to God, namely, one's own will. It contains the other two vows that are made through obedience, and it properly refers to the acts that pertain more to the end of religious life, since nobody is a religious without this vow (even if one makes the other vows).[98]

76. Some, unfortunately, do not obey, because they are moved by their own spirit, the spirit of the flesh or the spirit of the world. "Many live in obedience more from necessity than from love. Such [people] become discontented and dejected at the slightest excuse; they will never attain peace of mind unless they subject themselves wholeheartedly to the love of God."[99] When one withdraws himself from obedience, one also is withdrawn from grace: "He who attempts to escape obeying withdraws himself from grace. Likewise, he who seeks private benefits for him-

[97] Cf. CIC, c. 601.
[98] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 186, 8.
[99] THOMAS A KEMPIS, *Imitation of Christ*, I, 9.

self loses those which are common to all. He who does not submit himself freely and willingly to his superior, shows that his flesh is not yet perfectly obedient, but that it often rebels and murmurs against him. Learn quickly, then, to submit yourself to your superior if you wish to conquer your own flesh."[100] We must never forget that "obedience is the aroma of sacrifice… nevertheless, if your superiors were unable to perform their duties, if they were somehow defective, I say this in order for you to understand me: even if they were repulsive, you would acquire greater merit by obeying them, you would be more certain of obeying God. The defects of superiors make obedience infinitely more meritorious and pleasing to God. In order to obey, you must not take into account the superior's human qualities; you must not consider whether the order [given] is reasonable or not, but rather, you should consider that obedience is reasonable. If we obey only because of the reasonableness of what has been ordered, obedience itself will be destroyed. We, being worthless and useless, must deny ourselves at the feet of the Church and our superiors, and obey *for love of Christ* and be considered as a scouring pad … so that no one might surpass us in faithful obedience, obsequiousness, and love of the Holy Father and the Bishops, to whom the Holy Spirit has given the governance of the Church of God."[101] Saint John of the Cross teaches the same: "Always look upon the superior as though [looking] upon God, no matter who he happens to be, for he takes God's place. And note that the devil, humility's enemy, is a great and crafty meddler in this area. Much profit and gain come from considering the superior in this light, but serious loss and harm lie in not doing so. Watch, therefore, with singular care that you do not dwell on your superior's character, behavior, ability, or any other courses of action, for you will harm yourself so much so as to change your obedience from divine to human, as it will be motivated only by the visible traits of

[100] THOMAS A KEMPIS, *Imitation of Christ*, III, 13.
[101] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of the Epiphany of 1935*.

the superior and not by the invisible God whom you serve through him… If you fail to strive for indifference regarding the superiority of one over the other, with respect to your personal feelings, you will by no means be a spiritual person, nor will you keep your vows well."[102]

77. Saint John Bosco's words would become a reality if we were truly obedient religious: "If you will obey according to what is indicated, I can assure you in the name of the Lord that you will have a peaceful and happy life in the congregation. But, at the same time, I must advise you that from the day you put obedience aside, doing only your will, you will start feeling religious life as a burden. If in religious communities you find unhappiness, and even some people to whom community life is heavy, observe with attention, and you will see that this is caused by a lack of obedience."[103] We must engrave in our hearts Saint Francis de Sales' words: "In obedience all is secure; out of it, all is to be suspected."[104]

78. Religious obedience has three degrees:

- First degree: **obedience of execution** consists of carrying out an order even without inner submission.

- Second degree: **obedience of will** includes inner submission, that is, easily adapting our will to that of the superior with love and courage.

- Third degree: **obedience of judgment**, when we submit both our inner judgment and our intelligence to the superior, unless what he commands is clearly contrary to reason.

---

[102] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Precautions*, Second Precaution against the Devil.

[103] SAINT JOHN BOSCO, *Rules or Constitutions of the Society of Saint Francis de Sales*, 8.

[104] SAINT FRANCIS DE SALES, *Treaty of the Love of God*, 6, 13.

79. Religious obedience is totally opposed to both *judgmental obedience*, that is, obeying with murmuring and complaining, and *the spirit of antagonism*, namely, forming groups that oppose everything ordered by the superior. Religious obedience is also opposed to *subservience* and *pharisaic obedience*, that is, a cowardly and hypocritical obedience that shows a defeated will, but not a surrendered will, and that even tries to move the superior in its own direction.

80. In addition to our baptismal dependence and submission to the Roman Pontiff, by the vow of obedience we further obligate ourselves to obey Him as our Highest Superior, following Can. 590, §2: "The individual members are bound to obey the Supreme Pontiff as their highest Superior, by reason also of their sacred bond of obedience." Members are also subject to the authority of the Bishops. Members will follow the Bishops with pious subjection and respect in whatever relates to the care of souls, the public exercise of divine worship, and all other works of the apostolate. In the exercise of the external apostolate, religious are also subject to the authority of their own superiors and must remain faithful to the discipline of the Institute.[105]

81. To command *under obedience*, valid only when the legitimate superior does so in writing in the presence of two witnesses, will always be the exception. The superior commands *under obedience* when he uses a formula "by virtue of holy obedience," "under formal precept," or the like, or when the manner of commanding, or other circumstances, clearly manifests that such is his desire.

ARTICLE 5: CONSECRATION TO MARY

82. In addition to the vows of chastity, poverty and obedience, we make a fourth vow – consecration to Mary. This conse-

[105] Cf. CIC, c. 678.

cration is a total surrender to Mary so as to better serve Jesus Christ, and has two aspects:

A. FILIAL SLAVERY OF LOVE

83. This consecration to Mary is done as a "filial slavery of love" according to Saint Louis-Marie Grignion de Montfort's commendable method. He refers to such slavery as "willing" or "loving,"[106] because, as we are moved only by love, we freely and willingly offer ourselves and all our goods to Mary and to Jesus Christ through her. This offering is a fuller and more conscious renewal of the promises made in our baptism, when we were clothed in Christ,[107] and in our religious profession. Moreover, Mary's dominion and maternal providence over all things, especially over the souls of the faithful, becomes manifest through this loving slavery. According to Saint Bonaventure, "Any faithful soul, and even the universal Church, is a slave of Mary the Queen."[108] Blessed John Paul II says, "Surrender to Mary, in the spirit of St. Louis Grignion de Montfort, has seemed to me the best means of participating fruitfully and effectively in this reality, in order to draw from it and share with others its inexpressible riches… I think we are confronted here with the sort of paradox often to be noted in the Gospels, the words 'holy slavery' signifying that we could not more fully exploit our freedom… For freedom is measured by the love of which we are capable."[109]

84. By this slavery of love, we offer Christ through Mary not only our bodies, souls, and goods, but also our good works (past, present and future), together with their satisfactory and meritorious value. Thus, she may dispose of everything according to the

[106] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *TD*, 70-72.
[107] Cf. Gal 3:27.
[108] SAINT BONAVENTURE, *Speculum Beata Mariae Virginis*, 3, 5.
[109] Quoted by ANDRÉ FROSSARD, *Be Not Afraid!*, New York 1984.

will of her Son and for His greater glory.[110] We are certain that we must go to the Incarnate Word through Mary, His Mother, and that she will form "great saints."[111]

B. "MARIANIZING" LIFE

85. "Marianizing" life is the fruit and natural consequence of the consecration to the Blessed Virgin Mary. To "marianize" life, one must first do everything **through Mary**. The phrase "through Mary" indicates the way, that is, the fusion of intentions. The Mother of God keeps nothing for herself, but she teaches and tells us in all things, just as she did to the servants at Cana, *"Do whatever he tells you"* (Jn 2:5).

86. Second, we must do everything **with Mary**. She is our companion and model, the masterpiece of God, who must guide "all our intentions, actions and operations."[112] The Apostle Paul said, *"Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ"* (1 Cor 11:1); with greater reason we can say the same of the Virgin Mary – in whom the Almighty, whose name is Holy, has done great things.[113] "While in the most holy Virgin the Church has already reached that perfection whereby she is without spot or wrinkle, the followers of Christ… turn their eyes to Mary who shines forth to the whole community of the elect as the model of virtues."[114]

87. Third, one must act **in Mary**, in intimate union with her, which means that an abiding unity should exist between the consecrated soul and the Mother of God. He who loves abides in the beloved; this is ardent love, tending toward a mutual union, becoming more profound and more solid with each positive act. In this way one imitates the Incarnate Word who came into the

---

[110] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNON DE MONFORT, *TD* 121-125.
[111] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNON DE MONFORT, *TD* 47.
[112] SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Spiritual Exercises*, 46.
[113] Cf. Lk 1:49.
[114] LG 65.

world and dwelled in Mary's womb for nine months; and Jesus' last command and gift becomes effective: *'Behold your mother!' And from that hour that disciple took her to his own home* (Jn 19:27).

88. Finally, one must do everything **for Mary**. The Blessed Virgin, who always submitted to Christ according to the Father's eternal design, must be the end that guides all our actions, the object that attracts the heart of each consecrated person, and the motive at the beginning of each task. Mary is the "proximate end, our mysterious intermediary, and the easiest way of reaching Him."[115]

89. Therefore, every faithful slave of Jesus in Mary must invoke her, salute her, think of her, talk about her, honor her, glorify her, entrust himself to her, rejoice and suffer with her, work, pray and rest with her. In brief, one must seek to live always, through Jesus and Mary, with Jesus and Mary, in Jesus and Mary, and for Jesus and Mary.

[115] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNON DE MONFORT, *TD* 265.

PART 5

COMMUNITY LIFE

CHAPTER 1
THE COMMUNITIES

ARTICLE 1: IMPORTANCE

90. Truly community life is the greatest penance.[116] However, unlike mathematics, in which one-plus-one equals two, in community life, one-man-plus-one-man equals two thousand. One man along with another grows in courage and strength; his fear disappears, and he escapes from any trap.

91. The beauty and riches of fraternal life in common are much greater than the difficulties that it entails: *How good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!* (Ps 133:1).

92. Fraternal life truly shows that we are united in Christ: *You are all one in Christ Jesus* (Gal 3:28), as a distinct Religious Family. Fraternal life must exist so as to become a mutual help in fulfilling each member's personal vocation. Through fraternal communion,[117] rooted and based in charity, members need to be examples of universal reconciliation in Christ. They must be a "domestic church."[118]

ARTICLE 2: ESSENCE

93. In our communities we must try to live out the essence of the Kingdom that Jesus Christ came to inaugurate on earth: *The kingdom of God is… righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit*

---

[116] Cf. F. CERVÓS, *Vida del angélico joven San Juan Berchmans*, Madrid 1920, 150: "Mea máxima poenitentia vita communis." (Translation is ours).

[117] Cf. 1 Pt 1:22.

[118] LG 11.

(Rom 14:17). Our communities will be authentic to the degree that we live in justice, peace, and joy, which are identified with holiness. When holiness is non-existent, there is no law or superior that can prevent disintegration. As Saint Pius X said, "Where sanctity is lacking, there corruption will inevitably find its way."[119]

ARTICLE 3: JUSTICE

94. We want **justice** to shine in our communities, that justice which gives everyone his due: latria to God, veneration and obedience to superiors, respect to equals, service to inferiors, and to everyone, in its measure, charity. Justice is so beautiful that neither the morning nor the evening star can compare to it. Blessed John Paul II said that for St. Gregory VII, justice is "the order of God in the world, justice orders all human things, from the smallest to the greatest, according to the will and the law of God, so that man should not be deformed by sin, but molded into God's image."[120]

ARTICLE 4: JOY

95. Joy, the fruit of the Holy Spirit and the effect of **charity**, requires us to make use of any and all means so that "nobody may be disturbed or grieved in the house of God."[121] We must live fraternal charity: that is, *outdo one another in showing honor* (Rom 12:10); bear their weaknesses, both physical and spiritual, with unlimited patience; be eager to obey one another; seek not one's own good as much as one's neighbor's; practice true fraternal love; live always in the fear and love of God. Love your Abbot

[119] SAINT PIUS X, *Haerent Animo*, 5.

[120] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily at the Mass celebrated in Concordia Square (May 26, 1985), 1; OR (7/7/1985) Spanish Edition.

[121] SAINT BENEDICT, *Holy Rule*, 31.

(superior) with true and humble charity; do not let anything come before Christ who will take all of us together to Eternal life."[122]

96. Fraternal charity should be lived so that in observing our life, one could say, "Look how they love each other and are willing to die for each other,"[123] or, like it was said of the first Christians, "They love one another almost before they know one another."[124] Do not believe that charity is [merely] utopian, since we have heard expressions like these before. We should always be determined to preserve charity even though there might be *false friends*,[125] who interfere to *spy on our freedom in Jesus Christ* (Gal 2:14), who pretend to be with us but do not belong to us.[126] *Love is eternal!* (1 Cor 13:8). Each one of us should be able to write our biographies by replacing the word "love" with our own name in Saint Paul's hymn to the Corinthians. Therein, he describes fraternal love with two general characteristics and thirteen features, eight negative and five positive: *Love is patient and kind; love is not jealous or boastful; it is not arrogant or rude. Love does not insist on its own way; it is not irritable or resentful; it does not rejoice at wrong, but rejoices in the right. Love bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things* (1 Cor 13:4-7). "Formally love is the life of the soul, just as the soul is the life of the body."[127]

ARTICLE 5: PEACE

97. Peace is also a fruit of the Holy Spirit and an effect of charity. By charity we direct all our affections to God, and this order brings about peace. Dissipated souls do not let the Holy Spirit guide them, and therefore, they do not live in Christ's peace.

---

[122] SAINT BENEDICT, *Holy Rule*, 72, 1-12.
[123] TERTULIAN, *Apologeticum*, ML 1,534.
[124] MARCUS MINUTIUS FELIX, *Octavias*, ML 3,289.
[125] Cf. 2 Cor 11:26.
[126] Cf. 1 Jn 2:19.
[127] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 23, 2, ad 2.

This peace is one of the many benefits our Lord brought to the world and is an effect of His redeeming passion: [*The Father wanted*] *through him to reconcile all things for him, making peace by the blood of his cross, whether those on earth or those in heaven* (Col 1:19-20).

98. Man reaches this interior peace when he eliminates the battle within himself that sometimes arises because of the struggle between the flesh and the spirit,[128] or because of a conflict in his will between two opposing loves.

99. Peace can be false. This occurs when it is shrouded within an apparent good, or when it is achieved at any cost by doing one's own will. True peace will be perfect only in the Heavenly Homeland; on this earth it is imperfect, but we can always preserve it, even amid the greatest contradictions, tribulations, and tragedies, as the Apostle Paul admonishes: *Have no anxiety… And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will keep your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus* (Phil 4:6-7). We achieve this peace by making love the weight of our souls; by it our heart is carried to what it loves: "My weight is my love."[129] If that love is placed in Christ, peace will be found there, since He is the foundation of all: *For through Him all things were created… and in Him all things hold together* (Col 1:16-17). Peace should be sought internally, not externally. It should not be sought by filling our hearts with useless worries and resentments against everything around us, because our soul's peace does not depend on the removal of external obstacles, but rather on the elimination of the affection for sin: *What causes wars, and what causes fighting among you? Is it not your passions that are at war in your members?* (Jas 4:1). Peace should be sought internally because God is inside us: "You were more inward to me than the most inward part of me."[130]

---

[128] Cf. Mt 26:41.
[129] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Confessions*, 13, 9, 10.
[130] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Confessions*, 13, 6, 11.

ARTICLE 6: CHAPTER OF FAULTS[131]

100. *Confess your sins to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed* (Jas 5:16). The Chapter of Faults is a great help in this regard, and is generally held every week. The purpose of this exercise is to humiliate the spirit and to mortify the flesh which once more realizes its own weaknesses.

101. Members should accuse themselves only of exterior faults they have committed before others, and never of purely interior faults. The accusation must be simple, brief, sincere, and without omissions, humble and without justifications, and charitable and without accusing anyone or revealing another's defects.

102. Despite the fact that his faults may be humiliating, others should think more highly of, and have a greater esteem for, the member accusing himself. For though they have to judge the member as guilty, now, thanks to his confession, they realize that he is humble and loves humiliation, and by that humiliation, he has already erased his fault.

103. Outside the Chapter of Faults, we must never speak of what occurred in it.

ARTICLE 7: FRATERNAL CORRECTION

104. Fraternal correction holds an important place in building up our communities according to the example of the only Church of Christ. One of the spiritual works of mercy is to correct those in error. It is a warning, by words or gestures, to the guilty neighbor, especially in the case of ignorance or negligence. It is made privately and solely out of charity, from brother to brother, in order to remove him from sin, either by taking him out of it or by

[131] Cf. RDW, 254,256-258, 261, 263.

preventing it from being committed. It is neither the correction of the superior as a judge (judicial correction), nor of the superior as a father (paternal correction). "Brothers, ministers and servants, as well as all the rest, always avoid getting angry or irritated by the sin or the defect of others, for the devil takes advantage of one person's guilt to mislead many. Instead, as best as you can, spiritually assist those who have committed sin, because the healthy do not need a doctor, but the sick do."[132]

105. The duty is grave. Not only should we help our neighbor in his material needs but also in his spiritual needs, according to God's command: *If your brother sins against you, go to him and show him his fault, between you and him alone. If he listens to you, you have gained your brother* (Mt 18:15). This duty refers to mortal sins already committed, and to venial sins which, due to their frequency or consequences, may lead to mortal sins. Material sins, committed in invincible ignorance, should be corrected if they are the cause of scandal, if there is a danger of falling into bad habits, or if they affect the common good. Correction should be carried out by anyone, whether superior or subject, with charity and righteous, rational judgment, even though he himself is a sinner. It is normally directed toward equals or the inferior, though sometimes toward the superior, but in doing so, their authority as superiors should not be disregarded.

106. In order to be appropriate and necessary, the correction must pertain to a true matter and must be presented clearly and spontaneously. It must be: necessary, seeing that our neighbor will not correct himself without it; effective, that is, not counterproductive or liable to fail; feasible, that is, that it could be carried out without serious discomfort or detriment for the party making the correction, unless he should do so out of the duties of his office or piety; opportune, taking into account the time, place and manner.

[132] SAINT FRANCIS OF ASSISI, *Writings*.

107. In manner, the correction should be:

- charitable: seeking the good of the one corrected with the utmost sweetness and gentleness: *If a man is overtaken in any trespass…you who are spiritual must restore him in a spirit of gentleness* (Gal 6:1);

- patient: though positive results may not be immediately obtained, you should persevere until it is God's time, as the drop of water which, slowly and with perseverance, erodes the stone;

- humble: consider the way Christ would do it, without presumption or boastfulness. It must show respect if directed at a superior;[133]

- prudent: choose the moment and the occasion, deferring it if the offender is disturbed or not alone. Correction should be entrusted to someone else if better suited, avoiding humiliation, if possible;

- discreet: do not correct every fault, nor do it all the time. We should not be antagonists of other people's lives, and we should avoid indiscreet jealousy;

- ordered: avoid publicizing, if possible, following the order of the Gospel.[134] First in private, then in front of one or two witnesses, and finally, tell it to the superior who will start paternal correction and will resort to judicial correction when there is no other solution. This order can and should be the reverse if its effectiveness is in doubt, or the sin affects the common good.

108. In summary, "Let us therefore implore forgiveness for all those transgressions which we have committed through any suggestion of the adversary. And these who have been the leaders of

[133] Cf. 1 Tim 5:1.
[134] Cf. Mt 18:15-17.

sedition and disagreement ought to have respect for the common hope. For those who live in fear and love would rather that they themselves, and not their neighbor, be involved in suffering. And they prefer to bear the blame themselves, rather than that the harmony which has been well and piously handed down to us should suffer… Who then among you is noble-minded? Who compassionate? Who full of love? Let him declare, 'If on my account sedition and disagreement and schisms have arisen, I will depart, I will go away wherever ye desire, and I will do whatever the majority commands; only let the flock of Christ live on terms of peace with the presbyters set over it…'"[135]

[135] SAINT CLEMENT OF ROME, *Letter to Corinthians*, 51, 1-2; 54, 1-2.

CHAPTER 2
THE SUPERIORS

ARTICLE 1: ONE GOVERNS MANY

109. The principle of community life and unity was discovered many centuries ago: "The multitude is governed better by one than by many."[136] This principle of unity is the superior in whom justice and mercy should shine. Saint Thomas teaches, "Justice without mercy is cruelty; mercy without justice is the mother of dissolution."[137]

ARTICLE 2: CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SUPERIOR

110. We believe that Saint Ignatius of Loyola gives the best description of a Superior General.[138] Analogously, this description is suitable for any other superior:

111. - He should be closely united with God in prayer and in all his actions because God blesses the other members through him. He should implore God for all graces on behalf of the community.

112. - He should set an example for others, and shine in the practice of virtues, especially charity and humility. He should have his passions under control so that they may not hinder him from seeing and considering everything clearly, and utilizing proper

[136] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST I*, 103, 3.
[137] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Super Evangelium S. Mattheum lectura*, n. 429.
[138] SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Constitutions of the Society of Jesus*, 8, 3.

judgment. In his conduct and words, he should never cease to edify the members of the Institute as well as others: "Woe to the superiors who destroy with their example what they preach with their words!"[139]

113. Also shining in him should be an unyielding rectitude of intention, seeking only to please God, together with kindness and meekness, so that even those who are corrected or punished would realize that he is moved by charity. He should also possess generosity of spirit and fortitude to begin great works in the service of God, and to persevere until their completion. He should suffer the weaknesses of many, without faltering because of compliments or threats; he should rise above the vicissitudes of fortune and failure, and be willing to give up his life, if necessary, for the good of the Institute in the service of Jesus Christ.

114. He should be gifted with great understanding and judgment both in speculative and practical matters. Above all, he must possess prudence and discernment of spirits in order to realize and meet all spiritual and material needs. He should also be capable of giving advice and remedying situations.

115. He should be vigilant and careful to begin works, and responsible to continue and finish them, without negligently leaving them half-finished.

116. He should be healthy and mature enough to carry out the responsibilities required by this role for the Glory of God, as well as possess the necessary experience. He should be neither too old nor too young, because the former lacks strength and the latter experience.

117. He should have those external qualities that would facilitate and help him in edifying his neighbor and serving God in his

[139] SAINT JOSEPH OF CALASANZ, *Life*, 31, sentence 46.

position, especially credibility and a good reputation before the members of the Institute as well as others outside it.

118. For all these reasons, the superiors who are elected should be the most virtuous and meritorious in our Religious Family. If the superior should lack any of the above characteristics, he must not lack true kindness and love for the Institute, nor sufficient prudence and knowledge. All the rest can be compensated for with the help of God.

ARTICLE 3: SPIRITUAL FATHERHOOD

119. Above all, the priest should be a father, because he fathers children through the cross, by prayer, apostolic zeal and preaching. Christ was the first in this ministry. That is why He is called the *everlasting Father* (Is 9:6). The other priests are fathers by participation in His fatherhood; they are fathers "through Him, with Him and in Him."

120. To accomplish this, the priest must:

- Have a vivid consciousness of the Divine Fatherhood and His majesty, to whom everything belongs;

- Not usurp the glory of God: the bonds of spiritual fatherhood are stronger than the bonds of the flesh, but they must not snatch from God what belongs to Him: "Let God's glory be for God."

- Ask for the spirit of fatherhood, having the Spirit of His Son and pure love toward God: "Ask Him for the spirit of fatherhood toward His children whom we father."

- In this way, the priest becomes a visible image of God the Father, whom we cannot see: *No one has ever seen God* (Jn 1:18).

121. However, this "sweet thing of fathering children" necessarily implies the cross: "The children we are to father by the word should not be children of voice as much as children of tears… those who become fathers should learn to weep." The true father must die to himself in everything so that his child may live. "Will he not consider remaining silent when necessary, so as to help his children even when they complain about every small thing? Will he not be careful to avoid arousing envy by loving one more than another, or of seeming to love one more than the other? He takes care to feed his children even when it means he must take the morsel from his mouth, or has to leave the presence of angelic choirs to lower himself and give his child food. He must always be temperate to avoid making the child feel he loves him less. And even though sometimes the father's heart might be tormented with a thousand concerns, so that he needs, for his own tranquility, to give free rein to his sadness, and empty himself with tears, when his child comes, he still must play and laugh with him, as if the child was his sole focus. For, who can count all together the temptations, dryness, dangers, deceits, scruples, and other thousands of fantasies that come from everywhere? How the father needs to be vigilant so that his son will not follow them! How much wisdom he needs to bring the child back once he has fallen for these! Patience, so he does not get tired of hearing the same questions over and over again which he has heard and responded to a thousand times, and so that he can explain again what he has already said before! What constant and courageous praying he must do to God, begging that his child not die! For, if he dies, believe me, father, no pain can equal this; neither do I believe that God has allowed another sort of martyrdom in this world as painful as that of the true father whose son dies. Therefore, he who desires to be a father is greatly helped by having a gentle heart, a heart of flesh, so as to be compassionate toward his sons (which is a martyrdom in itself), and another heart of iron, in order to suffer the blows that their death will bring, so that the father will not stumble nor be driven to leave his office, nor faint, nor spend

days just crying."[140] Herein lies the ideal of the shepherd! From here also, "Those who escape this work of fatherhood, therefore, did not take any part in engendering spiritual children."[141] This is the antithesis of a true father, the negation of the priesthood, as paternity is its fullness.

[140] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Letter to Friar Luis de Granada*, op. cit., Vol V, 20-21.

[141] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Second Memorial to the council of Trent*, Vol. VI, 92.

CHAPTER 3
THE SUBJECTS

122. We must realize that the community is built day by day, moment by moment. It has always been subject to insidious treatment, i.e. the case of Brother Ruffino with Saint Francis of Assisi, for example![142] Today the same thing happens, and perhaps even more so. The community has tribulations and temptations: some in general to all the members and some in particular to the superiors or to the subjects.

ARTICLE 1: GENERAL DIFFICULTIES

123. General temptations or "states" of temptations are, for example: when the community, or most of its members, fail in faith to recognize the singular gift of their calling and its corresponding response; when there are no enthusiastic projects for the future; when the community is not presently involved in passion-filled tasks; when there is no gratitude for past gifts; when generosity in service decreases and the community falls into disordered comforts; when one breathes a climate of gossip, of suspicion, of criticism, of disordered passions, of tension; in a word, when there is no life of faith, hope and charity; when members do not look for unity in truth and in charity; when, by looking at the tree of difficulties, they lose sight of the forest of good things; when one makes a tempest in a teapot to draw attention to oneself; when there is no dialogue and solidarity.

[142] BROTHER UGOLINO, *Little Flowers of Saint Francis of Assisi*, 1, 29.

ARTICLE 2: PARTICULAR DIFFICULTIES

124. Tribulations come to the religious under authority when he closes in on himself, selfishly looks only for things of his own concern, and falls into one of the four roots of self-love: his own judgment, self-will, self-honor and self-pleasure. Such a subject does a bad thing and then hides his guilt; he looks at the speck in his brother's eye and pays no attention to the log in his own eye.[143]

125. Tribulations also occur when a subject believes himself to be very important and that whatever he suffers is a big thing. Saint Peter exhorts him: *Do not be surprised at the fiery ordeal which comes upon you to prove you, as though something strange were happening to you* (1 Pt 4: 12). "Do not be like those proud and conceited churchgoers, by imagining that your crosses are heavy, that they are proof of your fidelity and a mark of God's exceptional love for you. This temptation arising from spiritual pride is most deceptive, subtle and poisonous. You must understand that your pride and sensitiveness make you magnify splinters into planks, scratches into wounds, molehills into mountains, a passing word meaning nothing into an outrageous insult or a cruel slight….that keen satisfaction you feel on considering your troubles, that self-complacency of Lucifer which makes you imagine you are somebody and so on."[144]

126. When one succumbs to duplicity of spirit, even while unaware of it, he "incubates serpents' eggs and knits spiders' webs."[145] This graphic description illustrates the malice and powerlessness of a man devoted to himself who mischievously seeks "superiors" of his own liking instead of obeying his legitimate superior, in order to be judged according to a principle that does

[143] Cf. Mt 7:3-5.

[144] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *Circular Letter to the Friends of the Cross*, 48.

[145] Cf. Is 59:5.

not belong to the community. He destroys the spirit of communion when he upholds an inauthentic principle of unity, and thus begins to see everything upside-down: to have *the same regard* (Rom 12:16; Phil 2:2) is obsequiousness; discerning together is injustice; charity is weakness; exercising authority is self-worship; trusting in Divine Providence is imprudence; justice is hardness; obedience is slavery; if anyone becomes the father, it is because he is considered equal to or more than God; *eutrapelia* is slackening; virginity of heart is impossible; firmness is intolerance, and flexibility is compromise; saying the truth is lying; doing good is bad. Someone with a contrary spirit becomes sad when the community is happy, and happy when the community is sad. He succumbs to Isaiah's warning: *Woe to those who call evil good and good evil, who put darkness for light and light for darkness, who put bitter for sweet and sweet for bitter!* (Is 5:20).

127. Community life is destroyed when one exercises the "preference of persons," and the spirit of the vows is whisked away with disordered love, with the use of goods without permission and conscientious disobedience. "Preference of persons" is a type of injustice explicitly prohibited in Sacred Scripture: *You shall not be partial in judgment* (Dt 1:17) since *in God there is no partiality* (Eph 6:9).

128. More particularly, there are temptations against superiors: either looking to diminish their authority or credibility, or making it impossible for them to lead or be heard by the community. Zechariah prophesied: *Strike the shepherd, that the sheep should be scattered* (Zec 13:7). Jesus cites the same words before His Passion[146] as the cause of the flight and dispersion of the disciples.

129. How are the superiors "struck"? In many ways: impeding their speech; trying to make the subjects not understand the superiors, or to make them understand the opposite; putting obstacles

[146] Cf. Mt 26:31.

in the way of good pasture (conversion, perfection, etc.); attempting to go against his leadership – *he goes before them* (Jn 10:4). Then, frightened, he abandons the sheep and flees, making the subjects unknown to himself and himself a stranger to the subjects. This also happens by distracting the superior with petty things so he cannot do the important things, or by pressuring him so he cannot give his life for the sheep.

130. There are temptations that directly attack the sheep: when subjects do not listen with docility to their superiors; when they obey in word but not in deed; when they excuse themselves and accuse the superior; when they act like lobbyists, taking skillful, active steps to gain the will of their peers so as to attain personal objectives. They generally form groups or cliques to influence surreptitiously, covertly and slyly. At times they think there is no other way to get what they want.

131. Finally, it is clear that these abnormalities, and whatever others may be denounced, ultimately signify a lack of sanctity. When the soul truly loves, every difficulty is light and is an occasion to win merit for eternal life: *My yoke is easy and my burden is light* (Mt 11:30). On the contrary, when someone does not love, even the lightest things become unbearable.

CHAPTER 4
BUILDING THE COMMUNITY

132. The pillars upon which our religious communities must be built are identical to the goals of our members' formation (see Part 7).

ARTICLE 1: HUMAN VIRTUES

133. Above all, this formation must be founded on "human perfection which shines forth in the Incarnate Son of God and which is reflected with particular liveliness in his attitude toward others"[147]; so as to serve as a bridge, not an obstacle, for others to reach God; so as to know the human soul deeply; so as to have insight into difficulties and problems; so as to contribute to community life and dialogue; so as to obtain trust and collaboration; so as to express objective and serene judgments. In other words, we should try to form balanced, solid, and free personalities, capable of carrying the burden of responsibilities; we should form members who love truth and loyalty, respect others, have a sense of justice, keep their word, have true compassion, are coherent, and in particular, have well-balanced judgment and conduct.[148]

134. We should be able to relate to others not with arrogance or dispute, but rather with sincerity of words and heart, with prudence and discretion, with generosity and willingness to serve, with the ability to make a personal offering and to promote loyal and brotherly relationships with everyone, with a willingness to

[147] PDV 143.

[148] Cf. OT 11; PO 3; SACRED CONGREGATION FOR CATHOLIC EDUCATION, *Ratio Fundamentalis Institutionis Sacerdotalis*, June 1, 1970, 51, 356-357; PDV 43.

understand, forgive and console.[149] Since "no one can live without love,"[150] we should be people of great emotional maturity. We should have an education in sexuality that favors esteem and love for chastity, that knows how to include sincere friendship and profound brotherhood in human relationships, and that, above all, includes a great, personal, and vibrant love for Jesus Christ. When these characteristics are lacking, or when grave human faults exist with no effort to change, forming a community is impossible.

135. We should also know how to live in mature, responsible freedom with a delicate, but not scrupulous, moral conscience.

ARTICLE 2: LIFE OF PRAYER

136. The community is founded, above all, on an intense spiritual life:[151] daily Mass, adoration of the Blessed Sacrament, Liturgy of the Hours, weekly penitential liturgy,[152] weekly chapter, daily Rosary, the Angelus, the Way of the Cross, the wearing of the Scapular, etc.

137. Participation in the Holy Sacrifice of the Mass is the most important act of our day. It is the main act of worship, the sacrifice of praise that gives infinite glory to God. It is in the Mass that Christ, the High and Eternal Priest, perpetuates His redeeming sacrifice on altars all over the world, in such a way that the effects of His Passion reach all men of all times. The Holy Mass is the liturgical act par excellence, and "the liturgy is the summit toward which the activity of the Church is directed; at the same time, it is the font from which all her power flows."[153] From it "grace is

[149] Cf. 1 Tim 3:1-5; Tit 1:7-9.
[150] Cf. RH 10.
[151] Cf. CIC, c. 663.
[152] Cf. CIC, c. 630.
[153] SC 10.

poured forth upon us; and the sanctification of men in Christ and the glorification of God, to which all other activities of the Church are directed as toward their end, is achieved in the most efficacious way possible."[154] Therefore, con-celebration of the Holy Mass should be of the utmost importance to the members of the community.

138. "The Canticle of Praise that eternally resounds in the heavens, what Jesus Christ, High Priest, introduced into this world of exile, has been faithfully and constantly continued by the Church."[155] This Canticle of Praise is the Liturgy of the Hours, in which Christ "continues His priestly work through the agency of His Church, which is ceaselessly engaged in praising the Lord and interceding for the salvation of the whole world."[156] The Liturgy of the Hours, "source of piety and nourishment for personal prayer,"[157] must be celebrated with the conviction that "all who render this service… by offering these praises to God… are standing before God's throne in the name of the Church, their Mother."[158] In this prayer, the "necessary complement for the perfect act of divine worship which is the Eucharistic Sacrifice,"[159] it is necessary "that… we recognize our own voice in Christ and his own voice in us."[160] If possible, we should try to pray the Lauds (Morning Prayer) and Vespers (Evening Prayer) in common.

139. We should try to have exposition and adoration of the Blessed Sacrament for an hour each day, if possible, as well as Perpetual Adoration in each Province (through turns in each house). "Eucharistic Adoration is the holiest of actions. It is so

---

[154] SC 10.
[155] PAUL VI, *Laudis Canticum*, prologue.
[156] SC 83.
[157] SC 90.
[158] SC 85.
[159] PAUL VI, *Laudis Canticum*, prologue.
[160] PAUL VI, *Laudis Canticum*, 8; Cf. SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Expositions on the Book of Psalms*, 85, 1.

because it shares the life of Mary on earth, when she adored Him in her womb, in the manger, on the Cross or in the Divine Eucharist, and because it is the perfect exercise of all the virtues: faith, hope and love. Faith is complete and perfect when we adore Jesus Christ hidden, veiled, and as it were, annihilated in the Sacred Host. It is the exercise of hope because Jesus Christ created the beautiful heaven of the Eucharist so that we could wait patiently for the Heaven of Glory and so that he could lead us to it. And it is the exercise of love, since love is the whole law, and we fulfill the whole law when, according to the first commandment, we adore our Lord and God with our whole mind, heart, soul and being. In adoration one can practice perfect charity toward one's neighbor by praying for him and acting as mediator and victim for his salvation, obtaining for him the Savior's graces and mercies. Eucharistic Adoration is the most just act: we adore Jesus Christ for all who do not adore Him, for all who forget Him, abandon Him, scorn Him, and offend Him."[161]

140. Praying the Holy Rosary, preferably daily, we meditate on the work of the Redemption consummated by Jesus and to which His Mother is intimately linked. "The Holy Rosary is a sacrifice of praise to God for the great gift of our redemption and a holy reminder of the sufferings, death, and glory of Jesus Christ."[162] "It is an equally universal experience that those who have… great marks of predestination about them love and relish the Hail Mary, and delight in saying it. We always see that the more a man is for God, the more he likes that prayer.… I do not know how it is, nor why, but nevertheless I know well that it is true; nor do I have any better secret of knowing whether a person is for God, then to examine if he likes to say the Hail Mary and the Rosary."[163] The Rosary is a "compendium of the Gospel,"[164] an "evangelical pray-

[161] SAINT PETER JULIAN EYMARD, *Eucharistic Works*.
[162] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *The Secret of the Rosary, 68*.
[163] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNON DE MONFORT, *TD* 250-251.
[164] PIUS XII, *Philippinas Insulas*, 38.

er centered on the mystery of the redeeming Incarnation," and in it "the litany repetition of the 'Hail Mary…' becomes also a praise to Christ."[165]

141. Another practice of piety and veneration of the Blessed Virgin that should characterize us is the Angelus, wherein, "As we commemorate the Incarnation of the Son of God, we ask to be taken by His Passion and cross to the Glory of the resurrection"; in it, we find essential elements such as "the contemplation on the mystery of the Incarnation of the Word, of the greeting to the Virgin, and of recourse to her merciful intercession."[166] The prayer of the Angelus should help us "to renew the consciousness of the Mystery of the Incarnation of the Son of God."[167]

ARTICLE 3: INTELLECTUAL LIFE

142. Intellectual work is another means of encounter in the community; this can take place in the conscientious and intelligent preparation of the Sunday homily, in studying the cases of moral theology that may arise, in studying the ascetics and mystics, and in pastoral planning. We must know how to attain a spirit of recollection and silence, as well as the appropriate use of bibliographies: "Study was for the saints prayer and contemplation."[168] Why did some people, who apparently studied so much, make mistakes? Saint Augustine says, "This way, (the Word) by which they might descend to Him from themselves, they knew not; nor that through Him they might ascend unto Him. This way they knew not, and they think themselves exalted with the stars and

---

[165] PAUL VI, *Marialis Cultus*, 46.

[166] PAUL VI, *Marialis Cultus*, 41.

[167] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily at the Mass of the Presentation of the Encyclical Letter Laborem Exercens, September 13, 1981.

[168] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse in Italy to the Participants of the International Symposium Celebrated on the Occasion of the 350th Anniversary of the Publication of "Dialogues on the Two Great Systems of the World" of Galileo Galilei, September 5, 1983, 8.

shining, and lo! They fell upon the earth, and '*their senseless minds were darkened*' (Rom 1:21)… the Artificer of the creature, they seek not with devotion, and hence they find Him not… For even when we have a knowledge of these worldly matters, it is folly to make a profession of them; but confession to You is piety."[169]

143. We must encourage all ways of access to universal culture, provided they are not disordered; this especially includes access to the knowledge of those considered as the greatest teachers in literature, fine arts, classical and choral music, architecture, the modern visual arts, etc… In the same way, for those members who have the necessary willingness, we encourage knowledge of the different branches of human science: physics, mathematics, astronomy, natural science, medicine, law, social, political, historical, philosophical, philological sciences, and others.

ARTICLE 4: LIFE OF DISCIPLINE

144. Members of the Institute should live in their own religious house, living life in common, under the authority of the Superior.[170]

145. As everyone knows, community life demands discipline so that each member can contribute to the good of all. From every point of view, common schedules are necessary for all common activities. The equitable distribution of the "offices" or works of the house is also necessary. Everyone must develop the ministry given to him responsibly and conscientiously.

[169] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Confessions*, 5, 3, 5.
[170] Cf. CIC, c. 665.

A. DIALOGUE WITH THE SUPERIOR

146. All religious must turn to their superior frequently and with total confidence. They do this in order to let their superior know about their health, studies, apostolic work, and the difficulties they find in religious life and in the practice of fraternal charity, as well as anything that would contribute to the good of the individuals or the community. The superiors must consider this dialogue as one of their obligations and must always be available to receive and listen to their subjects.

B. RECREATION

147. The time dedicated to recreation, or *eutrapelia*, summer camps, vacations, sports, trips, etc., is worthy of special mention. Especially in small communities, no one should be excused from participation in recreation. Generally, if one does not want to participate cordially in recreation, and if after being corrected there is no change, charitably let him know that he does not have the spirit of our Institute, and dismiss him.

C. LEAVE OF ABSENCE

148. The Institute's members live in their own religious house and may not be absent without permission of the Superior or whoever acts in his place. According to Canon Law,[171] we hereby establish that in the case of a short absence, the local superior can grant permission. In the case of a prolonged absence (diuturnal), the Provincial Superior can give permission; requesting said permission from the superior general is not necessary. We establish that a prolonged absence is one that lasts more than a month. To grant permission for a prolonged absence, the superior needs more than just cause; he also needs the advice and consent of his

[171] Cf. CIC, c. 665.

council. As a general rule, the absence may not be prolonged beyond a year, except in these three anticipated cases:[172] illness, studies, or apostolate to be exercised in the name of the Institute.

149. When a religious needs to live permanently outside of the community to carry out certain demands of apostolic life entrusted to the Institute, he must have express permission from the Provincial Superior. The Provincial Superior will approve or deny the request after considering the importance of the mission to be performed and the individual's spiritual good. In every case, a schedule of visits to the closest community must be established, so as to more easily maintain the fraternal bond. This norm must be understood with regard to an apostolate exercised in the name of the Institute, and not to a personal apostolate freely chosen by the religious.

150. When a religious feels sick, he must communicate this to his superior and submit to the superior's command with complete detachment and Ignatian indifference.

151. Except for the aforementioned three cases of illness, apostolate, or studies, for an absence longer than a year, we should consider seeking an indult of exclaustration.[173] Illegitimate absence for more than a semester is grounds for cause to be dismissed from the Institute.[174]

D. USE OF MEDIA

152. We must be very discerning in the use of media. In general it disturbs an authentic life of prayer and study. Whatever we read, see, and hear should always be done with a critical spirit. The inappropriate use of TV, Internet, etc., is destructive to our

[172] Cf. CIC, c. 665.
[173] Cf. CIC, c. 686.
[174] Cf. CIC, c. 686, § 1.

communities because it fills the soul with things that are not God. Members are to rigorously avoid "whatever is harmful to their own vocation and dangerous to the chastity of a consecrated person."[175]

E. ENCLOSURE

153. An enclosure must be maintained in every house, so that one part of the house is for the exclusive use of the religious. This space should be appropriately adapted in each house according to its own rule. This also applies to the monasteries.[176]

F. HABIT

154. The religious of our Institute must wear the holy habit, which is a sign of their consecration and a witness to their poverty.[177] The value of the habit is given "not only because it contributes to the propriety of the priest in his external behavior or in the exercise of his ministry, but above all because it gives evidence within the ecclesiastical community of the public witness that each priest is to give of his own identity and special belonging to God."[178] Now more than ever, signs must be utilized, "especially in today's world, so sensitive to the language of images… where the sense of the sacred has been so terribly weakened; people need these elements that cry out to God, that cannot be disregarded without an impoverishment of our priestly service."[179] This sign "expresses for the religious his consecration and makes

[175] Cf. CIC, c. 666.
[176] Cf. CIC, c. 667.
[177] Cf. CIC, c. 669, § 1.
[178] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Letter to Card. Ugo Poletti, Vicar General to the Diocese of Rome, September 8, 1982.
[179] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Letter to Card. Ugo Poletti, Vicar General to the Diocese of Rome, September 8, 1982.

evident the eschatological end of religious life."[180] Therefore, let us love the habit, which should be like our very skin. Saint Francis of Assisi said that the simple presence of a religious dressed in the holy habit was a way of preaching.[181]

ARTICLE 5: PASTORAL LIFE

155. Pastoral life is oriented "to communicate the charity of Christ."[182] It must have a special emphasis, because when carried out in an orderly manner, it eminently fosters community life.

156. Pastoral work is a cross for us, not an escape. This is why we must never succumb to unproductive activism, as "the activity for the Lord must not let us forget Who is the Lord of the activity."[183]

157. In the weekly chapters, after the first point on Spirituality and the second on the faults, there must be a third point to organize, among other things, the pastoral work. Nobody should assume any commitment (Masses, preaching, etc.) without the explicit permission of the superior or his delegate, as he is the one who must coordinate these apostolic works.

158. We should know how to transition from a passive ministry to an active ministry, from a bureaucratic ministry to a ministry that will effectively reach everyone. Except for the enclosure, have the doors open so that the lay faithful may come to consult us. According to the area, the church doors especially should be kept open. However, if there is danger, prudently seek out some type of security measure. Unless there are truly grave and unsolvable

---

[180] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Letter to Card. Ugo Poletti, Vicar General to the Diocese of Rome, September 8, 1982.

[181] Cf. BROTHER UGOLINO, *Little Flowers of Saint Francis of Assisi.*

[182] PDV 157.

[183] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Allocution in Rome to the International Union of Superior Generals, May 22, 1986; OR 10/12/1986 Spanish Edition.

circumstances, the people of God ought to have easy access to Jesus present in the Tabernacle.

159. We should always be with the poor, above all giving them food. We should not be afraid of not having enough for ourselves. God is never outdone in generosity. The superior should take care of every aspect of tending to the poor. In some cases, this may mean not only assisting the urgent works of mercy, but also promoting long-term works of justice.

160. We have to take on the modern Areopagi that are open to the Church's activity without abandoning the traditional methods of apostolate. Healthy creativity is an essential element of the living Church tradition. We must not be afraid; Christ Himself invites us to "put out into the deep."[184] This principle always remains true, "for the same God is now that was then."[185]

[184] Cf. Lk 5:4.
[185] SAINT CATHERINE OF SIENA, *First Letter to Gregory XI.*

PART 6

APOSTOLATE

ARTICLE 1: SENDING

161. The risen Christ, King of the Universe, sends His apostles to all nations to continue His own redeeming mission which "is to enable people to share in the communion that exists between the Father and the Son."[186] *Go, therefore, and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you* (Mt 28:19-20).

162. This sending has two characteristics:

- A universal dimension: all men are called to be a part of the Kingdom of God, since *God wants all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth* (1 Tim 2:4).

- The certainty of divine help: *I am with you always, to the close of the age* (Mt 28:20); *they went forth and preached everywhere, while the Lord worked with them*… (Mk 16:20).

ARTICLE 2: PROCLAMATION OF THE KINGDOM

163. In virtue of this sending, the Church's mission is the proclamation of the Kingdom of God. "The kingdom of God is not a concept, a doctrine, or a program subject to free interpretation, but it is before all else a person with the face and name of Jesus of Nazareth, the image of the invisible God."[187] The Church carries out this mission to liberate men from sin and death: *When you were dead [in] transgressions… he brought you to life along with him, having forgiven us all our transgressions* (Col 2:13). The principal pro-

[186] RMs 23.
[187] RMs 18.

moter is the Holy Spirit, who acts in the Apostles and in the whole Church.[188]

164. That is why fidelity to the Holy Spirit permits us to overcome all the difficulties that the Church finds in her mission: prohibition against evangelization, obstacles from local cultures, lack of fervor, divisions among Christians, de-Christianization in countries of long-standing Christian tradition, a decrease in missionary vocations, a poor witness of the faithful, indifferent mentalities, and others.[189] It is the Holy Spirit who guides us to the complete truth.[190]

ARTICLE 3: WITNESSING

165. The Church's mission is carried out by every Christian, and in a particular way, by those who have consecrated themselves to God in apostolate. Their purpose is identical to the Church's purpose: to bring all men to conversion to God, to "a complete and sincere adherence to Christ and His Gospel through faith,"[191] which must result in the worthy reception of the Sacraments.

166. In this apostolic work where "we are missionaries above all because of what we are… even before we become missionaries in word or deed,"[192] our testimony of life – the "first and irreplaceable form of mission"[193] – occupies the first place so that the charity of Christ may shine among the faithful.[194]

---

[188] Cf. DoV 42.
[189] Cf. RMs 35.
[190] Cf. Jn 16:13.
[191] RMs 46.
[192] RMs 23.
[193] RMs 42.
[194] Cf. Eph 3:19.

167. Preaching is an essential element of this work of apostolate, i.e. "a clear proclamation that Jesus Christ offers salvation to all men,"[195] because, *how can they call on him in whom they have not believed? And how can they believe in him of whom they have not heard? And how can they hear without someone to preach? …Thus faith comes from what is heard, and what is heard comes through the word of Christ* (Rom 10:14-17).

168. In a particular way, there is an urgent necessity for apostolic endeavors in the so-called "modern Areopagi." In these new environments, we first find the world of communication, upon which the work of evangelizing modern culture greatly depends. This world of communication is "unifying humanity and turning it into what is known as a 'global village'… The means of social communication have become so important as to be for many the chief means of information and education... In particular, the younger generation is growing up in a world conditioned by the mass media."[196] Particularly "we must also mention the immense Areopagus of culture, scientific research, and international relations which promote dialogue and open up new possibilities,"[197] such as the commitment to peace, to development, to human rights, and the longing for interior life and prayer. "While on the one hand people seem to be pursuing material prosperity and to be sinking ever deeper into consumerism and materialism, on the other hand we are witnessing a desperate search for meaning, the need for an inner life, and a desire to learn new forms and methods of meditation and prayer… This phenomenon – the so-called 'religious revival' – is not without ambiguity, but it also represents an opportunity. The Church has an immense spiritual patrimony

[195] EN 27.
[196] RMs 37.
[197] RMs 37.

to offer humankind, a heritage in Christ, who called himself *the way, and the truth, and the life* (Jn 14:6)."[198]

ARTICLE 4: APOSTOLIC COMMITMENTS

169. The Institute of the Incarnate Word will take on the works of apostolate most conducive to the inculturization of the Gospel. For this reason, there are various Directories that complement the Constitutions. These Directories deal with apostolic action in the most urgent and important fields.

170. We list the preferred fields of apostolate here:

171. a) Spiritual dimension. The Institute will accomplish evangelization of the culture by sanctifying people individually. This will be done preferably by using the Spiritual Exercises according to the method and spirit of Saint Ignatius of Loyola, and by spiritual direction.

172. b) Intellectual dimension. The Institute gives priority to: priestly formation in seminaries; education on all levels; the formation of lay leaders by means of courses in Catholic culture; the media.

173. c) Pastoral dimension. Preference will be given to helping parishes through preaching (tridua, novenas, feasts of patron saints), and the administration of the Sacrament of Reconciliation. Another priority is the outreach mission in parishes and in rural areas according to the method and spirit of Saint Alphonsus Liguori, in all its forms: intensive mission; ongoing mission; missions preached to the youth and children, the sick, factory workers; open missions, etc. In response to Bishops' requests, the Institute can accept the direction of parishes, preferably in missionary areas or those in greater need. We will be attentive to respect, rescue,

[198] RMs 38.

and elevate the religious and ethnic traditions proper to each place, so that the Gospel will be better received and become more deeply rooted in peoples' hearts.

174. d) Charitable works. We must give privileged attention to the poor, sick, and all those in need: *the love of Christ impels us* (2 Cor 5:14), practicing concrete charity, witnessing first to the members of our Institute that "charity, and only charity, will save the world. Blessed are those who have the grace of being victims of charity!"[199] In order to evangelize the culture, charity is essential, for it is both the end of the one who works and the end of the work itself; otherwise, the "civilization of love"[200] will not be reached.

ARTICLE 5: SECOND AND THIRD ORDERS

175. In our apostolic work, special preference will be given to the spiritual care of the Servants of the Lord and the Virgin of Matará according to their needs. "Special care" will be given to the institutions, associations, movements and members of the lay Third Order, so that they might be formed in the spirit of our Religious Family.[201]

176. Any members of our Institute dedicated to spiritual apostolate should be convinced that the sanctification of the laity is of immense value to the Church's life. The works and examples of the great masters of Catholic pastoral ministry will be the foundation of their apostolate.

177. Unless they ask to be excluded, we regard all those who ever belonged to our Institute as members of the Brotherhood or

[199] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Christmas Greeting 1934*.

[200] PAUL VI, Homily during the Closing of the Holy Year, December 25, 1975; AAS 68 145; passim.

[201] Cf. CIC, c. 677.

Confraternity of the Incarnate Word, including those who try to harm us. Even if they do ask to be excluded, we are obligated to pray for them and to do good to them. The fact that they leave our Institute does not mean that they are no longer our beloved brothers.

ARTICLE 6: EDUCATIONAL APOSTOLATE

178. Any religious dedicated to education will try to immerse themselves in an absolute and total love for the truth. They will work such that the Gospel principles may effectively influence the lives of men. In a world that believes that error possesses the same rights as truth, they will combat errors with all their strength. They will give a privileged place to the Magisterium of the Church, to the doctrine of the Church Fathers and to the teachings of Saint Thomas Aquinas, a place that the Popes, the Second Vatican Council, and the Code of Canon Law give to them in theological disciplines. In philosophy they will teach the contribution of the ancient Greeks received into the Catholic tradition that has rightly been called the "philosophical heritage that is perennially valid."[202]

179. Those who are dedicated to theological, philosophical, scientific, and cultural research, or to research in other fields, should have a very clear understanding that, though seemingly distant, this intellectual work is not only for the greater glory of God, but also for the greater good of souls. They must understand that their work fully belongs to the charism of our Institute. Saint Thomas says, "We must consider that in any art the one who arranges the art and is called the architect is absolutely better than any manual laborer who carries out what is designed for him by another. So also in constructing buildings, the one who designs the building, although he does no work with his hands, is con-

[202] Cf. CIC, c. 251.

tracted for greater pay than the manual workers who hew the wood and cut the stones. But in a spiritual building there are manual workers, as it were, who particularly pursue the guidance of souls, e.g. by administering the sacraments or by doing certain other things. But the bishops are like the principal artisans who command and arrange how the mentioned workers ought to conduct their duties, which is why they are called "episcopi," i.e. superintendents. And likewise teachers of theology are like principal craftsmen who inquire and teach how others ought to procure the salvation of souls. Therefore, it is absolutely better to teach theology and more meritorious if it is done with good intention, than to devote particular care to the salvation of this one and that… Reason itself also demonstrates that it is better to teach salvation-related matters to those who can benefit from it both for themselves and others, than to [teach] simple people who can only benefit from it themselves."[203]

180. Keeping in mind the particular benefits of intellectual apostolate, we will give special attention to spreading the Gospel through articles in investigative journals, periodicals, essays, books, and other kinds of publications. What is written remains and is more widely disseminated.

ARTICLE 7: PASTORAL WORK IN PARISHES

181. The religious who take care of parishes should give priority, with enthusiastic pastoral action, to the following:

- The Sunday liturgy, with a conscientiously-prepared homily. The center of the parish pastoral work should always be the Sunday Mass, [and our members should] work especially to promote the solemnity of the celebration so that the faithful will participate

[203] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Quodlibetales I*, 7, 2.

knowingly, devoutly and actively.[204] This should be complemented by bringing communion to the sick.

- Availability to hear confessions at any time. We should be willing to offer authentic spiritual direction. We should know how to guide those who are predisposed to the practice of the Spiritual Exercises. We should assume the responsibility of teaching catechism to children and adults.

- We should create appropriate lay associations, so that all faithful lay Christians can work in an apostolate, with both diversity and unity, according to their own charisms and willingness. Children and youth should be looked after according to the spirit of Saint Philip Neri and Saint John Bosco. The "Oratory" is still relevant.

- The central moments for the parochial pastoral work will be: Holy Week, Feasts of Patron Saints, First Communions, Confirmations, outreach mission, and courses on Catholic culture.

ARTICLE 8: PREACHERS

182. Religious who are dedicated to the pastoral care of parishes located in the neediest of places, and to the preaching in outreach missions, will become a continuation of the redemptive work of Christ Himself through their actions. To better fulfill their mission, they must be convinced that the best way to develop an efficient apostolate is to live in intimate union with the Incarnate Word and to love souls to the point of sacrificing themselves with heroism and without reserve. We must have a special appreciation for the teaching of the great masters of sacred preaching, particularly in regard to how the preaching should be

[204] Cf. SC 11, 48; CD 30.

done.[205] "All those who announce the Word, are the voice of the Word."[206]

ARTICLE 9: SELECTION OF MINISTRIES

183. The Superior General can send any member of the Institute to anywhere there is a need. In the selection of ministries, we must take into account the wise provisions given by Saint Ignatius of Loyola.[207]

184. Workers are needed everywhere. Therefore, a selection process in sending missionaries becomes necessary. The place, objective, number of people sent and how to send them, those to be sent, the length of the assignment, and other circumstances will be taken into account. We must weigh the advantages and inconveniences, and seek only the greater glory of God and the common good; we must pray and ask others to pray, ask for advice from prudent persons and decide in God's presence according to a right conscience.

185. The one who is sent should have no preference about going to one place or another, since God is in all places. He will put his assignment totally and freely in the hands of his superior who takes the place of Christ our Lord. The superior will have to guide him in the way of greater service and praise of God. The religious must absolutely avoid influencing the superior's will regarding the

---

[205] SAINT GREGORY THE GREAT, *Pastoral Rule*, especially, part III; SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *Rule of the Missionary Priests of the Company of Mary* 50-65; SAINT ALPHONSUS LIGUORI, *Letter to a New Bishop and Abbreviated homilies*; SAINT ANTHONY M. CLARET, *Method of Evangelization in the Villages or Farms*, *Letter to the Missionary Teophilus*; SACRED CONGREGATION FOR THE BISHOPS, *Directory for the Bishops Imago Ecclesia*, 557a and 169; BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Speech to the participants of the National Italian Congress about "Missions for the people for the 80's", February 6, 1981; OR (3/8/1981) Spanish Edition.

[206] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Sermo 288*, 4: "Omni homo annuntiator Verbi, vox Verbi est."

[207] Cf. SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Constitutions of the Society of Jesus*, 7, 2.

provision of any assignment. In the Church there are no assignments that are places of punishment; therefore, neither are there any in our Institute. If anyone thinks the contrary, he does not know the Church or the Institute.

186. In addition, in order to always seek the greater glory of God and the universal good, the following rules must be considered when sending missionaries. We prefer to send missionaries:

a) Wherever there is a **greater need** for missionaries, either because of the lack of missionaries or because the faithful are in urgent need of them.

b) Where there will be more fruit for the Glory of God, by having more facilities, more willingness of the faithful to take advantage of the mission (which may be judged by an insistent request for missionaries), and where there are more compatible conditions and qualities in which to develop and preserve the anticipated spiritual fruits.

c) Wherever we owe a **debt of gratitude**, for example, wherever more vocations have come from, or where we have more benefactors; wherever, in fact, God has planted us, there we must flourish.

d) Since the more universal goodness is, the more divine it is, we must prefer those who, because of their authority, can spread goodness to many others; including government leaders, professionals, teachers, intellectuals, entrepreneurs, managers, artists, and many others. For example, evangelizing the Secretary of the Treasury who, once converted, will justly eradicate all slums, is preferable to trying to solve each individual problem. However, both aspects must be considered.

e) Wherever there is more evil sown against our Institute, including bad opinion or bad will; with their lives and doctrine, missionaries would change those misinformed prejudices.

f) Wherever there is something that concerns our Institute in a particular way, or wherever there is no one else to take care of that ministry, always giving preference to those ministries that would benefit the most and endure the longest.

g) Wherever there are responsibilities of great importance, and to these missions we should choose to send the people we trust the most. Likewise, strong and healthy people should be appointed to places where there is need of more pastoral work. Solid people who have been proven in virtue may be sent where there are more spiritual dangers.

187. Those who are outstanding in discretion and prudence should be appointed to govern, whereas those who have talent for preaching and hearing confessions should be appointed to work with the people.

188. Sending one member by himself to a mission is not advisable. At least two members should be sent, so that they can help each other in their spiritual and material matters. One of them should have more experience than the other, so as to be imitated and consulted for advice. Sending a cheerful and fervent member with another more prudent and tranquil member is most appropriate, so that the differences can balance and help each other. In a mission of greater importance, more missionaries must be sent.

189. h) When sending or transferring someone, we must keep in mind: the importance of the spiritual work, the obligation to go there, the ability of the Institute to provide what is needed in those places, as well as the fruits we expect to obtain, where the Institute is now working and where the missionary will be sent.

190. i) Motions or considerations against going to a particular mission can be presented to the Superior by any member of the Institute. However, the member must always submit himself to the Superior's will.

191. j) The Superior must give clear instructions regarding the office and place chosen for the member. Likewise, the member must appropriately submit information about anything needed, so that the Superior can provide the necessities of the mission to them. This should be done even when the member is well-instructed and experienced. Reporting on these matters in detail is a serious obligation, and should be done at least once a year by means of the "annual letter."

ARTICLE 10: REST

192. All members of the Institute will interrupt their apostolic work with periods of retreat and spiritual refreshment. No one can provide sanctification to other souls if he is not working to acquire the perfection he wants to transmit.

ARTICLE 11: KEYSTONES

193. All members of the Institute participate – each one in his own capacity – in the apostolic mission of the congregation, even when they perform works that do not strictly deal with souls. Likewise, sick and elderly religious participate fully by their sufferings in the apostolate exercised by the other members, because they are *completing what is lacking in the passion of the Lord.*[208]

194. The sick and the elderly, together with the members of the contemplative branch, the coadjutor brothers, and those who

[208] Cf. Col 1:24.

are dedicated to works of mercy, are the cornerstones of the apostolic endeavor of our Institute.

PART 7

FORMATION OF MEMBERS

CHAPTER 1
DIMENSIONS OF THE FORMATION

195. We want to form the members of our Institute in human and Christian maturity so that they reach *the extent of the full stature of Christ* (Eph 4:13).

With their works, members should demonstrate that they have God in their hearts because *every tree is known by its own fruit* (Lk 6:44), and *faith, if it has no works, is dead* (Jas 2:17).

We can organize this work into four sections: Human formation; Spiritual formation; Intellectual formation; Apostolic and pastoral formation. Nothing is better on this topic than the teachings of Blessed John Paul II,[209] which we embrace as our own.

ARTICLE 1: HUMAN FORMATION

196. Human formation is the basis of religious and priestly formation. Misunderstanding the relationship between nature and grace is the root of many evils. Grace does not destroy nature, but rather heals it, raises it, perfects it, dignifies it, and ennobles it. Nature is not only the foundation of grace, as though it were a mere external condition, but it belongs to the very essence of Christian identity and remains perfected. At the same time, grace transcends nature. Nature is subordinate to grace, as the obediential potency to its perfective act. Thus the natural has relative autonomy subordinate to the supernatural.

197. Because of the greater demands of his vocation, the priest should reflect – as should every Christian – the Incarnation of the

[209] PDV 42-59.

Word, in whom human perfection and divine perfection shine, in intimate union but without blending together. Moreover, the priest, *taken from among men and made their representative before God* (Heb 5:1), must serve as a bridge, and not as an obstacle to others; he should make his ministry acceptable and believable from a human standpoint.

198. He "should be able to know the depths of the human heart, to perceive difficulties and problems, to make meetings and dialogue easy, to create trust and cooperation, to express serene and objective judgments." Therefore, there is a need "for them to be balanced people, strong and free."[210]

- Balanced: we must be priests who remain focused on the whole and not on just a single part, who don't become overly-excited with what they consider the whole; they must not let themselves be overcome by a depressive attitude that sees more evil than good, and must instead make room in their soul for all things, without despising or minimizing anything, but with hierarchy and order.

- Strong: we must be priests who do not allow ourselves to be carried away by every wind of doctrine and novelty, priests who move ourselves and judge by principles, who are neither soft-hearted and sentimental, nor hard and aloof.

- Free: we must be priests who do everything out of love, who do good even when no one is obliges them, or because the Superior is watching, nor on account of commendations or rewards. We must not be obsequious with the superiors, or try to obtain advantages. As priests, we should know how to implement fraternal correction, without caring about what others think of us, and

[210] PDV 43.

understand with Saint Teresa of Jesus "the nothingness of the world and how it would soon come to an end."[211]

199. "They need to be educated to love the truth, to be loyal, to respect everyone, to have a sense of justice, to be true to their word, to be genuinely compassionate, to be men of integrity, and especially, to be balanced in judgment and behavior."[212] Education for the love of truth must be carried out via extensive intellectual formation, which is ordered to the truth and is unsatisfied with mere theological opinions. It must be a philosophical formation, as Saint Justin understood it. This formation will include theorizing, intellectual leisure, and sincere debate, which is a shared search for truth. Classes need to be moments in which true teaching and learning take place. "A simple and demanding program for this human formation can be found in the words of the apostle Paul to the Philippians: *Whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is gracious, if there is any excellence, if there is anything worthy of praise, think about these things* (Phil 4:8)."[213]

200. Along with intellectual formation, the will must be appropriately formed through constant practice of the virtues and control of passions, so that we are seeking and choosing only the greater good, always and everywhere. We want to form men who are authentically free and masters of themselves, who by that self-mastery are capable of giving themselves totally. We regard the practice of sports, camping, community vacations, etc., to be of great importance in this formation of the will.

---

[211] SAINT TERESA OF AVILA, *Book of her Life*, 3, 5.

[212] PDV 43.

[213] PDV 43; cf. CONGREGATION FOR INSTITUTES OF CONSECRATED LIFE AND SOCIETIES OF APOSTOLIC LIFE, *Directives on Formation in Religious Institutes*, 29.

ARTICLE 2: SPIRITUAL FORMATION

201. The supernatural end of man corresponds to the natural end, but at the same time, transcends it: man's desires are completely brought to rest in the beatific vision.[214] During the time of formation, we must keep in mind this correspondence and transcendence. Pius XI teaches, "The Christian education encompasses the entire human life… to elevate, regulate, and perfect it according to the example and doctrine of Christ."[215]

202. Spiritual life must be understood "as a relationship and communion with God."[216] "Spiritual training …should be imparted in such a way that students might learn to live in an intimate and unceasing union with the Father through His Son Jesus Christ in the Holy Spirit."[217] Therefore, spiritual life is a form of friendship: *I no longer call you slaves, because a slave does not know what his master is doing. I have called you friends, because I have told you everything I have heard from my Father* (Jn 15:15). This friendship has the characteristics of a true search:[218] the priest must have an unquenchable thirst for God. He must never oppose "the search for the truth and the certainty of already knowing the fountain of this truth."[219] This search is possible because in some way we have already found the truth; however, we must make our relationship even more intimate. There is a threefold path to this encounter:[220] meditation on the Word of God; participation in the Sacred Mysteries; fraternal charity, especially with those most in need.

203. - Faithful meditation on the Word of God is how we know the divine mysteries and make its values our own. This is

---

[214] Cf. CG, III, 63.
[215] PIUS XI, *Divini illius Magistri*, 102.
[216] PDV 45.
[217] OT 8.
[218] Cf. PDV 46.
[219] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Professors and Students of the Catholic Institute, June 1, 1980; OR (6/8/1980) Spanish Edition.
[220] Cf. OT 8; PDV 46ff.

particularly related to prophetic ministry.[221] We take to heart the teaching of the Second Vatican Council: "All clerics, particularly priests of Christ and others who, as deacons or catechists, are officially engaged in the ministry of the Word, should immerse themselves in the Scriptures by constant sacred reading and diligent study. For it must not happen that anyone becomes an empty preacher of the Word of God to others, not being a hearer of the Word in his own heart."[222] The response to *lectio divina* is prayer, "which is without any doubt of primary value and a demand of spiritual formation…" because "the priest is the man of God, the one who belongs to God and makes people think about God." Moreover, "one aspect of the priest's mission, and certainly by no means a secondary aspect, is to become a 'teacher of prayer'"; therefore, "the priest needs to be formed to have a deep intimacy with God."[223] The fruits of this intimacy with God and of the work of the Holy Spirit in the soul of the priest are discernment, relishing the presence of God, accepting His will, and rightly judging matters.[224]

204. - Active participation in the Sacred Mysteries, especially the Eucharist, which "is the source and summit of Christian prayer,"[225] must also be a part of the formation. An authentic liturgical education is necessary for this participation, which increasingly brings one to a "full, conscious and active"[226] participation in it. Above all, priests are the ministers of the Sacrifice of the Mass[227] because of their condition as ministers of the sacred things: his "role is utterly irreplaceable, because without the priest there can

[221] Cf. PDV 47.

[222] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Sermon 179*, 1; DV 25.

[223] PDV 47.

[224] Cf. CONGREGATION FOR INSTITUTES OF CONSECRATED LIFE AND SOCIETIES OF APOSTOLIC LIFE, *Directives on Formation in Religious Institutes*, 19.

[225] Cf. SC 48.

[226] SC 14.

[227] Cf. PO 13.

be no Eucharistic offering."[228] Therefore, seminarians must participate daily in the Eucharistic celebration. They must regard it as the most essential moment of the day, when they identify themselves with the sacrificed Christ himself.

205. Furthermore, they must discover the beauty and joy of the Sacrament of Penance, amid a world that has lost a sense of sin and divine mercy.[229] Additionally, and in order to practice "the 'radical self-giving' proper to the priest following the example of Christ the good shepherd… it is necessary to inculcate the meaning of the cross, which is at the heart of the paschal mystery."[230]

206. - We need formation in fraternal charity, especially toward those most in need. We have to teach those in formation to look for Christ in all men. "The priest is a man of charity and is called to educate others according to Christ's example and the new commandment of brotherly love (cf. Jn 15:12). But this requires that he allow himself to be constantly trained by the Spirit in the charity of Christ. In this sense preparation for the priesthood must necessarily involve a proper formation in charity, and particularly in the preferential love for the 'poor' in whom our faith discovers Jesus (Mt 25:40), and a merciful love for sinners."[231] This charity in the priest springs forth from prayer and from contemplating the mystery of divine mercy.

207. According to this view of charity, "which consists of the loving gift of oneself, the following should be found in the program of spiritual formation of the future priest: education in obedience, celibacy and poverty."[232] "Students should clearly understand that it is not intended for them to dominate people or to receive honors from them but to give themselves over totally to

[228] PDV 48.
[229] PDV 48.
[230] PDV 48.
[231] PDV 49.
[232] PDV 49.

the service of God and to pastoral ministry. With particular concern they should be so formed in priestly obedience, in a simple way of life and in the spirit of self-denial, that they are accustomed to willingly giving up even those things which are permitted but are not expedient, and to conform themselves to Christ crucified."[233]

208. Furthermore, living the proper charism of the Institute must be instilled in them.[234]

209. Jesus Christ, Son of God and of the Blessed Virgin, must be the center of our entire spiritual life. *No one comes to the Father but by me* (Jn 14:6). In the temple, the cloister, the cell, the dining room, and at recreation, we must always be crying out for Christ. The song and laughter of the members of our Religious Family must be like cries for Jesus Christ. This is our duty. The sweeter the melody we sing in the choir, the better will the profound and interior sigh of our souls crying out for Jesus Christ be made manifest. The memory and recollection of Him must never be separated from our hearts. It must come when we sleep and when we dream. Our heart is always falling in love, and our memory must never be occupied by anything but Him.[235]

210. Christ became flesh in order that we *might have life and have it more abundantly* (Jn 10:10). To have this life *in Jesus Christ*,[236] it is absolutely essential to be united with His Person, have His Spirit, assimilate His doctrine, frequent His sacraments, imitate His example, profoundly love His Mother, and be in perfect communion with the Church hierarchy by a double bond: by faith and charity themselves, and by the governance of one, Peter, over all.

---

[233] OT 9.

[234] Cf. CONGREGATION FOR INSTITUTES OF CONSECRATED LIFE AND SOCIETIES OF APOSTOLIC LIFE, *Directives on Formation in Religious Institutes*, 16.

[235] Cf. SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Talk to the nuns of Saint Claire of Montilla.*

[236] 1 Cor 15:21-22; Passim.

211. Our motto is "with Peter and under Peter."[237]

212. We want to form virtuous men (that is, "virtuous" in the sense of *vir* and *vis*: to have the strength of the man) according to the doctrine of the great teachers of spiritual life, especially Saint Augustine, Saint Thomas Aquinas, Saint John of the Cross, Saint Teresa of Jesus, Saint Ignatius of Loyola, Saint Louis-Marie Grignion de Montfort, Saint Thérèse of the Child Jesus, and according to the examples of all the saints of all times that the Church proposes as models of virtue for us to imitate.

213. In this way, following the Holy Father in belief and following the saints in practice, we will never err, since, just as the Holy Father cannot err in his teachings about faith and morals, nor did the saints err in their practice of the virtues.

214. We want to form priestly souls of priests who are not "tributaries,"[238] priests who will fully live the Christian and priestly kingship and lordship. Since they have Jesus Christ, may they feel this phrase resounding in their ears: "I am your Father because I am God, I am your firstborn brother because I am man. I am your payment and ransom. Why do you fear debts, if you with penance and confession beg to be absolved of them? I am your reconciliation. Why do you fear wrath? I am the bond of friendship. Why fear the anger of God? I am your defender. Why fear adversaries? I am your friend. Why are you afraid of lacking what I have, if you do not separate from me? My Body and my Blood are yours. Why do you fear hunger? My heart is yours. Why do you fear forgetfulness? My divinity is yours. Why do you fear miseries? And for further assistance, my angels are yours to defend you; my saints are yours to pray for you; my blessed Mother is yours to be your attentive and pious Mother; the earth is yours for

[237] "Cum Petro et sub Petro," AG 38.

[238] Cf. Nm 18:24; Gn 47:26; SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Sermons*, quoted from SAINT VINCENT FERRER, *Opusculum de fine mundi*.

you to serve Me on it, the heavens are yours because you will come to them; the devils and hell are yours, because you will humiliate them as slaves in prison; life is yours because with it, you win what lasts forever; good pleasures are yours because you offer them to Me; hardships are yours because for My love and your [own] profit, you suffer them; temptations are yours because they are the merits and cause of your eternal crown; death is yours because it will be your nearest transition to life. And all this you possess in Me and for Me, because I have gained this not for Me alone, neither do I want to enjoy this alone; because when I entered into fellowship with you in the flesh, I assumed it to make you partakers in what I would work on, fast, eat, sweat and weep, [participants] in My pains and in My deaths, if it was not given to you to do. You who have so much wealth are not poor, if you who lead a bad life, do not want to lose it knowingly."[239]

215. We religious must be convinced, as St. John of the Cross was, that "mine are the heavens and mine is the earth. Mine are the nations, the just are mine, and mine the sinners. The angels are mine, and the Mother of God, and all things are mine, and God himself is mine and for me, because Christ is mine and all for me."[240] Our religious must understand and live that vibrant expression of Saint Paul: *Everything belongs to you, Paul or Apollos or Cephas, or the world or life or death, or the present or the future: all belong to you, and you to Christ, and Christ to God* (1 Cor 3:21-23).

216. One aspect of spiritual formation should be to acquire discipline of life, a goal that means to grasp the "style" of our Lord Jesus Christ, that is, the attitudes that He has as the Son next to the Father. Discipline in our relationship with Him as disciples means understanding Him as our "path" to the Father. Discipline is the fundamental attitude of the disciple. It is a submission to the rules of life so that the truth may become flesh in the disci-

[239] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Letter 20*.
[240] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Sayings of Light and Love*, 26.

ple's life. For us, the truth is Christ, and being docile to discipline means letting Him be our Lord.

217. We want to be docile to the Church's great discipline, which is expressed in the Code of Canon Law and in all ecclesiastical rules and laws, and to be docile to the particular discipline of our Institute, remembering the teaching, *"Apprehendite disciplinam."* Thus it is written: *Embrace discipline, lest at any time the Lord be angry* (Ps 2:12),[241] as well by the Apostle: *Fathers, do not provoke your children to anger, but bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord* (Eph 6:4). In this way, the members of the Institute will become *useful to the master of the house* (2 Tim 2:21). "To educate them in discipline is nothing but to induce them to good."[242] In this way, the brothers "show their own style of life."[243]

218. The discipline of the Institute is contained: in a general way in its good customs and traditions, as well as in the collection of regulations of its proper law that orders the life of members and communities. These solidify the spirit of the Institute in everyday life, and in a particular way, it is the collection of practical norms contained in the Directories and Regulations.

ARTICLE 3: INTELLECTUAL FORMATION

219. The intellectual formation of future priests is an urgent issue facing the New Evangelization and the subject of modern challenges. This formation "is a fundamental demand of human intelligence by which one "participates in the light of God's mind" and seeks to acquire a wisdom, which in turn opens to and is directed toward knowing and adhering to God."[244] This for-

[241] In the Vulgate Version.
[242] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on the Letter to the Ephesians*, 6, 4.
[243] *Letter to Diognetus*, 5, 4.
[244] PDV 51.

mation includes two phases, one ordered to the other: the study of philosophy, and the study of the Sacred Science.

220. "A crucial stage of intellectual formation is the study of philosophy, which leads to a deeper understanding and interpretation of the person, and of the person's freedom and relationships with the world and with God."[245] This study is urgent, not only in view of later theological studies, but also in light of a particular cultural situation that exalts subjectivism as the criteria and measure of the truth.[246] A "certainty of the truth" is necessary, and this is given only by a sound philosophy, founded in the objective reality of things, since "intelligence… is able to arrive at what is."[247] Without it, there is no basis for a total personal abandonment to Jesus and the Church since, "If you are not sure about the truth, how can we risk our own life and be strong enough to seriously question the life of others?"[248] That is why the study of philosophy leads the future priest to lovingly embrace the truth, which in turn leads him to recognize that this truth is not created and measured by man, but granted to him as a gift by the Supreme Truth, God. Human reason, even with limitations and difficulties, can reach objective universal truth, even in reference to God and existence in its radical sense. He must learn that faith itself cannot do without reason or the effort to ponder over the contents of faith, as Saint Augustine attested: "I have wished to see with understanding what I have believed by faith, and I have debated and worked hard."[249]

221. In intellectual formation, the beginning and end is Jesus Christ, especially Jesus Christ as He is known through Sacred Scripture. He is the light of the *Paginae Sacrae*: *He opened their minds to understand the Scriptures* (Lk 24:45). Understanding the Bible is a

[245] PDV 52.
[246] Cf. PDV 52.
[247] PAUL VI, *Creed of the People of God*, 5.
[248] PAUL VI, *Creed of the People of God*, 5.
[249] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Holy Trinity XV*, 28: CCL 50/A, 534.

grace from Christ: *Their thoughts were rendered dull, for to this present day the same veil remains unlifted when they read the old covenant, because through Christ it is taken away* (2 Cor 3:14). He is the center of the Sacred Scriptures as He, *Beginning with Moses and all the prophets, … interpreted to them what referred to him in all the scriptures* (Lk 24:27). Thus, "Ignorance of Scripture is ignorance of Christ."[250] Therefore, Sacred Scripture is the "soul" of theology.[251]

222. The reading of Sacred Scripture should be done "in church"[252] because: …*No prophesy of the scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation* (2 Pt 1:20). The strictest fidelity to the Supreme Magisterium of the Church of all times, the proximate norm of faith, is absolutely necessary.

223. Intellectual formation of the future priest "is based and built above all on the study of sacred doctrine and theology"[253] that comes from faith and tries to lead us to faith, as the Magisterium of the Church and Catholic theologians have always taught. Saint Thomas teaches that faith is the "habitus" of theology, that is to say, its permanent operative principle,[254] and that all theology is ordained to nourish the faith.[255] Indeed, what a great need we have to enter into the mysteries of the faith by means of theological studies, as we are called to be men of faith who should bring our brethren to, and strengthen them in, the faith!

224. Theological reflection "is centered on adherence to Jesus Christ, the wisdom of God. In addition to helping candidates grow in scientific precision, [it] will also help them develop a great

---

[250] SAINT JEROME, *Comment to Isaiah*, prologue.

[251] Cf. OT 16.

[252] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Council of "Equipes Notre-Dame", (September 17, 1979); OR (9/30/1979) Spanish Edition.

[253] PDV 53.

[254] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *In Lib. Boeti de Trinitate*, 5, 4, ad 8; cf. PDV 53.

[255] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *In I Sent. D. 1*, q. 1, a. 1.

and living love for Jesus Christ and for his Church."[256] That love nourishes spiritual life and serves as a model for the generous exercise of ministry. Therefore, theology must be nourished by prayer and by the love of Jesus Christ. Saint Bonaventure points out, "May no one believe that reading without unction is enough, nor speculation without devotion, searching without amazement, observation without joy, activity without piety, science without charity, intelligence without humility, studies without divine grace, investigation without wisdom coming from supernatural inspiration."[257]

225. This study must lead to "a complete and unified vision of the truths which God has revealed in Jesus Christ and of the Church's experience of faith. Hence arises the need both to know all the Christian truths, without arbitrarily selecting among them, and to know them in an orderly fashion."[258]

226. In reflecting on faith, theology moves in two directions: first is the study of the Word of God, written in the Sacred Books, celebrated and transmitted in the living Tradition of the Church and authentically interpreted by the Magisterium. This study of Sacred Scripture includes not only the Fathers of the Church who explained the recorded deeds and words of God,[259] but also liturgy, Church history, and magisterial declarations. The second direction is that of man, "the interlocutor of God," who is called to live, believe, and communicate the Christian faith. From this comes the study of dogmatic, moral, pastoral, and spiritual theology, as well as of Canon Law.[260]

227. We will give preference to the works of Saint Thomas Aquinas, because we have to be formed "under his magisteri-

[256] PDV 53.
[257] SAINT BONAVENTURE, *Itinerary of the Mind into God*, Prologue, 4.
[258] PDV 54.
[259] Cf. AG 22.
[260] Cf. PDV 54.

um,"[261] and hold him "especially as a teacher"[262] for the following reasons: he "illumined the Church more than all the other doctors. In his books, one profits more in only one year than in the study of all the others during his whole life."[263] He "most venerated the ancient doctors of the Church, [and] in a certain way he seems to have inherited the intellect of all."[264] The "Church has proclaimed that the doctrine of Saint Thomas is her own."[265] God has willed that by the strength and truth of the doctrine of the Angelic Doctor, "All the heresies and error that would follow will be driven away, confounded and condemned."[266] His knowledge is of undeniable and fundamental importance for the right interpretation of Sacred Scripture, so as to transcend the sensory and achieve union with God, and to build the edifice of Sacred Theology upon the solid base provided by a profound knowledge of the philosophy of being – a "perennially valid philosophical heritage"[267] – and the advances of philosophical investigation.

ARTICLE 4: PASTORAL FORMATION

228. Jesus Christ is also the end here, as *Chief Shepherd* (1 Pt 5:4), for He is the Supreme Model, and the flock is His: *Tend my sheep* (Jn 21:16). That is why "the whole formation imparted to candidates to the priesthood aims at preparing them to communicate the charity of Christ, the Good Shepherd."[268] Since our Institute has an apostolic branch, pastoral endeavors are essential to it. We must never forget that there is no authentic Catholic pastoral

[261] Cf. OT 16.
[262] CIC, c. 252 § 3.
[263] JOHN XXII, *Allocution in the Consistory*, July 14, 1323.
[264] CAJETAN, *Commentary on Summa Theologiae*, II-II, 148, 9, 4. Quoted by LEO XIII, *Aeterni Patris*, 10.
[265] BENEDICT XV, *Fausto Appetente Die*, 4b.
[266] SAINT PIUS V, *Mirabilis Deus*; cf. LEO XIII, *Aeterni Patris*, 13.
[267] CIC, c. 251.
[268] PDV 57; cf. OT 4.

work without a profound spiritual life, without solid doctrinal formation, and without manly discipline.

229. A thirst for souls must be part of the vocation from the very beginning of religious life that gradually and prudently cements itself in the life of the candidate, the novice, and the professed. This is why pastoral formation should include an initial and progressive experience in ministry.[269]

230. Here, formation ends in Christ alone, Christ always, Christ in everything, Christ in all, and All Christ, until the religious can truly say, *Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ* (1 Cor 11:1) and, *it is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me* (Gal 2:20). In such a way Jesus Christ will defend us before the Father on Judgment Day, "See that he is my member and he is me."[270]

231. We aspire to form priests for the Catholic Church according to the Heart of Christ, priests who nourish their spirit with the Word of God, serve their neighbor in solidarity with all in need, promote the laity, and have a great capability for dialogue without suffering any identity crisis. Our priests must desire ongoing formation, abandon themselves to Providence, and love the Catholic liturgy. These individuals are tireless preachers, "rich in spirit,"[271] "with tongue, lips, and wisdom, which the enemies of truth cannot resist,"[272] who are exceptionally fruitful in their apostolic and vocational efforts; they have missionary and ecumenical impetus, are open to any particle of truth wherever it is found, have preferential love for the poor without exclusivity and without exclusions. They must live in transparent and contagious joy, in unperturbed peace even amid the most arduous battles; they live in absolute and unrestricted ecclesiastical communion as relentless evangelists and catechists and as lovers of the cross. In

[269] Cf. PDV 58.
[270] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Sermons, Sunday III after Pentecost.*
[271] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Sermons, Feast of Saint Nicholas.*
[272] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *Ardent Prayer*, 22.

short, we seek to form priests who are men with common sense, with that Christian common sense, which is none other than a familiarity with the Word made flesh.

CHAPTER 2
STAGES OF FORMATION

ARTICLE 1: MINOR SEMINARY

232. The first stage of formation is the minor seminary. The minor seminary is for all those who demonstrate a desire to devote themselves to God at an early age. "The goal of the minor seminary is to help those adolescents who have manifested the seed of a vocation, to discern more easily and to be able to respond to it."[273]

At the end of his studies at the minor seminary, the candidate, "having a clear conscience of the divine call… may have reached the human and spiritual maturity that permits him to make the decision to respond to the call with sufficient responsibility and freedom."[274]

233. "As experience has long shown, a priestly vocation tends to manifest itself in the preadolescent years or in the earliest years of youth. Even in those who decide to enter the seminary later, it is not uncommon to find that God's call had been perceived much earlier."[275] In considering Jesus' predilection for the apostle John, Saint Thomas taught, "This gives us an understanding of how God loves in a special way those who give themselves to his service from an early age."[276]

---

[273] SACRED CONGREGATION FOR CATHOLIC EDUCATION, *Ratio Fundamentalis institutionis sacerdotalis*, 11.

[274] SACRED CONGREGATION FOR RELIGIOUS AND SECULAR INSTITUTES, *Instruction on the Renewal of Religious Life*, *Renovationis Causam*, 4.

[275] PDV 63.

[276] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Exposition of the Gospel of John*, 21, 5, 2; PDV 63.

234. In the minor seminary superiors must instill in the candidate who desires to consecrate himself to God a "special religious formation that disposes him to follow Christ the Redeemer – poor, chaste and obedient – with the spirit of generosity and purity of intention,"[277] particularly by means of "adequate spiritual direction."[278]

We have to ensure, therefore, that the seminarians "mature harmoniously in their physical, moral, and intellectual qualities and in their affections."[279] The work of the superiors does not exclude the "appropriate cooperation of the parents."[280]

235. For appropriate formation of seminarians, we must teach them to value and love: the mystery of the Holy Eucharist, which must be the center of their whole life, particularly in the Holy Mass; the Sacrament of Reconciliation; prompt and joyous obedience; the Holy Virgin Mary and the saints who are intercessors and models of life. Holy Scripture, as it has been written, *From infancy you have known the sacred scriptures, which are capable of giving you wisdom for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus* (2 Tim 3:15); "Christ known, searched for, and loved more and more through one's studies, personal sacrifices, victories over one's self, in the slow conquest of the virtues of justice, fortitude, temperance and prudence; Christ contemplated with fervent and patient perseverance in order that… there will be imprinted upon them the same face of Christ (cf. 2 Cor 3:18)."[281]

---

[277] OT 3.

[278] OT 3.

[279] SACRED CONGREGATION FOR CATHOLIC EDUCATION, *Ratio Fundamentalis institutionis sacerdotalis*, 14.

[280] OT 3.

[281] SACRED CONGREGATION FOR CATHOLIC EDUCATION, *Circular Letter on Some of the More Urgent Aspects of the Spiritual Formation of Seminarians*, 1.

ARTICLE 2: POSTULANCY

236. The period of postulancy is a time of first contacts with the members of the Institute, with the purpose of familiarizing the candidate with the charism of the order and with the obligations of the novitiate. This contact will be carried out by one or several priests, as designated by the Provincial Superior, who must know the candidate, his vocation and his suitability, in order to present him to the novitiate.

237. The duration of the postulancy is not fixed but depends on the candidate's preparation, his level of Christian and human maturity, his basic general culture, his emotional balance, and his capacity to live in community, etc.,[282] because "most of the difficulties found nowadays in the formation of novices come from the fact that they don't have the minimum necessary maturity when admitted to the novitiate."[283] So that "nobody will be admitted without adequate preparation,"[284] this period is required. Postulancy will not last more than two years.

ARTICLE 3: NOVITIATE

238. Life in the Institute begins in the novitiate. The novitiate lasts for one year. "The novitiate, through which life in an institute is begun, is arranged so that the novices better understand their divine vocation, and indeed one which is proper to the institute; so that they experience the Institute's way of life, and form

[282] Cf. SACRED CONGREGATION FOR CATHOLIC EDUCATION, *Circular Letter on Some of the More Urgent Aspects of the Spiritual Formation of Seminarians*, 42-44.

[283] CONGREGATION FOR RELIGIOUS AND SECULAR INSTITUTES, *Instruction on the Renewal of Religious Life*, *Renovationis Causam*, 4, note 7, introduction; cf. CIC, c. 642.

[284] CIC, c. 597 § 2.

their mind and heart in its spirit; and so that their intention and suitability are tested."[285]

239. The candidate's Provincial Superior admits him into the novitiate, wherein the novices[286] must duly prepare themselves to make their profession according to the demands of religious life. The Institute scrutinizes the candidate to receive him into its bosom.

240. The following individuals are invalidly admitted to the Novitiate:

1st one who has not yet completed the seventeenth year of age;

2nd a spouse, while the marriage is still valid;

3rd one who is currently bound by a sacred bond to an institute of consecrated life, or is incorporated into a society of apostolic life;

4th one who enters the Institute through force, fear or deceit, or whom the superior accepts under the same influences;

5th one who has concealed his incorporation in an institute of consecrated life or society of apostolic life.

241. 1. Before candidates are admitted to the novitiate they must produce proof of baptism and confirmation, and of their free status.

2. The admission of clerics or others who had been admitted to another institute of consecrated life, to a society of apostolic life, or to a seminary, also requires the testimony of the local Ordinary, the major superior of the Institute or society, or the rector of the seminary, according to necessity.

---

[285] CIC, c. 646.
[286] Cf. CIC, c. 641-645.

3. The superiors can seek other information, even without informing the candidate, as they deem necessary.

242. 1. The establishment, transfer and cessation of a novitiate house are to be carried out through written decree of the Institute's Superior General with the consent of the Council.

2. To be valid, the novitiate must take place in a house which is duly designated for this purpose. In particular cases, by way of exception, and with the permission of the Superior General given with the consent of the Council, a candidate can make the novitiate in another house of the Institute, under the direction of an approved religious who takes the place of the Master of Novices.

3. The Provincial Superior may permit a group of novices to reside in another specified house of the Institute for a certain period of time.

243. 1. In order to be valid, the novitiate must consist of twelve months spent in the novitiate community.

2. To complete the formation of the novices, we establish one or more periods of apostolic activity, to be performed outside the novitiate community.

3. A novitiate is invalidated by a continuous or interrupted absence from the novitiate house for more than three months. Any absence of more than fifteen days must be made up.

4. With the permission of the Provincial, first profession may be done in advance, though not by more than fifteen days.

244. "A novice may freely leave the institute. The competent authority of the institute may also dismiss a novice,"[287] without prejudice to what is said in can. 653 § 2.

[287] CIC, c. 653 § 1.

245. Spiritual formation must prevail in the novitiate, as must intellectual formation for the novices, such that they may pursue further studies. However, pastoral experiences, especially missionary ones, can also be carried out according to the charism proper to the Institute.

246. The novices are under the care of a Master named by the Superior General with the deliberative vote of the Council. Another priest can be added as Vice-Master according to necessity.[288]

247. The governance of the novices is reserved solely for the Master of Novices, under the authority of the Provincial Superior.

248. Dialogue with the Master of Novices: Dialogue with the Superior is a privileged time during the formation period. It benefits the novice as well as the temporally professed members. It favors the good of the community. In this trust-filled dialogue, the religious informs his superior about all the activities he is carrying out. If he wishes, he may reveal the state of his conscience as well. It is advisable to dialogue twice a month during the novitiate. (This practice is also advisable once a month after profession until perpetual profession, and frequently thereafter.)

249. The Master of Novices must encourage the novices to live human and Christian virtues, and bring them along a path of greater perfection through prayer and self-denial; he must instruct them in the contemplation of the mystery of salvation and in the reading and meditation of Sacred Scriptures. He must prepare them for the celebration of God's worship in the Sacred Liturgy, form them to live a consecrated life to God and to all men in Christ through the evangelical counsels, and instruct them in the character, spirit, purpose, discipline, history, and life of the Insti-

[288] Cf. CIC, c 651 § 2.

tute; he will strive to infuse in them love for the Church and her holy shepherds.[289]

250. After an assessment period, the novices will receive the religious habit.

ARTICLE 4: PROFESSION

A. TEMPORARY PROFESSION

251. In order to be valid, temporary profession requires:

1. that the person making it is at least eighteen years of age;

2. that the novitiate has been made validly;

3. that the profession be explicit and made without force, fear, or deceit;

4. that the profession be received by the Provincial Superior, personally or through another.

252. Upon completion of the novitiate, a novice will be admitted to temporary profession. The admission is decided by the Provincial Superior with the deliberative vote of the Council. When there are doubts concerning the vocation, either from the candidate or the Institute, the time of novitiate may be prolonged, but not for longer than a period of six months.[290]

253. The temporary profession will be made during the first four years for a period of one year each, and then for a two-year period. For those religious who are candidates to the priest-

[289] Cf. CIC, cc. 646, 652; CONGREGATION FOR INSTITUTES OF CONSECRATED LIFE AND SOCIETIES OF APOSTOLIC LIFE, *Directives on Formation in Religious Institutes*, 45-53.

[290] Cf. CIC, c 653 § 2.

hood, what is established in n. 256 must be taken into consideration. The Superior General, with the consent of his council and with just cause, can dispense from this norm so that a religious could be admitted to perpetual profession after completing the third year of temporal profession[291] with due regard for what is established in canon 657 § 3.

254. The formula for temporary consecration is as follows:

For love
of the Father, first source and supreme end of consecrated life;
of Christ, who calls us to His intimacy;
of the Holy Spirit, who disposes our soul to receive His inspirations.

I, N., freely, make an oblation of my entire being to God:
to deepen, each time with a love more sincere and intense,
the gift of the evangelical counsels in a Trinitarian dimension;
to be a concrete imprint that the Trinity leaves on history
so that in this way, all mankind will discover an attraction and longing for the divine beauty;
so that my life may be a living memory
of the way that Jesus, *the Word made flesh* (cf. Jn 1:14)
lived and behaved
before the Father and before mankind.

Therefore, I pledge all my strength
so as not to be elusive to the missionary adventure,
to inculturate the Gospel
in the diversity of all cultures,
to extend the Incarnation of the Word
"to all men, in the whole man,
and in all of the manifestations of man,"

[291] Cf. CIC, c. 658 § 2.

assuming all that is authentically human,
in order to be like another humanity of Christ,
to carry out, with greater perfection,
the service of God and man.

Therefore, in the presence of God our Lord, and all His saints,
before N., Provincial Superior
of the Institute of the Incarnate Word
(or before N., who takes the place of the
Provincial Superior of the Institute of the Incarnate Word)
and in the presence of all the members of the Institute
and of the Servants of the Lord and of the Virgin of Matará,
I make a vow for … year/s to live
chaste, for the sake of the kingdom of heaven,
poor, manifesting that God
is the only true wealth of mankind,
and *obedient*, even until death on the cross,
to follow more intimately the Incarnate Word
in His chastity, poverty, and obedience,
in accordance with the evangelical way
traced in the Constitutions
of the Institute of the Incarnate Word.
To fulfill this more perfectly,
I consecrate myself to Mary *in filial slavery of love*.

I request Our Lady, the Twelve Apostles,
and all the other patron saints to intercede for me,
and I also ask for the prayers
of my brothers in the Institute of the Incarnate Word
and the sisters of the Institute
of the Servants of the Lord and the Virgin of Matará.

May the love and grace of the Most Holy Trinity
help me to be faithful to the work that He has begun.

The one who is receiving the vows replies:

In the name of the Church
and the Institute of the Incarnate Word,
I welcome with great joy to our Religious Family
these brothers with temporal vows,
who have demonstrated their explicit desire
for a total conformity
to Christ, the Incarnate Word.

B. PERPETUAL PROFESSION

255. For perpetual profession to be valid, the candidate must be at least twenty-one years of age.

256. The religious who are candidates to the priesthood can be admitted to perpetual profession after at least five years of temporary profession, having completed their philosophical and theological studies prior to the diaconate. If there are doubts about suitability, or if the candidate himself asks for it, an additional period of up to three years with temporary vows can be permitted. At the end of this period, the candidate will either be admitted to the perpetual profession or dismissed.

257. The formula for perpetual profession will be the following:

For love
of the Father, first source and supreme end of consecrated life;
of Christ, who calls us to His intimacy;
of the Holy Spirit, who disposes our soul
to receive His inspirations.

I, N., freely, make an oblation of my entire being to God:
to deepen, each time with a love more sincere and intense,

the gift of the evangelical counsels in a Trinitarian dimension;
to be a concrete imprint that the Trinity leaves on history
so that in this way, all mankind will discover an attraction
and longing for the divine beauty;
so that my life may be a living memory
of the way that Jesus, *the Word made flesh* (cf. Jn 1:14)
lived and behaved
before the Father and before mankind.

Therefore, I pledge all my strength
so as not to be elusive to the missionary adventure,
to inculturate the Gospel
in the diversity of all cultures,
to extend the Incarnation of the Word
"to all men, in the whole man,
and in all of the manifestations of man,"
assuming all that is authentically human,
in order to be like another humanity of Christ,
to carry out, with greater perfection,
the service of God and man.

Therefore, in the presence of God our Lord, and all His saints,
before N., Provincial Superior
of the Institute of the Incarnate Word
(or before N., who takes the place
of the Provincial Superior
of the Institute of the Incarnate Word),
and in the presence of all the members of the Institute,
and of the Servants of the Lord and of the Virgin of Matará,
I make a vow to forever live

chaste, for the sake of the kingdom of heaven,

poor, manifesting that God is the only true wealth of mankind,

and *obedient*, even until death on the cross,
to follow more intimately the Incarnate Word

in His chastity, poverty, and obedience,
in accordance with the evangelical way
traced in the Constitutions
of the Institute of the Incarnate Word.
To fulfill this more perfectly,
I consecrate myself to Mary *in filial slavery of love.*

I request Our Lady, the Twelve Apostles,
and all the other patron saints to intercede for me,
and I also ask for the prayers
of my brothers in the Institute of the Incarnate Word,
and the sisters of the Institute
of the Servants of the Lord and the Virgin of Matará.

May the love and grace of the Most Holy Trinity
help me to be faithful to the work that He has begun.

The one who is receiving the vows replies:
In the name of the Church
and the Institute of the Incarnate Word,
I welcome with great joy to our Religious Family
these brothers with perpetual vows,
who have demonstrated their explicit desire
for a total conformity
to Christ, the Incarnate Word.

ARTICLE 5: RELIGIOUS SEMINARY

A. SEMINARY FOR RELIGIOUS WHO ARE CANDIDATES TO THE PRIESTHOOD

258. The Institute of the Incarnate Word is a clerical institute, wherein the majority of the members are priests. Upon finishing the novitiate, a new period of priestly formation begins, executed

according to Canon Law for the formation of clerics and according to the documents of the Holy See, and always in accordance with the spirituality and mission of the Institute, so as to accomplish an authentic overall formation: human, spiritual, intellectual, and pastoral.

259. According to our own charism, we strive to orient all our studies toward the evangelization of the culture, for which we will spare no efforts or means. We are not content with a merely superficial knowledge of philosophy and theology that is incapable of understanding the modern exercise of atheism in all its depth, and is thus incapable of providing a remedy for it.

B. SEMINARY OF THE COADJUTOR BROTHERS

260. The Institute will also have religious called "coadjutor brothers." They will dedicate themselves to serving the houses and to giving spiritual services that do not require the sacramental grace of Holy Orders.

261. These brothers should complete formation in the seminary, where they will take some courses in philosophy and theology, "attending to the needs of the Church and the circumstances of men and the times, according to the end and the character of the Institute."[292] The coadjutor brothers will continue their formation, under the direct authority of the local superior, until their perpetual profession in the houses to which they are assigned. Their ongoing formation must be monitored.

ARTICLE 6: ONGOING FORMATION

262. Religious life is a process of continual conversion that does not end with the years of formation, but must be maintained

[292] Cf. CIC, c. 659 § 1-2.

and must grow every day.[293] Regarding our pastoral work, this formation is an act of true and proper justice for God's people, who always demand the most appropriate answer from us.[294]

263. Ongoing formation, not limited by the age or circumstances of the member, possesses four dimensions: human, spiritual, intellectual, and pastoral.

264. We believe that permanent and ongoing formation is fundamental. To accomplish this, in addition to ordinary measures such as conferences, retreats, courses, exams, etc., extraordinary measures should be taken whenever possible, for example: the 30-day spiritual exercises every ten years, pilgrimages to the Holy Land and to great shrines of Christianity, etc.

265. In order to undertake this ongoing formation, we desire that all the members of our Institute take ecclesiastical or civil courses after the Seminary, according to their capacities and talents. These will be taken preferably in the pontifical universities of Rome or in those institutions recognized by the Holy See, so as to receive the qualifying degree of licentiate and doctorate.[295] We already have a priestly community in Rome where two years are normally spent for this purpose.[296] The formation in Rome implies the attainment of a Roman spirit, which entails a "crown of virtues: universal openness, fidelity to the Magisterium, a missionary spirit, endurance, and magnanimity."[297] Being in Rome is a "situation that permits [one] to live the supernatural reality of communion with the Church of Rome and with the Bishop of Rome. In the ecclesiastical experience [one] enters into the field of

[293] Cf. CONGREGATION FOR INSTITUTES OF CONSECRATED LIFE AND SOCIETIES OF APOSTOLIC LIFE, *Directives on Formation in Religious Institutes*, 66-68; CIC, c. 661.

[294] Cf. PDV 70.

[295] Cf. CIC, c. 253 § 1.

[296] Cf. CIC, c. 660 § 1.

[297] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily during Vespers in the Capranica College of Rome, 5; January 21, 1992; OR (1/31/1992) Spanish Edition.

a new reality: [one] experiences the communion with all who are in communion with the Church of Rome."[298] Therefore, the opportunity to study in the Eternal City has a two-fold advantage: "It means having the advantage of living in a community either of priests or seminarians, and having access to the scholarship available in or through the Roman universities. It means being witnesses, day after day, to the living tradition of the faith as it is proclaimed in the See of Peter."[299]

266. Therefore, the Church of Rome is the best place for this formation: "There is no other place with such an opportunity to form suitable priests as there is in the center of Christianity, next to the tombs of the two great Apostles, under the paternal solicitude of the Supreme Pontiff, who by his function as Vicar of Christ, is the common Father of all people and guardian and interpreter of the Catholic faith."[300]

Roman-ness is "understood as the special spirit of communion with the Successor of Peter, visible Head of the Church of Christ, by means of unity of faith, and charity."[301]

These studies can also be undertaken in any scholastically prominent civil university according to the judgment of the Superior General and his Council.

267. Every superior should use any means necessary for all members of the community to obtain this ongoing formation: conferences, retreats, courses, exams, etc. We must spend our whole life searching for the full truth: "If truth is not longed for

[298] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse at the North American Pontifical College of Rome, October 15, 1984; OR (12/2/1984) Spanish Edition.

[299] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse at the North American Pontifical College of Rome, October 15, 1984; OR (12/2/1984) Spanish Edition.

[300] LEO XIII, *Benigna hominum parens*, quote by BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse at the Armenian Pontifical College of Rome, July 7, 1984; OR (12/9/1984) Spanish Edition.

[301] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Speech to the Students and Alumni of the Capranica College of Rome, January 21, 1983; OR (4/10/1983) Spanish Edition.

with all the strengths of one's soul, it cannot be found in any way."[302]

ARTICLE 7: THOSE RESPONSIBLE FOR THE FORMATION

268. We will take special care preparing and choosing those priests in charge of the formation of seminarians, as the future of the Institute depends on it. This is what we mean by "to form a school": that those priests in charge of the formation of our future priests must be able to transmit the heritage of our Institute, as opposed to forming a "solitary" priest, that is, one who would not contribute to the continuation of our work. In the work of evangelizing the culture, the efforts of one individual or one generation are not sufficient; rather, a great evangelical movement is necessary, one that will forever deepen and extend itself in this task. This is the work of those responsible for formation. Therefore, those in charge of formation must be formed themselves as men of suitable discernment who are rich in spirit.

269. Besides sufficient knowledge of Catholic doctrine regarding faith and morals, the task of forming others demands certain conditions. These conditions are: human intuition and warmth, familiarity with God and prayer, wisdom, love for liturgy, necessary cultural competence, availability, and willingness to dedicate personal care to each of the seminarians individually, and not merely to the group. To accomplish this, one must have interior serenity, availability, patience, understanding, and true affection toward those who have been commended to him.[303]

---

[302] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *The Gift of Perseverance*, 20, 53.

[303] Cf. CONGREGATION FOR INSTITUTES OF CONSECRATED LIFE AND SOCIETIES OF APOSTOLIC LIFE, *Directives on Formation in Religious Institutes*, 30-32.

ARTICLE 8: RE-ADMISSION

270. Anyone who may have legitimately left the Institute upon completing the novitiate, or even after profession, may be re-admitted by the Superior General with the consent of his Council, with no obligation to repeat the novitiate. The Superior General will determine the appropriate testing prior to temporary profession, as well as the duration of the vows prior to perpetual profession.[304]

[304] Cf. CIC, c. 690 § 1.

PART 8

GOVERNMENT OF THE INSTITUTE

INTRODUCTION: THE RELIGIOUS FAMILY OF THE INCARNATE WORD

271. The Institute of the Incarnate Word recognizes the primary and supreme authority of the Supreme Pontiff, and professes not only obedience to him, but also fidelity, filial submission, adherence, and disposition for the service of the universal Church.

272. Ever docile to the will of God, superiors will regard the exercise of their authority as true service to the Church and will always remember that the primary obligation of the superior is to command well.

ARTICLE 1: FEMALE BRANCH: THE INSTITUTE OF THE SERVANTS OF THE LORD AND THE VIRGIN OF MATARÁ

273. Both "the Institute of the Incarnate Word" and its female branch, "the Institute of the Servants of the Lord and the Virgin of Matará" form the "Religious Family of the Incarnate Word." Both Institutes are indissolubly united. Their union is spiritual, though legally independent. Their spiritual union is given essentially through possessing the same founder and twin Constitutions, by the Spiritual Father (elected by the women religious), and

by the help of other priests of the Institute of the Incarnate Word (spiritual advisers, community advisers, spiritual directors, confessors, professors, etc.) who are appointed for these tasks by the competent authority.

ARTICLE 2: CONTEMPLATIVE BRANCH

274. The male contemplative branch is also part of the Institute of the Incarnate Word. It is comprised of those houses where the religious dedicate themselves to the contemplative life in conformity with the provisions of proper law.

275. Every monastery should have a superior designated by the Superior General with the consent of his council.

276. The monasteries are houses of the Institute belonging to the province in whose territory they are located.

ARTICLE 3: THIRD ORDER

277. The Institute of the Incarnate Word also has a Third Order. Third Order "members live in the world but share in the spirit of … [the] institute, under… [its] overall direction…"[305]

278. The Third Order is structured on three levels, according to the degree of commitment which the members freely choose:

- First Degree: Lay associates who aspire to evangelical perfection according to the spirit of the Institute by participating in its mission,[306] obligating themselves freely through private vows or some other sacred bond.

[305] Cf. CIC, c. 303.
[306] Cf. CIC, c. 725.

- Second Degree: Lay associations of the faithful: groups or movements, each with its own structure, that want to participate in the spirit and purpose of the Institute.

- Third Degree: All faithful lay people related in different ways to the Institute, who want to share in its spirit: friends, acquaintances, benefactors, family members, etc.

279. The Third Order is united to and dependent upon our Religious Family in both aspects, in groups and individually.

280. The Superior General, with the deliberative vote of his Council, chooses the Major Adviser, the liaison between the Institute and the Third Order. Each Provincial Superior, in conjunction with the Provincial Superior of the Institute of the Servants of the Lord and the Virgin of Matará, is the liaison in his province, and gives spiritual assistance to the tertiaries, according to the three levels of the Third Order.

ARTICLE 4: CENTRAL COORDINATING BOARD

281. The Superior General of the Institute of the Incarnate Word, or his delegate, will preside over the Central Coordinating Board, made up of: the Superior Generals of both Institutes; the superiors of each Institute, Movement, and Association of the Third Order. This board will coordinate the different apostolates, the foundations, the promotion of the spirit of the Institutes, etc. It will not possess any competence in the government of any branch.

CHAPTER 1
DIVISION OF THE INSTITUTE

282. The houses of the Institute will be grouped into provinces, vice-provinces, and delegations that can be established by the General Chapter and the Superior General together with his Council "ad referendum" of the General Chapter.

283. When a homogeneous group of houses does not meet the minimum conditions to constitute a province, then a vice-province or a delegation can be established, according to the degree of development it may have reached. The vice-provinces and the delegations will be governed by a superior who possesses the necessary faculties and who is appointed by the Superior General with the consent of his Council.

CHAPTER 2: GENERAL CHAPTERS

284. The supreme governing body of the Institute of the Incarnate Word is the General Chapter, which shall be convoked according to the time and form established below.

ARTICLE 1: CONVOCATION OF THE CHAPTERS

285. General Chapters can be either ordinary or extraordinary.

The General Chapter is convoked ordinarily every six years in order to elect the Superior General and to deal with all matters established in canon 631 § 1, and other matters that may be necessary. Likewise, it is convoked extraordinarily to hold a new election on account of the death, resignation, or removal[307] of the Superior General.

Pending due consent of his Council, the Superior General may convoke an Extraordinary Chapter to address grave matters of the utmost importance to the Institute.

286. The General Chapter will be convoked and presided over by the Superior General or his substitute. Also attending, with voice and deliberative vote, will be the following:

1) By reason of office:

- The former Superior Generals of the Institute of the Incarnate Word.
- The General Councilors.
- The Provincial Superiors and others who are their equals

[307] Cf. CIC, c. 194.

- The Rectors of the Major Seminaries.
- The Rectors of duly established Clerical Colleges.

2) Delegates by Election:

- Priests under perpetual vows from each province and vice-province, in proportion to the number of members of each jurisdiction, elected by an absolute majority of the perpetually professed members. The numerical proportion must be established in a pre-Chapter regulation.

- Two superiors of monasteries – for every six monasteries – elected as the Directory of Contemplative Life dictates.

With regard to the capacity and conditions of the voters and the votes, we will take into account what is established in Canon Law.[308]

287. The number of Delegates by Election of the General Chapter must be higher than that of the Participants by Reason of their Office.

ARTICLE 2: CELEBRATION OF THE CHAPTER

288. The President of the Chapter is the Superior General of the Institute or one who takes his place.

289. The Chapter Fathers will secretly vote for a Chapter Secretary, two auxiliaries and two auditors.

290. A profession of faith according to can. 833 will be made at the opening of the General Chapter. The General Secretary will then immediately record in the minutes the names of those in at-

[308] Cf. CIC, cc. 168-172.

tendance. In the same way, he will record the name of the person elected Chapter Secretary, auxiliaries, and auditors. He will also record the agenda of the day.

291. At a suitable time, the Chapter will proceed to elect the Superior General by a vote that is free, secret, certain, and absolute, and by a two-thirds majority vote of the Chapter Fathers present. After two inefficient audits wherein the two-thirds majority has not been reached, there will be a third vote between the two candidates who obtained the highest number of votes; or, if there are more than two, the election will be held between the two longest professed; or, if they are equal in length of period of profession, the election will be between the two oldest. After the third audit, if a tie persists, the longest professed will be elected, and if they are equal in this amount of time, the older will be elected.[309] The Superior-elect will be notified immediately. From that moment, the Superior-elect will have a period of eight working days to accept or reject the position, and if he accepts, to name the Vicar General, the General Secretary, and the Treasurer. Those designated by the Superior General will likewise have an equal length of time to accept or reject the appointment.

292. After electing the Superior General, the Chapter will proceed to elect, by absolute majority, two members who will be part of the General Council, and then to elect the first, second, and third substitute Councilors, also by absolute majority. In the event that the Superior General's nominations include any members already elected by the Chapter to be Councilors or Substitutes, the nominations by the Superior General will take priority, and he himself will fill the missing positions. The members of the General Council, elected by the Chapter, will remain in their functions

[309] Cf. CIC, c. 119 § 1.

for the same period of time as the Superior General, and both the Superior General and council members can be re-elected.[310]

293. Once the elections have been verified, the Chapter will hold the necessary sessions in which the new Superior General will be informed of the state of the Institute of the Incarnate Word. The other religious in attendance can make observations about things that they think are worthy of consideration for the well-being of the provinces and houses of the Institute of the Incarnate Word.

294. The main matters that will be addressed within the General Chapter are:

1) The defense of the patrimony of the Institute of the Incarnate Word; making adjustments and implementing renewal according to it, electing the Superior General, and promulgating the rules that bind for all Institute members.[311]

2) The amendment of a given point of the Constitutions, by a two-thirds consent of the General Chapter members, which then must be approved by the competent ecclesiastic authority.[312]

3) The revision and modification of the general Directories,[313] Regulations, and other rules.

4) The division of the Institute as a whole into provinces, vice-provinces, and delegations,[314] and the cessation of the same.[315]

5) Definition of the way in which the evangelical counsels will be observed.[316]

---

[310] Cf. CIC, c. 177.
[311] Cf. CIC, c. 631 § 1.
[312] Cf. CIC, c. 595 § 1.
[313] Cf. CIC, c. 587 § 4.
[314] Cf. CIC, c. 581.
[315] Cf. CIC, c. 585.

6) The handling of any other major topics, requests, and suggestions that may be freely contributed.[317]

[316] Cf. CIC, c. 598 § 1.
[317] Cf. CIC, c. 631 § 1-3.

CHAPTER 3
GENERAL GOVERNMENT

ARTICLE 1: SUPERIOR GENERAL

295. The Institute is permanently governed by a Superior General assisted by his Council of five Councilors. Of the six members of the General Government, the Superior General and at least two Councilors will be elected by the Chapter. The Vicar General, the General Secretary, and the General Treasurer are named by the Superior General.

296. The Superior General holds the highest rank in the Institute and exercises the functions of primary authority. He attends to the care and government of the Institute of the Incarnate Word and of all its members according to the present Constitutions and Canon Law.

The Superior General's jurisdiction of authority is over the entire Institute of the Incarnate Word and over each of its members, both in the apostolic and contemplative houses.

To be elected and to perform this office, he must possess ability, discretion, prudence, maturity, and the other virtues required for the sound performance of his duty.

To be elected, the Superior General must be a priest with at least fifteen years of perpetual profession[318] in the Institute of the Incarnate Word.

He is elected for a period of six years and can be reelected.

[318] Cf. CIC, c. 623.

297. - The voters must be careful not to elect anyone who has desired or sought the office of Superior General. The same applies for choosing the other superiors.

298. - The Superior General must avoid preferential treatment of members of the Institute. He must have the same attitude toward everyone, and avoid showing partiality. Preference of persons is a sin that opposes distributive justice – the principle of giving positions, offices, and responsibilities for the common good in proportion to the dignity or ability of each person. In justice, the person who is most suitable for each assignment must be chosen for the common good. Therefore, the person's qualifications regarding his suitability must be considered. When we fail to do so, we commit the vice of partiality of persons. The person chosen in such a case is appointed because of who he is, and not because of his abilities; he therefore prevents the one who, in justice, should fill that office from doing so. This kind of injustice is expressly prohibited in Sacred Scripture.[319] The Superior should be a father in the image of the Heavenly Father, *Who shows no partiality* (Acts 10:34).

299. - The Superior General is expected to be faithful to the Constitutions. He should not grant himself the authority to exempt anyone from honoring them even for minor reasons.

300. - He is never to reprimand in anger. He is to be gentle with all and strict with himself. He is never to speak in praise of himself except with the hope of bringing about some good, and even then only with humility and acknowledgment of God's gifts.

301. - All functions and obligations flowing from his office as Superior General must be performed with a spirit of exceptional service. His authority is for service and his service is authoritative. He is to govern as one who serves, because he is obligated by rea-

[319] Cf. Dt 1:17; 16:19; Jas 2:9.

son of his office to serve by leading: *Let the greatest among you be as the youngest, and the leader as the servant* (Lk 22:26).

302. Faculties and duties of the Superior General are:

1st To govern the members as sons of God. The Superior General is to extend to them the same paternal charity that God has for them. He is also to have that fraternal charity desired by God in loving the other superiors and members. God also desires that they too love each other with the same fraternal charity.

2nd To respect each human person because of his dignity as a person, and even more so because of the added dignity flowing from baptism and consecration. Moreover, he is to respect them because of the combination of inborn and acquired abilities which make up the uniqueness of each member.

3rd To promote voluntary obedience, to foster willingness in obedience and submissive freedom. Whoever has freely professed obedience must voluntarily practice the specific acts of that counsel. The perfect attainment of this ideal will be the supernatural and human sign of the proper exercise of authority.

4th To listen willingly. To listen is neither to assent, nor to hear with deaf ears; neither is it the attention of a disciple, nor the instruction of a teacher. Listening does not require giving an answer, for indeed, an answer may not exist. Nor may it be prudent or obligatory to give any answer. Nor is it his duty to reach an agreement on what he and any member may have been talking about, as this agreement is often non-existent or impossible to attain. Nor is it his duty to make a decision that accommodates the desires of a member.

5th To foster his initiatives for the good of the Institute and the Church, because he is obligated to do so by his office, he must

energetically resist any passivity, as if merely waiting for others to suggest initiatives.

6th To decide and to order what should be done, taking into account the executive power given by Canon law.[320]

303. The specific and proper functions of the Superior General, besides the ones already established by can. 619 of CIC, are the following:

1st To work for the preservation and growth of the Institute of the Incarnate Word.

2nd To promote members' knowledge and observance of the Holy See's decrees relating to religious.

3rd To oversee observance of the Constitutions and fidelity to the spirit of the Institute of the Incarnate Word.

4th To promote as much as possible the spiritual and temporal good of all the members of the Institute, and to ensure that everyone fulfills his respective duties and obligations.

5th To preside over the sessions of the General Council and present therein all the matters to be addressed. The Superior General can seek advice from the Council any time he deems it necessary.

6th To notify the Provincial Superiors, and when he deems it appropriate, to directly notify the Local Superiors, of the Council's resolutions that they should be aware of.

7th To visit all of the Provinces and houses of the Institute for inspection and general direction.

[320] Cf. CIC, c. 137 and concordant paragraphs.

8th To oversee all aspects of the spiritual and intellectual formation of religious.

9th To convoke ordinary and extraordinary General Chapters, according to these Constitutions.

10th To grant the license to publish writings related to religious or moral matters.[321]

11th Within the limits of his proper competence, the Superior General can grant dispensations, that is, relaxations of merely ecclesiastical laws in a particular case,[322] in every place, with respect to the members, and with respect to himself,[323] according to the conditions demanded by Canon law.[324]

304. The Superior General also possesses other duties which he must execute together with his Council as determined in Chapter 4 (The Office of the General Chapter).

305. The Superior General can be removed from his office for the reasons stated in the Code of Canon law.[325]

ARTICLE 2: MEMBERS OF THE GENERAL COUNCIL

A. VICAR GENERAL

306. He is the second in authority in the Institute, whom all religious are obliged to obey after the Superior General. He will exercise his authority according to these Constitutions only when

[321] Cf. CIC, c. 832.
[322] Cf. CIC, c. 85.
[323] Cf. CIC, cc. 91 and 136.
[324] Cf. CIC, c. 90 and related canons.
[325] Cf. CIC, c. 194.

he replaces the Superior General or carries out the functions delegated by him.

307. The appointments that are under the competence of the Superior General cannot be made by the Vicar General.

308. In the case of vacancy or absence, the Vicar General can be replaced by whomever the Superior General designates.

309. The priest who performs this office should have the necessary abilities and must be perpetually professed at least 10 years in the Institute.

310. The Vicar General can be removed from his office for the same reasons as the Superior General. The same applies for all other superiors.[326]

311. In addition to his obligations as Vicar General, he, as first General Councilor, will substitute for the Superior General in his absence, illness, or other impediments. Likewise, in case of death, resignation, or removal of the Superior General, the Vicar will temporarily undertake the governance of the Institute. However, the Vicar General may neither proceed to a new election, nor transfer, nor appoint any Provincial or Local Superior except in the case of necessity, for four months from the date of vacancy. After those four months, the Vicar General cannot defer the convocation for the election of the Superior General for longer than three more months.

B. SECRETARY GENERAL

312. This office will be performed by a priest with at least 10 years of perpetual profession in the Institute. He must also possess the qualities required by this office.

[326] Cf. CIC, c. 194.

313. It is incumbent on the Secretary General:

- To record the minutes of Council sessions and those of the General Chapters.

- To send out all communications of the Superior General regarding matters of the Superior General's office.

- To take care of and update all of the Institute's records concerning persons, houses, provinces, dealings with civil and religious organizations, contracts, statistics, etc.

C. TREASURER GENERAL

314. The priest to whom the office of Treasurer General is given must have at least 10 years of perpetual vows in the Institute and be qualified for this job.

315. The Treasurer General is responsible for the administration of the Institute under the authority of the Superior General and the supervision of his Council. He will take particular care of all documentation concerning goods and their custody.

316. The Treasurer General will register all income and expenses of funds and valuables. He will inform the Council regarding the state of the above-mentioned matters every three months and whenever the Council requires.[327]

D. OTHER GENERAL COUNCILORS

317. In addition to the priests already mentioned, two more priests will form part of the General Council. They will be given the name of General Councilors.

[327] Cf. CIC, c. 636.

318. These priests must have at least 10 years of perpetual vows in the Institute and have the prudence and all the other virtues necessary for the exercise of their office together with the other members of the Council.

319. To replace the General Councilors appointed by the Superior General, the Superior General himself will make the new appointments. The same applies to the replacement of those provincial or local councilors appointed by the provincial or local superior, respectively.

320. Whenever any Councilor from those elected by the General Chapter ceases to belong to the General Council because of resignation, removal, transfer, or any other cause, he will be replaced by the first substitute, and successively thereafter.

CHAPTER 4
THE OFFICE OF THE GENERAL COUNCIL

ARTICLE 1: FACULTIES

321. The General Council acting as a college. The Superior General is first among his equals with the same right to vote. The decision must be made as a college,[328] and therefore its execution is binding for the members of the General Council. The college will be convoked according to can. 166 and requires a quorum of four. It is responsible for:

- approval of the Directories of the Institute, ad referendum of the General Chapter; modification of those Directories already approved, as needed, and also ad referendum of the General Chapter, to adapt them to the Church Magisterium's new documents. Modification of the Directories is necessary to update them according to the new documents of the Magisterium of the Church. Any modification to the Directory of Monasteries will require two-thirds consent of the perpetually-professed members of the Contemplative Branch.

- Decree of dismissal by absolute majority of the present members.[329]

322. The General Council acting with deliberative vote. The Council acts according to can. 127, § 1 from the CIC, not as a college, but rather as a group of persons from whom consent is required. Decisions will be made by an absolute majority of those

[328] Cf. CIC, c. 127 § 1.
[329] Cf. CIC, c. 699 § 1.

present. The final action will be the result of the personal choice and authority of the Superior, who may act according to the mentioned decision, or abstain from acting. The Council will be convoked as established in can. 166 of CIC, and will decide on:

- The establishment of provinces, vice-provinces and delegations ad referendum of the next General Chapter.

- The appointment of Provincial Superiors, vice-provincials, and delegates. The appointment should be preceded by appropriate consultation.[330] Individuals must be notified of the offices for which they have been appointed; they may accept or refuse their respective offices within a period of eight working days.

- The appointment of superiors of houses of formation, namely, both major and minor seminaries, masters of novices, rectors of universities, and superiors of monasteries, after having consulted the Provincial Superior.

- The agreement upon and the appointment of the priest elected by the female branch to be its spiritual father.

- The appointment of the major adviser of the Third Order.

- Admission to the diaconate and priesthood.

- The establishment of houses.[331]

- The establishment or cessation of novitiates,[332] major seminaries, minor seminaries, and other houses of formation.

- The cessation of houses.[333]

- The approval of study plans for the houses of formation.

---

[330] Cf. CIC, c. 625 § 3.
[331] Cf. CIC, cc. 609 § 1; 610 and 616 § 1.
[332] Cf. CIC, c. 647 § 1.
[333] Cf. CIC, cc. 585 and 616 § 1.

- Material transactions.[334]

- The exception of making the novitiate in a different house.[335]

- Change of institute.[336]

- The exclaustration of perpetually professed priests.[337]

- The indult of departure to temporarily professed religious.[338]

- The re-admission of ex-members.[339]

323. The General Council acting with consultative vote. The Council acts as a group; everyone's advice or opinion is necessary for an act to be valid. The final action will be the result of the personal choice and authority of the Superior, who can act even against what is unanimously advised if he has sufficient reason for doing so. The Council will be convoked according to Canon law[340] to deal with the following matters:

- Approval of local regulations for the houses of formation and monasteries.

- Approval of other general regulations.

ARTICLE 2: MEETINGS OF THE GENERAL COUNCIL

324. There will be two kinds of general council meetings: ordinary and extraordinary, both of which will be presided over by

[334] Cf. CIC, c. 638 § 3.
[335] Cf. CIC, c. 647 § 2.
[336] Cf. CIC, c. 684 § 1.
[337] Cf. CIC, c. 686 § 1 and 3.
[338] Cf. CIC, c. 688 § 2.
[339] Cf. CIC, c. 690 § 1.
[340] Cf. CIC, c. 127 § 1.

the Superior General, and in his absence, by the Vicar General or whoever takes his place.

325. Ordinary meetings will be held each month, and the extraordinary meetings will be held when needed. Matters concerning the Institute will be dealt with and resolved in both types of meetings. Such matters will be presented by whoever presides. For meetings to be valid, a quorum of three is needed, except for what is established in paragraph 321 of these Constitutions.

326. Council members have the right to present proposals concerning the following topics: formation, apostolate, discipline, spiritual life, and other proposals, all of which should be recorded in the minutes.

327. Council members should present their opinions with fidelity and sincerity, and give their consent in matters of great importance.

328. Except for cases in which the Council acts collegially, the Superior is outside and above his Council, which means that he is not to vote when consultation or consent are required as a group of persons,[341] or as individual persons.[342]

329. During the first three months of the year and in an ordinary meeting, the income and expense accounts of the Institute's general administration will be submitted for examination and approval.

330. Within the first three months of the year, the Institute's Provinces and Houses are to prepare and submit the annual income and expense accounts of the previous year to the General Council; this does not prevent the Superior General or the Provincial Superior from examining the accounts of the provincial or

[341] Cf. CIC, c. 127 § 1.
[342] Cf. CIC, c. 127 § 2.

local administrations on the occasion of the ordinary or extraordinary canonical visit.

331. The Councilors are rigorously warned to keep all matters addressed during meetings confidential. Only the Superior General can communicate decisions with due discretion when appropriate.

CHAPTER 5
THE PROVINCIAL GOVERNMENT

ARTICLE 1: PROVINCES

332. To make governance of the Institute easier and more effective, territorial divisions called *provinces* are permanently established, according to the various conditions of people, places and time.

333. The General Chapter, and the Superior General *ad referendum* of the General Chapter, are responsible for the establishment or modification of province and vice-province boundaries, in accordance with established norms. The following norms must be considered:

a) In order for a territory or a group of houses to constitute a province, at least three canonically established houses of the Institute of the Incarnate Word are required.

b) As far as possible, homogeneity of the territory and its socio-cultural features will be taken into account, as will access to communications and administrative conveniences.

334. Under the direction of the Superior General and his Council, each province is governed by a Provincial Superior, assisted by four provincial Councilors.

ARTICLE 2: PROVINCIAL SUPERIOR

335. The priest appointed Provincial Superior must have the necessary physical and moral aptitude to execute the demands of

this office, and must have at least 10 years of perpetual vows in the Institute. The General Superior, with the consent of his Council, can dispense with this condition.

336. The Provincial Superior is appointed for three years, and may be reappointed for another three years in the same province, but ordinarily his appointment will not exceed this amount of time.

337. The Provincial Superior will exercise his authority over each and every house in the province under his jurisdiction, and also over the monasteries of contemplative life established in the same territory.

338. The faculties and obligations of the Provincial Superior are:

1st To exercise authority in the province, under the authority of the Superior General whose directives he will faithfully execute and whom he will appropriately inform regarding the life of the province.

2nd To appoint the first two members of the Provincial Council, that is, the vicar and the secretary.

3rd To appoint the local superiors with the consent of his Council.

4th To preside over the sessions of the provincial council and to propose the matters to be addressed therein. He can consult his council whenever he deems it necessary.

5th To communicate to the local superiors the resolutions and decrees that he receives from the general and provincial councils.

6th To resolve matters proposed by the house superiors or by religious, and also, according to the importance of these matters,

to forward any appropriate issues to the Superior General and his Council.

7th To transmit to the Superior General all news and reports which will help him in appointing members for the positions that are under his competence.

8th To visit the houses of his province once a year and as many times as necessary.

9th To admit candidates to the novitiate and to temporary profession, after having consulted his Council. Similarly, to extend the period of temporal profession, with the consent of his Council.[343]

10th To admit candidates to perpetual profession with the consent of the provincial council.

11th To exclude members from subsequent profession, after consulting his Council.[344]

12th To grant permission for a prolonged absence from the community.[345]

13th To grant permission in particular cases regarding the individual goods of those who are professing according to what is established in n. 70 of these Constitutions.[346]

339. For the Superior General to be well-informed on the life and progress of the Institute, at the end of each year the Provincial Superiors will send an exact and detailed account on the financial and disciplinary state of the province and its government

[343] Cf. CIC, c. 657 § 2.
[344] Cf. CIC, c. 689 § 1.
[345] Cf. CIC, c. 665 § 1; cf. cc. 148-151.
[346] Cf. CIC, c. 668 § 2.

(in addition to the ordinary reports), together with the annual personal letter.

340. The Superior General, with the deliberative vote of his Council, will be able to grant the Provincial Superiors wider faculties within the norms of Canon law, principally to those located further away. However, those faculties granted to Provincial Superiors, ordinary as well as extraordinary, can in no way limit the authority and rights that belong to the Superior General and his Council according to the Constitutions.

ARTICLE 3: MEMBERS OF THE PROVINCIAL COUNCIL

A. PROVINCIAL VICAR

341. The Provincial Vicar is appointed directly by the Provincial Superior. He shall exercise his authority over all members of the province when he substitutes for the Provincial Superior. He can also act with the functions delegated by the Provincial Superior.

342. In addition to possessing the aptitude required of his office, the Provincial Vicar must have at least 10 years of perpetual vows in the Institute. After consulting his Council, the General Superior can dispense with this condition.

B. PROVINCIAL SECRETARY

343. The provincial secretary is directly appointed by the Provincial Superior. He will perform the functions of secretary and provincial filing clerk, and the preservation of provincial documents as well as those of the provincial government archive will

be entrusted to his care. For appointment to this office, the priest must have made perpetual vows.

C. OTHER PROVINCIAL COUNCILORS

344. The other provincial councilors, apart from the required aptitude for the office, must be religious with perpetual vows. They will be elected by the religious with perpetual vows who belong to the province (they will also elect three substitute councilors). When the majority of those who have been convoked are present, members who have the absolute majority of votes will be elected. After two inefficient audits, there will be another vote between the two candidates who obtained the highest number of votes; if there are more than two candidates, the election will be between the two longest professed. If they share the same amount of time professed, the election will be between the two oldest; after the third audit, if a tie persists, the longest professed will be elected, and if the candidates are equal in this, the older will be elected.

345. The provincial councilors will remain in their office for three years. Upon completion of their term, they can be reelected, but not normally for a third three-year term.

D. PROVINCIAL TREASURER

346. The Provincial Superior will choose the provincial treasurer from the two councilors. The priest so-appointed must possess the necessary ability to faithfully execute his office.

347. The administration and custody of the province's goods belong to the provincial treasurer under the authority of his superiors. He will ensure the accuracy of all documents and ledgers of income and expenses. He will present his reports to the Provincial Superior and his council for their knowledge, revision, and ap-

proval every three months, and whenever required by competent authority.

ARTICLE 4: PROVINCIAL COUNCILS

348. The faculties and obligations of the provincial council are:

a) To handle cases within their competence, by means of consultative or deliberative vote, according to the rules of Canon law and the Institute's proper law.

b) To examine and approve the accounts of the province.

c) To give the consultative vote for the admission of candidates to the Novitiate and temporary profession, and to give its consent for the admission of candidates to perpetual profession, by absolute majority of the quorum.

349. The provincial council must be convoked once a month and can convene for extraordinary sessions whenever the Provincial Superior, or his substitute, deems it appropriate. For validity, a session requires a quorum of two members in addition to the Provincial Superior. What is established in n. 328 applies to the Provincial Superior.

CHAPTER 6
CANONICAL VISITS

350. The Superior General must make an official visit to every province and house of the Institute at least once during his mandate, and whenever necessity demands it; unofficially, he must do so when he deems it appropriate.

351. In the event that he cannot perform this grave duty, he himself will appoint a religious as visitor.

352. By reason of his office, the Provincial Superior will visit each house of his province on three different occasions during his term of office, and as many times as special circumstances require.

CHAPTER 7
THE LOCAL GOVERNMENT

353. Each house must have a sufficient number of religious to ensure community life and the practice of the evangelical counsels.[347] That is why at least three religious must be assigned, except in special cases.

354. In every local community of the Institute of the Incarnate Word, there must be a priest who carries out the office of the local superior, assisted by a council with four members (except where this is not possible because of the number of priests), the first two of whom shall be directly elected by the local superior and who shall carry out the office of local vicar and secretary, respectively. The rest of the members shall be elected by simple majority of the priests who belong to the same community. One of them shall be elected by the local superior for the office of local treasurer.

ARTICLE 1: LOCAL SUPERIOR

355. The superior is the head of the family in each house; all the religious in that community must obey his orders with docility, exactness, and religious submission.

356. Naming a local superior must be preceded by appropriate consultation.[348] To be appointed local superior, the religious must be a priest with perpetual vows, and must possess the ability to

[347] Cf. CIC, c. 610.
[348] Cf. CIC, c. 625 § 3.

govern, a spirit of religiosity, a spirit of observance, and other requirements for the office.[349]

357. His term of office will be three years, and ordinarily he will not be reappointed for a third consecutive term in the same house.

358. The local superior has the following duties and tasks:

1) To govern the community, keeping in mind the purpose of religious life and the particular goals of the Institute.

2) To oversee the observance of the Constitutions; to see to it that the spirit of the Institute of the Incarnate Word is maintained; and to dispense with some point of discipline in particular cases for a reasonable cause and in accordance with the norms established by the major superiors of the Institute of the Incarnate Word.

3) To promote the knowledge and observance of decrees of the Holy See related to religious, or those of interest among the community's religious.

4) To name the second councilor, when possible, and to consult his immediate major superior, and those responsible for the various offices. Those who have been named will be notified, and they will have eight working days to accept or decline the office.

5) To regulate what he deems conducive to the order and service of the household, and whatever leads to the greater good of the family entrusted to his care and concern.

6) To preside over all activities of the house.

7) To resolve grave and urgent cases when it is impossible to appeal to the general or Provincial Superior, and to give an ac-

[349] Cf. CIC, c. 625 § 3.

count of his resolution afterward to the competent major superior, indicating the motives for the resolution in question.

8) To meet with his councilors once a month and whenever necessary for their input, so that he may resolve what he deems more appropriate in the Lord. To be valid, the meeting must be attended by at least two members of the local council.

9) To write the local regulations with his council that will be submitted for approval of the Provincial Superior, except when the regulation must be approved by the Superior General according to proper law.

359. In cases requiring consultation and whenever else he deems it appropriate, he will contact the Provincial Superior. He will also submit to him an accurate report of the state of the house and its members at least every three months. He will also write to the Superior General at least once a year and as many times as he deems it necessary.

ARTICLE 2: LOCAL COUNCILORS

360. The first local councilor is also the vicar and substitutes for the superior during his absence, illness, or other impediment, outside of which he does not have any authority except for what the superior delegates to him. In the vicar's absence, the councilor who is next in line will substitute for the local superior, according to the established order.

361. The second councilor, directly appointed by the local superior, will be the filing clerk responsible for handling and maintaining the house files.

362. A priest will hold the office of local treasurer in each house of the Institute; he will administer the goods of the house under the direction of the local superior. In fulfilling his duties he

will oversee the funds and valuables that belong to the community. The local treasurer administers the goods of the community and is responsible for making ordinary purchases, according to the norms established by the local superior; he will carefully do the bookkeeping, and will give a report to the council of the house every month, every three months to the Provincial Superior, and as requested.

363. Besides possessing the necessary aptitude, those priests appointed for the local council[350] must have taken perpetual vows. They remain in office for a renewable three-year term.

364. Local councilors are obligated to maintain complete confidentiality regarding the matters about which they are consulted. However, they must honestly inform the general or Provincial Superior if required to do so.

[350] Cf. CIC, c. 627 § 1.

PART 9

ADMINISTRATION OF GOODS

365. The goods of the Institute are the goods of the Church. Therefore, their administration must be according to Canon Law, these norms, and the Institute's proper law. The Institute, as a juridical person,[351] has the right to purchase, possess, administer, and sell temporal goods, according to Church Canon law.[352]

366. Ultimately, the Superior General is responsible for all of the Congregation's goods.

367. The Treasurer General, acting under the authority of the Superior General, administers all the goods of the Institute.

368. The respective treasurers administer the goods of the Institute, provinces, and houses under the authority of their immediate superiors, who will be informed of all matters concerning these goods.[353]

369. The treasurers are to provide a regular account from their administration to their corresponding superior.

370. When acquiring assets, any resources consistent with the life of the Institute should be implemented, according to what is determined by the administration's regulations.

371. The Superior General's written consent will be required to validate any act of disposing of or administering goods that has grave significance to the Institute.

372. "Any appearance of luxury, immoderate profit and accumulation of goods is to be avoided."[354]

---

[351] Cf. CIC, c. 113 § 2.
[352] Cf. CIC, cc. 634 § 1; 1255.
[353] Cf. CIC, cc. 668-695.
[354] Cf. CIC, c. 634.

373. Something will be set aside, as means allow, for the needs of the Church and sustenance of the poor.[355]

[355] Cf. CIC, c. 640.

PART 10

SEPARATION FROM THE INSTITUTE

374. The norms of Canon law will be followed in the case of separation from the Institute:

375. Transfer to another Institute: CIC, cc 684-685.

376. Departure from the Institute: CIC, cc 686-693.

377. Dismissal of members: CIC, cc 694-704.

PART 11

OBLIGATION TO OBSERVE THE CONSTITUTIONS

378. All members of the Institute must observe the evangelical counsels with the greatest possible perfection. They must also surrender to Jesus through Mary, and "direct their lives according to the Institute's own law and so strive for the perfection of their state."[356]

379. The Institute's proper law is formed by: the Constitutions handed down by the founder; the Directories containing subsidiary and practical norms, which serve to apply the Constitutions; the Rules and Chapter norms and documents; the executive decisions of the superiors; traditions, good customs, and proper documents.

380. May the Blessed Virgin Mary help us all to reach the Father through the Son in the Holy Spirit.

"God alone."[357]

[356] Cf. CIC, c. 598 § 2.
[357] Dt 32:20.



DIRECTORY OF SPIRITUALITY

CONTENTS

CHAPTER 1 THE MYSTERY OF THE WORD 197
Introduction 197
Article 1: Primacy of Jesus Christ 198
Article 2: Love for the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit . 199
Article 3: Preexistence of the Word 199

CHAPTER 2 THE MYSTERY OF THE INCARNATE WORD 203
Article 1: His First Coming 203
Article 2: His Earthly Life 224
Article 3: His Exit From This World 249
Article 4: His Glorious Life 265
Article 5: His Mystical Life 280
Article 6: His Second Coming 313

CHAPTER 3 EPILOGUE 317

CHAPTER 1
THE MYSTERY OF THE WORD

INTRODUCTION

1. We want to be anchored in the sacrosanct mystery of the Incarnation which is "the first and fundamental mystery of Jesus Christ."[1] Rooted in this mystery that is truly present among us, we want to fervently set out *to restore all things in Christ* (Eph 1:10). We want to be another Incarnation of the Word so as to incarnate Him in all humanity.

2. Our religion "is a doctrine, but is above all an event: the event of the Incarnation, Jesus, the God-Man who recapitulated in himself the universe (Cf. Eph 1:10)."[2] "It is impossible to find an entirely comparable example of the Godhead of Persons and of the mystery of the Incarnation."[3]

3. We always want to draw new light and strength from the redeeming Incarnation, since Jesus Christ is the inexhaustible source of Being, Truth, Kindness, Beauty, Life and Love.

---

[1] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Angelus Message, September 9, 1981; OR (9/13/1981) Spanish Edition.

[2] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily in the Cathedral of Oaxaca, January 29, 1979; OR (2/11/1979) Spanish Edition.

[3] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 2, 6, ad 1.

ARTICLE 1: PRIMACY OF JESUS CHRIST

4. We profess the preeminence of Christ, even as a man, over all creation. He has primacy over the souls and bodies of the members of His mystical Body, and also over all men through all ages. He is the Head of everyone – even of those not predestined to eternal life in heaven with Him, who will only stop being potential members of the Body of Christ when they leave this world. The Son is "the Father's work of art."[4]

5. We profess that Christ is Head of the Church[5] and of all men,[6] and that He has triple primacy over them: a primacy of order, of perfection and of power. He has primacy of order because due to His closeness with God, His grace is the highest and the first – though not chronologically speaking. All who receive grace receive it in reference to His: *For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brethren* (Rom 8:29). He has primacy of perfection because He possesses the fullness of grace: *We have beheld his glory... full of grace and truth* (Jn 1:14). He has primacy of power because He has all the power to communicate grace and glory to all the members of His Body: *And from his fullness have we all received, grace upon grace* (Jn 1:16).

6. Therefore, heresies throughout the ages have had and will have a common denominator: **to diminish the dignity of Jesus Christ**. Saint Leo the Great pointed out: "We are assured that hardly anyone (any heretic) has gone astray except if he has failed to believe the reality of Christ's two natures, and to acknowledge one Person at the same time."[7] Saint Thomas teaches that, "When one considers the errors of heretics, it is apparent that their main

[4] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *De Trinitate VI*, 10 (ML 34,148); cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 59, 1, ad 2.

[5] Cf. Eph 1:22.

[6] Cf. 1 Tm 4:10; 1 Jn 2:2.

[7] SAINT LEO THE GREAT, *Homily on the Nativity*, 8, 4.

objective is to diminish the dignity of Christ."[8] "No other mystery exists outside of Christ."[9] That is why Saint Philip Neri teaches, "Whosoever wants something besides Christ, does not know what he wants. Whosoever wishes for anything but Christ, does not know what he wishes for; whosoever asks for anything but Christ, does not know what he is asking for; whosoever works not for Christ, does not know what he is doing."[10]

ARTICLE 2: LOVE FOR THE FATHER, THE SON, AND THE HOLY SPIRIT

7. Contemplation on the mystery of the Incarnation nurtures love for the Holy Trinity – Father, Son and Holy Spirit – who was the actual author of the Incarnation. This contemplation also ignites in us an ardent love for the Word who "for us men and for our salvation came down from heaven."[11] It also nourishes love for the Word in His preexistence, His entering the world, His earthly life (works and teachings), His leaving the world, His mystical life and His second coming.

ARTICLE 3: PREEXISTENCE OF THE WORD

8. a. Eternal Person. The person of the Word exists from all eternity: *In the beginning was the Word... and the Word was God* (Jn 1:1). By acknowledging the existence of the Word as coming before the Blessed Virgin and the creation of the world, we base our spirituality on the absoluteness of God before whom

[8] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Opuscula Theologica, Contra errores Graecorum*, Vol. I, Ed. Marietti, 1078.

[9] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Epistles*, 187, 34.

[10] SAINT PHILIP NERI, *Lo Spirito di San Filippo Neri nelle sua Massime e Ricordi*, Roma 1988, 7.

[11] COUNCIL OF NICEA I, The Nicene Creed.

everything is like nothing.[12] The exhortation of Saint Cyprian "to prefer nothing whatever to Christ"[13] must always be of prime importance to us. We have to be convinced that "God loves Christ… more than He loves the entire created universe,"[14] and, as Saint Teresa says, "God alone suffices."[15] In everything and for everything, we want to give primacy to the spiritual, and to surrender in holy abandonment to God's "will of good-pleasure," since as a response to the revelation of God, "man freely commits his entire self to God."[16]

9. b. Distinct Person. *And the Word was with God* (Jn 1:1). The Word Incarnate is "the Word that proceeds from silence."[17] The distinction of Persons, the Word from the Father and from the Holy Spirit, moves us to give our whole life a Trinitarian imprint – the supreme mystery of God, the fullness of man and "the substance of the New Testament," in Whom men, by means of the Son-made-flesh, have access to the Father in the Holy Spirit and become *partakers of the divine nature* (2 Pt 1:4). It must be a seal of honor to profess "three Persons equal in majesty, undivided in splendor, yet one Lord, one God."[18]

10. c. Divine Person. *And the Word was God* (Jn 1:1). We recognize in Him the fullness of divinity with all the attributes of the divine being and the divine operations, and that *all things came to be through him, and without him nothing came to be* (Jn 1:3). In a particular way, we want to see ourselves and all men in Him, and to see ourselves created "in the image and likeness of God."[19] "For God and before God, the human being is always unique and

[12] Cf. Is 40:17.

[13] SAINT CYPRIAN, *On the Lord's Prayer*, Chap. XIII-15, CSEL 3, 275-278.

[14] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST I*, 20, 4, ad 1.

[15] SAINT TERESA OF JESUS, Poem "Nada te turbe" Obras Completas, BAC, Madrid 1979, 514. (Translation is ours).

[16] DV 5.

[17] SAINT IGNATIUS OF ANTIOCH, Epistle to the Magnesians, 8, 2.

[18] RM, Preface of the Holy Trinity.

[19] Cf. Gn 1:26.

unrepeatable; somebody thought of and chosen from eternity; someone called and identified by his own name."[20]

[20] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Christmas Message, December 25, 1978; OR (12/31/1978) Spanish Edition.

CHAPTER 2
THE MYSTERY OF THE INCARNATE WORD

ARTICLE 1: HIS FIRST COMING

11. *And the Word became flesh* (Jn 1:14). The work of the Incarnation is shared among the three divine persons, but it is attributed to the Holy Spirit because: **a)** The supreme love of God is the cause of the Incarnation: *For God so loved the world that he gave his only Son* (Jn 3:16). **b)** Human nature was not assumed by our own merit, but only by grace, which is attributed to the Holy Spirit: *Now there are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit* (1 Cor 12:4). **c)** Jesus Christ alone is holy and the only Son of God: *The child to be born will be called holy, the Son of God* (Lk 1:35); and because in Him we are made children of God: *Because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, "Abba! Father!"* (Gal 4:6); in Him we are sanctified, since *He is the Spirit of holiness* (Rom 1:4).

12. Based on the mystery of the Incarnation – the work of the Spirit in the Virgin Mary – we must always sing the mercies of God[21] because "the immortality of blessedness becomes credible from the Incarnation of the Son of God."[22] We must understand clearly that without Jesus Christ, we can do nothing,[23] and that we must always be inclined to grow in virtue with all our strength.

13. Therefore, we must be moved by the Holy Spirit and have utter docility to Him. To obtain this we need:

---

[21] Cf. Ps 89:1.
[22] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *De Trinitate*, 13, 9.
[23] Cf. Jn 15:5.

14. a) Attention to the Holy Spirit's inspirations like the Virgin, who was worthy to be visited by the Angel Gabriel[24] and to listen to him because of her habitual attentiveness to the motions of the Spirit. Therefore, we must work against habitual dissipation, lack of mortification and disordered affections.

15. b) Discernment of spirits in order to accept and follow the motions of the Holy Spirit, and to reject those of the evil spirit. We must be very prudent, in imitation of the Virgin who *considered in her mind what sort of greeting this might be* (Lk 1:29).

16. c) Docility and readiness in the execution of the Holy Spirit's requests, as the Virgin who *arose and went with haste* (Lk 1:39). "Indecision is foreign to the grace of the Holy Spirit."[25] We must always work against the temptation to delay, against the fear to sacrifice and totally surrender, and against the temptation to recover what we have given, seeking compensation or setting our hearts[26] on things that are not of God.

17. Being in tune with the Holy Spirit must move us to live the Beatitudes, to allow ourselves to be led by the gifts of the Spirit acting in us, and to be fertile in producing the fruits of the Spirit: *love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control* (Gal 5:22).

18. We must also consider the "yes" of the Most Holy Virgin: *Let it be done to me according to your word* (Lk 1:38). The Mother of God's consent shows us that she was not "a mere passive instrument, but instead, she freely cooperated with the work of human salvation through faith and obedience."[27] Likewise, neither should we be passive instruments.

---

[24] Cf. Lk 1:28.
[25] SAINT AMBROSE, *Commentary on Saint Luke*, 2, 19.
[26] Cf. SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Spiritual Exercises*, 322.
[27] Cf. LG 56.

19. The Virgin gave her "yes" as a servant: *I am the handmaid of the Lord* (Lk 1:38), *He has looked upon the lowliness of his handmaid* (Lk 1:48), and then the Word took the *form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men* (Phil 2:7) in her pure womb. Therefore, our spirituality needs to be marked in a special way by professing a fourth vow of Marian slavery according to the spirit of Saint Louis-Marie Grignion de Montfort, so as to "marianize" our whole life. When we reach the chapter that speaks about vows, we will discuss our Marian spirituality further.

A. THE DIVINITY OF JESUS

20. Saint Peter's confession has always been central to the Catholic faith: *You are the Christ, the Son of the living God* (Mt 16:16). This confession must be central to our spirituality, too. As taught by the successor of Peter, Blessed John Paul II, "We are only redeemed if Jesus Christ can in his own person fully communicate the divine life."[28] On another occasion, Blessed Pope John Paul II said that when professing *Jesus is Lord* (Rom 10:9),[29] "We break with everything that claims to set itself up as an absolute, and we destroy the idols of money, power, sex, and those [idols] that are hidden in ideologies, 'lay religions' with totalitarian ambitions."[30]

21. He is the "Way" to the Father, and nobody goes to the Father except through Him.[31] His is the only name *by which we must be saved* (Acts 4:12). He is the one that makes the Church a "sacrament – a sign and instrument, that is, of communion with God and of unity among all men."[32] He alone sustains all the Church's dogmas since He is "the truth that contains all the

[28] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the International Theological Commission, October 6, 1981; OR (10/25/1981) Spanish Edition.

[29] Cf. 1 Cor 12:3; Jn 20:28.

[30] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Latin-American Episcopal Conference, July 7, 1980; OR (7/13/1980) Spanish Edition.

[31] Cf. Jn 14:6.

[32] LG 1.

others."[33] He alone reveals to us the primacy and weight of eternity above all temporal reality.

22. In addition, professing the divinity of Jesus Christ must move us to practice the virtues of transcendence: faith, hope and charity; and from practicing these, to the urgency of prayer and incessant contemplation, and to becoming conscious of the need to actively and passively purify the senses and the spirit.

23. In contemplating that the Incarnate Word is "God from God, light from light, true God from true God, begotten, not made, consubstantial with the Father,"[34] we want to put aside all attitudes of mere humanism (humanism without transcendence) that eventually annihilates man. We want to put aside all attitudes of false kenosis (emptying of oneself) that, based on an excuse of turning to that which is inferior, wind up emptying what is superior. "To be in the world" means that a person embraces the spirit of the world by emptying oneself and forgetting that Christians are in the world but *not of the world* (Jn 17:16). By "falling away from God altogether, [man] would cease to exist. For the glory of God is man fully alive; and man's life consists of beholding God."[35]

B. THE HUMANITY OF JESUS

24. Saint John the Baptist foretold Jesus: *After me comes a man* (Jn 1:30); Saint Peter denied Jesus before the servant girl: *I do not know the man* (Mt 26:72); and Pilate presented Him to the crowd: *Ecce homo (Behold the man)* (Jn 19:5). We profess that Jesus is not only God, but also true man, as the centurion did: *Truly this man was the Son of God* (Mk 15:39).

---

[33] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Pontifical Antonianum University, January 16, 1982; OR (1/31/1982) Spanish Edition.

[34] COUNCIL OF NICEA I, The Nicene Creed.

[35] SAINT IRENAEUS, *Against the Heresies*, 4, 20, 7.

25. Becoming man is "the first and fundamental mystery of Jesus Christ."[36] "God had never been so close to man – and never had man been so close to God – as in that very moment: in the instant of the Incarnation mystery!"[37]

26. The Word that not only expresses the Father, but also expresses the being and the work of all creatures,[38] and in particularly of all men, male or female, "manifests man fully, and man discovers himself in the sublimity of his vocation," in such a way that "it is only in the mystery of the Incarnate Word that the mystery of man truly becomes clear."[39]

27. Derived from this, as from its root, is one of the main elements of our spirituality. As Terence said: "I am a man, and nothing human is alien to me."[40] Even more so, due to the Incarnation, nothing genuinely human is alien to us. Therefore, we must work to extend the Incarnation to all reality, specifically evangelizing the culture, because: "No human activity is foreign to the Gospel."[41]

28. For us Christ is mysteriously identified with each man. Each and every man can be comprehended only in Jesus Christ: "It was necessary for mankind that God became man in order to demonstrate the dignity of human nature to mankind."[42] On judgment day He will say: *For I was hungry and you gave me food...* (Mt

---

[36] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Angelus Message, September 6, 1981; OR (9/13/1981) Spanish Edition.

[37] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Angelus Message, August 2, 1981; OR (8/9/1981) Spanish Edition.

[38] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST I*, 34, 3; I-II, 93, 1, ad 2: "And among other things expressed by this Word, the eternal law itself is expressed thereby."

[39] GS 22.

[40] "Homo sum, humani nihil a me alienum puto" *He auton timoroumenos*, v. 77 (Translation is ours).

[41] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily at Mass in Independence Square in Ghana, May 10, 1980; OR (5/25/1980) Spanish Edition.

[42] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, Opuscula Theologica, *Compendium of Theology*, 381.

25:35). The poor are Christ: "They represent the role of the Son of God."[43] The pilgrims are Christ: "Let all guests who arrive be received like Christ."[44] The children are Christ: *Whoever receives one child such as this in my name receives me* (Mt 18:5). In every man, "Jesus is hidden in the depths of his soul."[45] Saint Augustine said: "In Him we are Christs and Christ."[46]

29. All Christians, truly, should live a life in imitation of the Incarnate God. This truth is even greater for us, the religious of the family of the Incarnate Word. Not only are we to live Christ's life looking for God in everything, but we are to spread that life to others, and to endow the cultures of man with Christ's life in order to elevate him: "By his ignorance of the worthiness of his [own] nature, man is misled into clinging to things less than God in nature as to an end."[47]

30. This mysterious and joyful reality of being "other Christs" (central to our spirituality) makes Saint Paul devise the words to express it: *conmortui* (2 Tm 2:11), *consepulti* (Rom 6:14), *conresuscitati* (Eph 2:6), *convivificati* (Eph 2:5), *complantati* (Rom 6:5), *convivemus* (2 Tm 2:11), *consedere* (Eph 2:6). This brings him to exclaim: *It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me* (Gal 2:20). Also, Blessed Elizabeth of the Trinity said so very beautifully that we should be "like a new incarnation of the Word," "like another humanity of Christ," so that the Father may only see "his beloved Son"[48] in us.

31. In principle, we are already Christ by Baptism, but our task is to be Christ in the fullest sense, dying and living, as Saint Paul says: *You also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in*

[43] SAINT VINCENT DE PAUL, *Letters*, 11, 32; ES XI, 725.
[44] SAINT BENEDICT, *Holy Rule*, 53, 1.
[45] SAINT THÉRÈSE OF LISIEUX, *Story of a Soul*, 9.
[46] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Exposition on the Book of Psalms*, 26, 2, 2. CCL 38,154 ff.
[47] CG IV, 54.
[48] BLESSED ELIZABETH OF THE TRINITY, *Elevation* 33. 34. 36.

Christ Jesus (Rom 6:11), and as Saint Peter says: *He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live in righteousness* (1 Pt 2:24).

32. Dying:

- to sin and to the works of the flesh since in Christ *we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace* (Eph 1:7); *those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires* (Gal 5:24);

- to the pain of sin, that is to say, to the evil world: *I have overcome the world* (Jn 16:33), because before *we were enslaved to the elemental powers of the world* (Gal 4:3); and to hell because *at the name of Jesus, every knee should bend, in heaven and on earth and under the earth* (Phil 2:10);

- to the fear of death since the Son of God has become flesh *to deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong bondage* (Heb 2:15);

- to the power of the devil for *the reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil* (1 Jn 3:8);

- to the slavery of the old law: *He redeemed us from the curse of the law* (Gal 3:13).

33. Living:

- the life of grace in its fullness since Christ has come in flesh to bring us life and life in abundance.[49] This life is the grace of God that makes us *partakers of the divine nature* (2 Pt 1:4). It is the supernatural life of the theological virtues, of the instilled moral virtues, and of the gifts of the Holy Spirit.

[49] Cf. Jn 10:10.

- the prophetic life by which we participate in "Christ's prophetic office,"[50] giving testimony of faith and charity, offering a sacrifice of praise to God, proclaiming the Word whether convenient or inconvenient,[51] in preaching, teaching, writing, doing research, in evangelization, in catechesis, etc.

- the priestly life – both the common priesthood derived from baptism, and the ministerial or hierarchical priesthood (different from the common priesthood by essence, and not [merely] by degree).[52]

34. - In addition, we have to live the life of mastery over oneself.

a) A life of mastery includes dominion over oneself: in the measure that man triumphs over sin, he dominates the incentives of the flesh, and governs his soul and body. The religious, in the measure that he subjects his soul completely to God, becomes indifferent and detached from the things of the world. This doesn't imply a powerlessness, but on the contrary, a dominant and free will, able to be devoted to things of the world without being dominated by them.

35. b) A life of mastery includes dominion over people: in the measure that the religious generously surrenders to the service of Jesus Christ – the only King that deserves to be served – he acquires an effective, though spiritual, royalty over men, even over those who have power and authority, and even over those who abuse it. This dominion comes about because the religious takes the burden of their sin and their hardships upon himself, by a humble and helpful love that comes through his self-sacrifice.

---

[50] LG 12.
[51] Cf. 2 Tm 4:2.
[52] Cf. PIUS XII, *Mediator Dei*, 26-27; PO 2.

36. c) A life of mastery also includes dominion over the world:

- By collaborating with the created world through work, and with the redeemed world through apostolate. For this royalty to be effective, there must be a dedication to things, along with a detachment from and an indifference to these same things: *From now on, let those who have wives live as though they had none, and those who mourn as though they were not mourning, and those who rejoice as though they were not rejoicing, and those who buy as though they had no goods, and those who deal with the world as though they had no dealings with it. For the form of this world is passing away* (1 Cor 7:29-31).

- By leaving the world behind, be it for fidelity to the same world (a means and not an end), or by fidelity to God, resisting concupiscence, temptations, and sins of the world; by being indifferent to the maxims, jeers and persecutions of the world, depending only on our good conscience illuminated by faith, ready for martyrdom – the full and total rejection of the evil world – for fidelity to God.

37. The highest grace that God can grant our young Religious Family is persecution[53], especially that persecution that leads to martyrdom. "Jesus Christ always lives in order to give us the strength to support all hardships for His love. The works of God are always under attack so that the Divine Magnificence may shine forth."[54] We must always remember that for persecution to be blessed, it must fulfill two indispensable requirements: first, that we may be "persecuted for the sake of Christ," and second, that what is said against us is false.[55] We must be very careful not to return to our burdens, nor to spend time taking pleasure in them, nor to succumb to the "self-complacency of Lucifer which

[53] *Letter to Diognetus*, 5: "They love all men, and are persecuted by all… those who hate them are unable to assign any reason for their hatred."

[54] SAINT PAUL OF THE CROSS, *Letter 47*.

[55] Cf. SAINT JOHN CHRYSOSTOM, *Homilies on Saint Matthew*, 15, 5.

makes you imagine you are somebody,"[56] and that we are suffering a great deal. "[Our] pride and sensitiveness make [us] magnify splinters into planks, scratches into wounds, molehills into mountains."[57]

38. d) Dominion over the devil: we need religious who are not only convinced that by the grace of God they have the power to resist the devil, but also are able to exorcise the devil.

39. We should live as if we were resurrected: *Seek the things that are above, where Christ is seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth* (Col 3:1-2); we should live in the freedom of the children of God who are not enslaved:

* neither under *the elemental spirits of the universe* (Gal 4:3);
* nor under *the letter that brings death*;[58]
* nor under *the spirit of the world*;[59]

because we must not submit again to the yoke of slavery... (otherwise) Christ would be of no benefit to us.[60]

40. We must be so docile to the Spirit that we could say, "My glory is to live as free as a bird in the sky; I don't make a nest on this earth"; not owing anything to the flesh *for all flesh is like grass and all its glory, like the flower of grass. The grass withers, and the flower falls* (1 Pt 1:24) and *if we live by the Spirit, let us also walk by the Spirit* (Gal 5:25), since *what is born of the flesh is flesh, and what is born of the Spirit is spirit* (Jn 3:6).

---

[56] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *Letter to the Friends of the Cross*, 48.

[57] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *Letter to the Friends of the Cross*, 48.

[58] Cf. 2 Cor 3:6.

[59] Cf. 1 Cor 2:12.

[60] Cf. Gal 5:1-2.

41. This is akin to having *the spirit of a prince*,[61] to guide the soul to great acts, to be concerned about the big things, to carry out great works with absolute virtue. This is to be noble. And what does it mean to be noble? It is a feeling, not a saying. It is a man with heart, a man that has something to give to himself and to others, a man born to lead. Nobles are able to punish themselves and others. They create a style by their conduct. They do not demand freedom but hierarchy. They set laws and fulfill them... They feel honor as life [itself]. They can give themselves because they possess themselves. They know at every instant what one must die for. They are able to give things that no one demands and abstain from things that no one prohibits. They always regard themselves as beginners. Let us always regard ourselves as beginners and seek always and unceasingly to aspire to a holier and more perfect life.

42. Thus, we firmly resolve to reach sanctity. A religious who is not willing to go through the second and third conversions, or who does nothing concrete to achieve them, does not actually belong to our spiritual family, though he may be with us in body. We must have "a great and very resolute determination to persevere until reaching the end, come what may, happen what may, whatever work is involved, whatever criticism arises, whether they [we] arrive or whether they die on the road, or even if they do not have courage for the trials along the way, or if the whole world collapses…."[62] What matters is to take a step, one more step. It is the same step that always begins again.

43. Through baptism, the practice of virtues and religious profession, "deeply rooted in baptismal consecration and a fuller expression of it",[63] we seek to more closely imitate and

[61] Cf. Ps 50:14 [Vulgate version: *et spiritu potenti confirma me*].
[62] SAINT TERESA OF JESUS, *Way of Perfection*, 335, 2.
[63] PC 5; RD 7.

perpetually represent in the Church of the way of life that the Son of God made His own when He became flesh.[64]

44. We want to imitate Jesus Christ as perfectly as possible. He teaches us, *I have given you an example* (Jn 13:15). Saint Paul exhorts, *Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesu*s (Phil 2:5). We must be *the aroma of Christ* (2 Cor 2:15), *ambassadors for Christ* (2 Cor 5:20)... *of the mystery of the Gospel* (Eph 6:19), *[the] letter of Christ* (2 Cor 3:3), *[we must] put on Christ* (Gal 3:27).We must be firmly convinced that we are predestined *to be conformed to the image of his Son* (Rom 8:29), reproducing Him,[65] becoming similar to Him,[66] configuring ourselves to Him,[67] and knowing that we reflect the same image (2 Cor 3:18) of the only Son of God. We want to imitate Him until we can truly say to others, *Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ* (1 Cor 11:1); and, *It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me* (Gal 2:20).

45. The Word assumed human nature. This should move us to practice the virtues of self-denial: humility, poverty, suffering, obedience, self-surrender, mercy and charity to all men.

46. Since the Word became man without ceasing to be God, we must learn how to be in the world[68] "without being of the world."[69] We must go into the world in order to convert it and not to imitate it; to enter cultures not to convert ourselves into these cultures, but to heal them and to elevate them with the strength of the Gospel, doing as Christ did: "The Son took away the devil's nature, assumed human nature, and conferred the divine nature."[70]

---

[64] Cf. LG 44.
[65] Cf. Rom 8:29.
[66] Cf. Phil 3:10.
[67] Cf. Phil 3:21.
[68] Cf. Jn 17:11.
[69] Cf. Jn 17:14-16.
[70] BLESSED ISAAC DE STELLA, *Sermon 11*. ML 194, 1728.

47. Christ became like us *yet without sin* (Heb 4:15). Therefore, sin, error, and all its derivatives are not assumable. Before baptizing, exorcism is necessary; without conversion, reconciliation is impossible and without renouncing evil, redemption does not exist. Unity cannot exist at the cost of truth. There is no holiness without cleansing the soul: "Holiness means cleansing."[71]

48. Only things that have dignity or are necessary can be assumed. Inhuman, antihuman, or infrahuman things cannot be assumed. Likewise, irrational or absurd things, or anything derived from them, cannot be assumed.

49. Since Christ assumed a complete human nature, nothing genuinely human can be rejected. We must assume all that is human because "anything that wasn't taken, was not redeemed,"[72] and anything human that is not assumed "becomes a new idol replete with all the old malicious cunning."[73]

50. Assuming what is human must not only be apparent, but real. The only real assumption is the one that truly transforms what is human into Christ, [thus] elevating it, dignifying it and perfecting it. What is left merely at the human level has only seemingly been assumed.

---

[71] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Treatise about the Priesthood*, 12.

[72] SAINT GREGORY OF NACIANZUS, *Epistles*, 101; MG 37,181; AG 3, footnote 15 "The Holy Fathers constantly proclaim that that which is not assumed by Christ is not healed; cf. SAINT ATHANASIUS, *Epistle to Epictetus*, 7; MG 26,1060; SAINT CYRIL OF JERUSALEM, Catechesis 4,9; MG 33,465; MARIUS VICTORINUS, *Against Arrius* 3,3; ML 8,1101; SAINT BASIL, *Epistle* 261, 2; MG 32,969; SAINT GREGORY NICENE, *Antirrethicus, Against Apollinarius*, 17; MG 45,1156; SAINT AMBROSE, *Epistles*, 48, 5; ML 16,1153; SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Treatise on the Gospel according to John* 23, 6; ML 35,1585; *C. Chr.* 36, 236; moreover, in this way, it manifests that it was not the Holy Spirit who redeemed us because He was not incarnated: *The Agony of Christ*, 22, 24; ML 40,3026; SAINT CYRIL OF ALEXANDRIA, *Against Nestorius I*, 1; MG 76,20; SAINT FULGENTIUS, *Epistles*, 17,3.5; ML 65,454; *To Trasimundus III*, 21; ML 65,284: *De tristitia et timore.*"

[73] DP 400, 469.

51. All this especially applies to the evangelization of the culture, which demands from us a spirituality with unusual nuances. "All this demands a new approach of cultures, attitudes, [and] behaviors aimed at in-depth dialogue with cultural centers and at rendering fruitful their meeting with the message of Christ. This work also demands a faith on the part of responsible Christians that is illumined by continual reflection when confronted with the sources of the Church's message, and a continual spiritual discernment pursued in prayer."[74] "True inculturation is **from within**: it consists, ultimately, of a renewal of life under the influence of grace."[75]

52. Additionally, we must provide spiritual care to women religious because of their own dignity of consecration which makes them "spouses of the Word." In a particular way, women religious resemble Christ's human nature which:

- is totally stripped of itself, without having its own personality;

- is united with the Word in an intimate and perfect union;

- is a most docile instrument of the Word;

- has its riches in giving itself totally to the Word.

53. For love of this Divine Spouse,[76] the woman religious who truly yearns to be the spouse of the Word must:

- Abandon everything – by the three vows she separates all that can obstruct a perfect union with Jesus Christ;

---

[74] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Bishops of Zimbabwe in Ad Limina Visit, July 2, 1988; OR (8/21/1988) Spanish Edition.

[75] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Bishops of Zimbabwe in Ad Limina Visit, July 2, 1988; OR (8/21/1988) Spanish Edition.

[76] Cf. SAINT BERNARD, *Sermons about the Songs of Songs*, 85, 12.

- unite herself with all her strength to the Word – by charity and a stable, firm, and constant fidelity to the will of Jesus Christ, "In the Temple, in the cloister, in the cell, in the dining room, during recreation, [she] must be yearning for Jesus Christ"[77];

- live for Him and allow herself to be guided by Him – she must be zealous for the honor and glory of the Word, her Spouse, and must be able to say as Saint Paul said, *It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me* (Gal 2:20);

- conceive from the Word what she will bear for the Word – since by the Holy Spirit, all her acts must be supernatural, fertile and meritorious.

C. THE UNION OF BOTH NATURES

54. The fullness of the illustrious mystery of the Incarnate Word should be our life's constant inspiration: "The Father as though uttering Himself, begot the Son, equal in all things to Himself. For He would not have uttered Himself completely and perfectly, if there were anything less or more in His Word than in Himself. Here above all do we recognize "*yes, yes; no, no*" (Mt 5:37). And therefore, this Word is truly the Truth."[78]

55. In the Incarnation, the Word anoints with holy unction every cell of Jesus' body, and His entire soul, both in its essence and faculties. There is nothing in Christ that is not thrice holy, and therefore, **infinitely adorable**. Everything in Him is transparency, authenticity, sincerity, coherence and truth: *I am... the Truth* (Jn 14:6). He is the *Amen* (Rev 3:14). *For all the promises of God find their "Yes" in him. That is why we utter the Amen through him, to the glory of God* (2 Cor 1:20), *for in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily* (Col 2:9). In Him there is nothing empty, hollow, or not

[77] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Talk to the Nuns of Saint Clare of Montilla.*
[78] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Holy Trinity*, 15, 14, 23.

assumed hypostatically; there is nothing superficial, feigned or camouflaged; no lie, falsehood, insecurity, secret or hypocrisy. He is One Only,[79] the Word, in two distinct natures; both of which are perfect, whole and hypostatically united.

56. Christ is One without comparison, as Nicholas of Gorran says, "[Oneness] is said of Christ in multiple ways:

- Because of the divine nature, there is only one God; henceforth, there is no God except One.

- He is the only Creator because of His infinite dominion: *There is one most high Creator Almighty* (Sir 1:8; Vulgate).

- He is unique as man because of the singular eminence of His holiness: *There is none that does good* (Ps 14:1), *it is expedient for you that one man should die for the people* (Jn 11:50).

- He is the only Lord because of the preeminence of government: *One Lord, one faith* (Eph 4:5). In the same way there is one Lord, Jesus Christ.

- He is the only Teacher because of the infusion of knowledge: *Neither be called masters, for you have one master, the Christ* (Mt 23:10).

- An only Father because of the creation of all things: *For you have one Father, who is in heaven* (Mt 23:9).

- An only Shepherd because of the common care of the faithful: *So there shall be one flock, one shepherd* (Jn 10:16).

[79] Cf. Rom 5:17.

- An only Victim because of the one-time ransom paid for our Redemption: *For by a single offering he has perfected for all time those who are sanctified* (Heb 10:14)."[80]

57. We profess *our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ* (Jude 4), and that a reference to all creatures is contained in Him. He is the point of meeting and union between the comprehensor and the wayfarer (*comprehensor et viator*); the *Master*[81] and the *slave*[82]; the century and the **moment**; the universe and the atom; the **from-now-on** of salvation and the **up-to-now** of the promises; the not-yet of what we are waiting for and the already-realized. He is the point of meeting and union of God and man, of eschatology and the Incarnation, and of sidereal distances and the inch. For that reason, nothing escapes Christ, neither space travel nor the world of electronics and computers, neither the most current science nor the most sophisticated technology, nor recent discoveries, the family, work, culture, politics, economics, etc. Therefore, we want to live the exhortation of Saint Ignatius of Antioch, "Stop your ears, therefore when anyone speaks to you at variances with Jesus Christ."[83]

58. There is *one Lord, Jesus Christ* (1 Cor 8:6), and therefore we want "to leave no stone unturned so that the love of Christ may have the highest supremacy in the Church and society."[84]

59. Because Christ is One, we want to work with all our strength to build our life in union with legitimate Shepherds, most especially with a cordial fidelity with the Bishop of Rome, bearing witness to the one Church:

---

[80] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on the First Epistle of Saint Paul to the Corinthians*, 8, 2.

[81] Cf. 2 Tm 2:21.

[82] Cf. Phil 2:7.

[83] SAINT IGNATIUS OF ANTIOCH, *Epistle to the Trallians*, 9, 1.

[84] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to Episcopal Conference of Tuscany, September 14, 1980; OR (9/21/1980) Spanish Edition.

- so that all Christians may arrive at perfect unity, to fulfill the promise and prophecy of the Lord: *So there shall be one flock, one shepherd* (Jn 10:16); and that His prayer would bear fruit: *that they may all be one* (Jn 17:21). This is the ecumenical work.

- so that all men may confess the adorable Name of the Lord Jesus, fulfilling His commandment: *Go into all the world and preach the gospel to the whole creation* (Mk 16:15). This is the missionary work. We must remember that "it is above all in truth that unity is built: the communion of minds is easily transformed into the union of hearts..."[85]

60. Only in the truth will we be able to live the ineffable reality that Saint John Eudes expresses: "All of his is yours: the Spirit, the heart, the body, and the soul and all their faculties... all that there is in you must be grafted into him... he must be your spirit, your heart, your love, your life, and all of yours."[86]

61. The two natures of the Incarnate Word, entire and perfect, remind us of the double reality of the created – supernatural and natural – and therefore, of the real distinction between grace and nature, faith and reason, Church and world. These must not be confused, changed, mixed, absorbed, or submerged. One must not confuse the human with the divine, which is a kind of blending with which Christian understanding should not be concerned. The two natures move us to the practice of seemingly opposed virtues and to the avoidance of all false Gnostic monism, for example, justice vs. love, firmness vs. sweetness, fortitude vs. meekness, holy anger vs. patience, purity vs. great affection, magnanimity vs. humility, prudence vs. courage, joy vs. penance, etc. Great sanctity is the eminent union of all the virtues, even the most diverse.

---

[85] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Meeting with Clergy and Religious in Fatima, May 13, 1982; OR (5/23/1982) Spanish Edition.

[86] SAINT JOHN EUDES, *Treatise about the Sacred Heart of Jesus*, 1, 5.

62. Both natures, while conserving their properties, are united substantially in the person of the Word; therefore, there is no place for false dualisms or destructive dialectics that seek to divide, separate and oppose grace and nature, faith and reason, Church and world. These are realities that must not be destructively opposed, but united in an orderly fashion. The two natures compel us to avoid compromising either our spiritual life or pastoral life, and to avoid emphasizing any element over another, thus avoiding all duality, penetrating one's entire life with the Truth, being "amen" of the "Amen."[87]

63. We must also be careful not to succumb to Manichean visions of reality, or to Jansenistic reductionism. We must see to it that the legitimate and just autonomy of the temporal and the spiritual do not degenerate into independence from God: "Without a creator, there can be no creature."[88] Atheism is "the most grave phenomenon of our time."[89]

64. Undoubtedly, God assumes a human nature, and not the other way around. Likewise, this is how it should be throughout our life: we should always give primacy to God over the world, to grace over nature and to faith over reason: "In the priority of ethics over technology, in the primacy of the person over things, and in the superiority of the spirit over matter."[90] Just as the two natures in Christ are ordered, so all reality must be assigned a hierarchical subordination between the supernatural and natural orders. He is the One who gives us the law that directs the relationship between both orders. Indeed, God heals and elevates man, not the other way around. Faith purifies and perfects reason, not the other way around. The Church heals and saves the world, not the other way around. The inversion of values that affects

[87] Cf. Rev 3:14.
[88] GS 36.
[89] ES 37.
[90] RH 16.

modern culture is another problem of our time. We must give greater importance to this problem than what is currently mainstream, and seek first what is primary: *Seek first his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things shall be yours as well* (Mt 6:33).

65. Likewise, the mystery of the Incarnation is not a mere union of divine nature with human nature, but rather, it is a union of assumption.[91] Any other way of uniting God and creature is insufficient *to unite all things in him* (Eph 1:10), but, analogous to the mystery of the Incarnation, the union must be an assumption, i.e., there must be both an action and a passion that expresses becoming not only the final result, but that also expresses the distinct relation to each one of the terms of origin and of end. Likewise we must "assume" the cultures we live in, purifying them and elevating them, starting from Christ and the Gospel "within the framework of the Church."[92] When Christ truly takes possession of reality, it is not merely a superficial union with the world, nor a label that is placed on it. "Being in the world" only makes sense when it depends on "not being of the world." This is the only way to be truly *salt of the earth and light of the world* (Mt 5:13ff); otherwise, we would become tasteless salt, and light under a bushel basket.

D. THE PURPOSE OF THE INCARNATION

66. The ultimate and absolute purpose of the Incarnation is the glory of God. The mediate purpose is the exaltation and glory of Christ, the Redeemer of man. The immediate purpose is the redemption of mankind. With this in mind, we always want to seek the glory of God, the ultimate end of the entire universe, in everything and for everything – and in a particular way, in the search, investigation, proclamation, and celebration of the truth,

[91] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 2, 8.

[92] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Council of "Equipes Notre-Dame", September 17, 1979; OR (9/30/1979) Spanish Edition.

because we follow the Word that says: *I am the Truth* (Jn 14:6), because it is the "Truth…the final end of the whole universe"[93] and this is why Jesus Christ became man: *For this, I have come into the world, to bear witness to the truth* (Jn 18:37). It is primarily truth that gives clear knowledge of and praise to God.

67. A particular way of giving glory to God is by infinitely trusting in His Providence, based upon His design of salvation, that manifests itself most eminently in the Incarnation. We must learn to look at everything as having come from The One who doesn't even forget a sparrow... and who has even counted the hairs on our head.[94] For that reason Saint Paul teaches *that all things work for good for those who love God* (Rom 8:28). When he says "*everything*", he leaves nothing out. This includes every situation, whether prosperous or adverse; whether concerning the good of the soul, goods of fortune or reputation. This "*everything*" further includes all conditions of human life (family, study, talents, etc.), all interior states we experience (joys, happiness, deprivations, dryness, displeasures, tediousness, temptations, etc.), even faults and sins. It includes everything, absolutely everything. When Saint Paul says "*works for good*," it is understood that everything cooperates, contributes, and happens for our spiritual good. We must have this vision, and not that of the flesh or the world. We must see everything in light of the loving designs of God's Providence that are only discovered by the spiritual man: *The spiritual man judges all things* (1 Cor 2:15). We must believe with unyielding steadfastness that even the most adverse events, those most opposed to our natural view, are arranged by God for our own good, even though we don't understand His designs, and we ignore the end that He wants to bring us to. Yet for this to happen, we must fulfill a condition on our end, and this is why he adds "*those that love Him*": those whose will is united and submissive to God's, those who strive above all for the interests

[93] CG I, 1.
[94] Cf. Lk 12:6-7.

and glory of God, who are willing to sacrifice everything without reservation and are convinced that nothing is as advantageous as abandoning themselves into the hands of God, in anything He may deign to order, as Jesus showed us: *If any one serves me, the Father will honor him* (Jn 12:26). He alone knows everything, including our souls, our feelings, our characters, the hidden desires that must be changed in order to bring us to heaven, and He knows the effects that this or that will cause in us, and He has all the means at His disposal. If we love God, it is impossible for anything in the world not to coincide with, or contribute to, our own good.

68. We want to tend toward the sanctification and salvation of men, our brothers. Jesus Christ came into the world "for us men." Therefore, "all man, the whole man and all men,"[95] and in a preferential way – yet without discrimination – the ones who are more in need must be the object of our love and service. Like the incarnate and crucified Word, we must have "thirst for souls." We must concretely love the man who is materially or spiritually needy, and never use him as demagogic propaganda. We follow the One who inspired Saint John to say: *God is love* (1 Jn 4:8).

ARTICLE 2: HIS EARTHLY LIFE

69. Christ's entire life should be a source of spirituality for us: "He wanted to foreshadow us in His body, in His own body."[96]

A. ON BECOMING FLESH

70. At the moment when the Father *brings the firstborn into the world* (Heb 1:6) the sublime priestly consecration of Jesus Christ, by which he is marked and anointed forever, takes place: *Therefore*

[95] Cf. RH 13-18.
[96] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Writings about the Psalms*, 60, 3.

God, your God, has anointed you with the oil of gladness beyond your comrades (Heb 1:9). He is Supreme and Eternal Priest,[97] the only Mediator between heaven and earth.

71. At that moment His soul contemplated the Father's infinite majesty, and He experienced "the incomprehensible infinity of… [His] perfections."[98] At the same time, He contemplated the enormity of the offense made to God – in a certain way infinite – by the sins of all men from all times, and the inadequacy of the victims offered until that moment. He experienced that the Father had made Him priest and victim – for which He had to become flesh. The impulse of His unspeakable love made a sovereign priestly act, as He surrendered entirely to the Father's will.[99]

72. That first priestly act of Christ's sacred soul at the moment of His Incarnation and priestly ordination was never lessened or retracted. It remains forever in His priestly heart. It is present during His childhood, His hidden and public life, at the Last Supper, on Calvary and in His resurrection and ascension. Now Christ, dwelling in the heavenly Jerusalem, is reminded of this first priestly act by His five precious wounds. That priestly act was the prelude to His redeeming sacrifice on the Cross and all the acts of His priesthood in Heaven: ... *when Christ came into the world he said, "... a body you have prepared for me... Behold, I come to do your will, O God..."* (Heb 10:5-7). He recognizes the Father's supreme dominion; He offers Himself without restriction as a victim to the Father; He sacrifices Himself in atonement; He surrenders Himself to the Father without reservation.

73. Such should be the priestly attitude of all members of our small Religious Family. By baptism all *are built into a spiritual house,*

---

[97] Cf. Heb 5:5.
[98] SAINT FRANCIS DE SALES, *Treatise about the Love of God*, 5, 6.
[99] Cf. Heb 10:7.

to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ (1 Pt 2:5). Everyone, even our secular brothers, are *a royal priesthood* (1 Pt 2:9), because they "are united to Him and to his sacrifice."[100] Those bound by religious vows are likewise united "to Him and to his sacrifice" and should totally surrender to God through a deeper commitment, just as those who exercise the ministerial priesthood should through Holy Orders. All members of the Institute should perfect themselves, being in Christ "an eternal offering" for God,[101] and "a living and perfect victim to praise your glory."[102] This is the priestly attitude proper to the "third man" of the Spiritual Exercises of Saint Ignatius of Loyola.[103] It is man's answer to God's revelation: "by faith man freely commits his entire self to God."[104] One must live this attitude permanently, without diminution or retraction, without reserve or condition, without subterfuge or delay, without retreating or even slowness. In both personal matters and in great historical endeavors, it's impossible to build an empire if one cannot set fire to his ship after disembarking.

74. In the sublime moment of the Incarnation, Christ gives us an illustrious example of the practice of mortifying virtues to a profound degree. Without ceasing to be the infinite God, He became a finite man, showing us infinite humility, poverty, obedience and love.

75. The incarnation is an example of humility: *though he was in the form of God, he did not count equality with God... he humbled himself...* (Phil 2:6-8), *and taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men* (Phil 2:7). Without ceasing to be God, He manifests the utmost humiliation within Himself – He emptied himself (Phil

100 ChL 14.

101 Cf. RM, Eucharistic Prayer III.

102 RM, Eucharistic Prayer IV. (Translation taken from the Roman Missal Spanish Edition).

103 Cf. SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Spiritual Exercises*, 155; 157

104 DV 5.

2:7) – even as a man. He manifests an immeasurable humility in his human judgment – internal and external. His humanity acknowledged that everything it had was from God. Seeing such great humility, we should learn how to regard others as superiors, *each of you look not only to his own interests, but also to the interests of others* (Phil 2:4).[105] We must continually consider the inexhaustible treasure of the virtues of Jesus' hypostatic Heart. To contemplate incessantly this rich wellspring should be the badge of honor and the distinctive sign of our Institute.

76. We must follow the Most Holy Virgin Mary's example of faith in the Incarnation: *Blessed is she who believed...* (Lk 1:45) *We shall live by faith*;[106] a living, firm, unshaken, eminent, heroic faith; a faith convinced that God would not be God if we were capable of grasping Him with our limited intelligence or if we understood all His judgments and ways; a faith in absolute harmony with the doctrine proposed by the Catholic Church, even in the smallest details, molded with the strictest docility to the directives and teachings of the Pope; a faith full of promptness to reject error even perceived through the weakest appearances, full of ardent zeal to spread the faith, but without bitterness and harshness; a penetrating faith that sees all things by the light of revelation – *sub specie aeternitatis*, that elevates the soul to the supernatural plans of God and allows us to consider ourselves "worthy of all afflictions"[107]; an heroic faith – like the faith of the saints of the Old Testament[108] – that triumphs over the world and over evil;[109] that is able to build great things; that illuminates life and gives it meaning; one that strengthens, encourages, comforts, and casts out fear: *It is I, have no fear* (Mk 6:50). Cowards die many times before their death.

---

105 Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 161, 3.
106 Cf. Heb 10:38.
107 SAINT CATHERINE OF SIENA, *The Dialogue*, 100.
108 Cf. Heb 11:1ff.
109 Cf. 1 Jn 5:4.

77. In the Incarnation, Mary is an example of other virtues: humility, *She was greatly troubled at the saying* (Lk 1:29); she proclaimed herself humble:[110] *and exalted those of low degree* (Lk 1:52); prudence: … *[She] considered in her mind what sort of greeting this might be* (Lk 1:29); Purity: *How shall this be, since I have no husband?* (Lk 1:34); abandonment to God: *Behold, I am the handmaid of the Lord* (Lk 1:38). In Mary we must find strength to permanently rediscover the Christian and priestly life as fidelity to the faith of mystery and miracle, of martyrdom and mercy, of "Magnificat" and magnanimity: mystery: therein the Trinity is revealed: ...*the Lord God... Son of the Most High... The Holy Spirit...* (Lk 1:32-35); the Incarnate Word: *Let it be to me according to your word* (Lk 1:38); miracle: …*and behold, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son* (Lk 1:31); martyrdom: *is set for the fall and rising… for a sign that is spoken against… and a sword will pierce through your own soul also* (Lk 2:34-35); mercy: *For God so loved the world that he gave his only Son* (Jn 3:16); *and you shall call his name Jesus* (Lk 1:31); *for he will save his people from their sins* (Mt 1:21); *his mercy is on those who fear him from generation to generation...* (Lk 1:50-51); "Magnificat": *My soul magnifies the Lord* (Lk 1:46); and the angels praise God saying: *Glory to God in the highest...* (Lk 2:14); magnanimity: *for he who is mighty has done great things for me* (Lk 1:49).

78. We could say that our spirituality should be the spirituality of the Hail Mary, the Angelus, the hymn of kenosis,[111] the Magnificat and the Gloria.

B. IN THE WOMB OF THE VIRGIN

79. We must learn to be enclosed with Christ in Mary's womb, where, at the moment of Incarnation, we were included. Christ morally assumes the flesh of all. In Mary's womb He

[110] Cf. Lk. 1:48.
[111] Cf. Phil 2:6ff.

physically took her flesh, and **morally** took the flesh of us all in such a way that we too were conceived in the most pure womb of Mary. Therefore, she is our true and proper spiritual Mother. "We have issued forth from Mary's womb like a body united to its head."[112]

80. We can never insist enough on this mysterious and ineffable reality of our union with Christ by the principle of *koinonia* – solidarity or communion – by which we are recapitulated and concentrated in Him, since He assumed the representation, the responsibility and the destination of all men in Himself. At the moment of the Incarnation this intimate mutual union and identification of Christ with each one of us make us children of God *in radice*, forming a unique and compact whole with the Incarnate Word: we are sons in the Son – *filii in Filio*. "[Christ]… became the Son of man in order that we might have the power to be the sons of God."[113] "[Christ] to whom all are united, as members to a head, who constitute one mystical person."[114]

81. In addition to men, all things meet, converge, shake hands, unite, epitomize each other and are based in the Word-made-flesh: … *recapitulating all things… in the Alpha and the Omega.*[115]

82. For nine months the Virgin was the tabernacle that protected Jesus, just as for almost two thousand years she has been the monstrance that reveals Him to the world. One task is no less important than the other.

83. In her womb God took on human form, and so Saint Augustine called her *forma Dei*.[116] Likewise, by consecrating

---

[112] SAINT PIUS X, *Ad diem illum laetissimum*, 5.
[113] SAINT LEO THE GREAT, *Sermon on the Feast of the Nativity*, 6, 2.
[114] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 19, 4; cf. 48, 1.
[115] Cf. Eph 1:10; Rev 1:8.

ourselves as slaves of the Virgin, we want – in the likeness of Jesus – "to enter into the womb of our Mother and be born again."[117] To consecrate ourselves to Jesus through Mary is to follow the way that He followed coming into the world: the way that He uses and will always use.[118]

84. In the womb, Jesus taught us to depend totally and completely on God through Mary. At the same time, Mary taught us the evangelical ministry of visitation. By "carrying Him Who carried her,"[119] she taught us that all our apostolic enthusiasm is to be founded in Him; she taught us to accomplish the things of God quickly;[120] she taught us to serve our neighbor even in the simplest of tasks; she taught us to praise, thank, sing and be joyful in the Almighty, Holy, Merciful, Saving and Faithful God, because God "looked upon" her and did "great things" – the Incarnation – in her, deploying His power, scattering the proud, casting down the mighty, filling the hungry, lifting up the lowly and protecting His servants forever.

C. CHILDHOOD

85. Among other things, the birth of the Incarnate Word urges us to strictly live holy poverty since whoever has God is extremely rich. It also urges us to live in joy – a fruit of the Holy Spirit and a consequence of the Incarnation – as the angel announced to the shepherds: *I bring you good news of a great joy which will come to all the people* (Lk 2:10). This is the joy of the Virgin Mary, the "cause of our joy"; *rejoice, Mary* (Lk 1:28) said the angel

---

[116] Quoted by SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, in *The Secret of Mary*, 16, 267.

[117] Cf. Jn 3:4.

[118] Cf. SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *The Secret of Mary*, 58; *TD*, 50.

[119] SAINT BERNARD, *Sunday Sermon within the Octave of the Ascension of the Blessed Virgin Mary*, 9.

[120] Cf. Lk 1:39.

Gabriel. She herself, with great docility, proclaimed: *My spirit rejoices in God my Savior* (Lk 1:47). Therefore, all generations have called her and will call her *blessed* (Lk 1:48) – happy to a sublime degree.

86. The mystery of the Incarnate Word's birth urges us to work in the most difficult places – those where no one else wants to go – and when it is impossible to continue working there, we should spend a night in prayer before Jesus in the Blessed Sacrament, and then ask the Bishop to send us somewhere even worse.

87. From the Epiphany we must extract spiritual light so as to dedicate our entire lives to revealing Christ to the world, so that He may be recognized not only by the poor, but also by the rich; not only by the ignorant, but also by the wise; not only by those in our homeland, but also by those in other countries. We should not ensnare ourselves in false reductionist dialectics where we discriminate against others (i.e. the rich, the intellectuals, the foreigners or strangers, etc.), where we worry exclusively about a certain people or place – narcissistic localism – because the Spirit *blows where it wills* (Jn 3:8). Our field of action has no horizons, but rather, is the whole world, as Jesus said, *Go into all the world...* (Mk 16:15).

88. From the mystery of the Finding of Jesus in the Temple, we want to learn how to be steadfast and faithful to the call, to the vocation, over and above any other earthly demands: *Did you not know that I must be in my Father's house* (Lk 2:49)? We also want to learn how to better fulfill the will of God each time, in a way that is: **- more universal in its object:** fulfilling God's will in all its manifested forms: whether it be when God commands: commandments, precepts, laws, etc.; whether it be when He counsels: inspirations, one's vocation, evangelical counsels, etc.; whether it be when He manifests Himself by events – signified

will; **- more exact in its execution:** not being satisfied with merely a material fulfillment, but also taking care of the details (God loves us with a specific and particular love, and we must respond in a specific and particular way); **- more supernatural in its motives:** our intentions must be purer by doing things only because God wills them; **- more perfect in the disposition with which we fulfill it**: not doing God's will out of worldly fear, or selfish or temporal interest, but out of pure love, showing Him that we love Him and only want to please Him.

89. His example moves us to love theological science, to have a true sense of the salvation dialogue – "Apostolic dialogue **begins from faith** and presupposes a firm Christian identity"[121] – to devote oneself to the Father and to have a deep spirit of piety.

D. HIDDEN LIFE

90. Jesus' example in His hidden life is equally important for our spirituality. All preparation time is very important for us; it is not wasted time, when one makes good use of it; it is not time that we must pass through quickly; it is not a necessary evil. The future of an individual brother in religious life and, therefore, of the Institute as a whole, depends fundamentally on the formation that is given during the time of preparation: postulancy, novitiate, seminary, further studies and ongoing formation. Therefore, good doctrine is not enough. We need "teachers" who are very spiritual and have a clear intention of making a very rigorous selection of candidates. This is extremely important in order to maintain the good spirit of the community. When choosing, it is better to err on the side of excess rather than deficiency.

91. In likeness to Jesus' hidden life, the following should stand out in the candidates during the time of formation: a

[121] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Meeting with Representatives of Lay Apostolate in Liege, May 19, 1985; OR (6/23/1985) Spanish Edition.

longing for inner growth; a love for fruitful silence; a wholehearted commitment to intellectual and material work; a fulfillment of one's duty until the end; a spirit of subjection[122] along with responsibility, readiness and maturity; an ability to live in an atmosphere of festive joy.[123]

92. The soul needs silence in order to most deeply manifest that in the presence of God, there is nothing more to say. Silence is a way to achieve union with God, and brings one to the summit of prayer. Seeking quiet allows one to converse with God, who brings the soul to the desert so as to speak to the heart.[124]

93. Just as the Word chose to live in the silence of Nazareth for thirty years, some of our members consecrate themselves to Him in the contemplative state. They desire to dedicate themselves to the only necessary thing; they have chosen the best part.[125] "How beautiful is contemplative life to the eyes of God and the Church! It constitutes one of the fundamental structures of the Holy Church. It has been present in all the phases of its history – for two millennia, always fertile in solid virtues, always endowed with a mysterious and powerful attractiveness in the highest and most noble souls."[126] Therefore, contemplatives are on the front lines of all the Institute's apostolic works, since with their prayer life and penance, they obtain from the Lord the necessary graces for the salvation of many souls: "Institutes of contemplative life, by their prayers and trials, are of the greatest importance in the conversion of souls since it is in answer to prayer that God sends workers into His harvest, opens the minds of non-Christians to hear the Gospel, and makes fruitful the word

---

[122] Cf. Lk 2:51.

[123] Cf. Lk 2:42.

[124] Cf. Hos 2:16.

[125] Cf. Lk 10:41.

[126] BLESSED JOHN XXIII, Discourse to the Students of the Trappist International School, October 21, 1960.

of salvation in their hearts."[127] The following words of Saint Teresa apply to the contemplatives: "[T]he Lord… has brought you together here for that very purpose [salvation of souls]. This is your vocation; this must be your business; these must be your desires; these your tears; these your petitions… If your prayers and desires and disciplines and fasts are not performed for the intentions of which I have spoken, reflect [and believe] that you are not carrying out the work or fulfilling the object for which the Lord has brought you here."[128] Our monasteries of contemplative life should be magnets of God's grace and lightning rods for His wrath. God willing, we will be able to multiply them all over the world! "The Church and the world... need... a small ideal society where as a goal all the following reign: love, obedience, innocence, freedom from things and the art of its good use, the prevalence of the spirit, peace, – in a word – the Gospel."[129]

E. PUBLIC LIFE

94. It is impossible to summarize all that Jesus Christ taught us with His life and doctrine – the source for all Christian spirituality. We now want to point out some aspects of the spirituality of our small Religious Family inspired by the great examples of our Savior and Redeemer. However, the following list is by no means exhaustive.

Baptism

95. Christ was baptized by John so that baptism would be consecrated by Christ.[130] The whole theological depth of our baptismal birth and our religious profession – "deeply rooted in

[127] AG 40.

[128] SAINT TERESA OF JESUS, *Way of Perfection*, 1, 4-5; 3, 10.

[129] PAUL VI, Discourse after the Consecration of the Abbey of Montecassino, October 24, 1964.

[130] Cf. SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Gospel of Saint John*, 5.

their baptismal consecration […] a fuller expression of it"[131] – is known only in the light of the Lord's baptism.

96. Christ's baptism reminds us that we must unceasingly surrender ourselves to: the Father, who in the Son has said to us: *This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased* (Mt 3:17); the Son, from whom we are made disciples and through whom we call ourselves **Christians**;[132] the Holy Spirit, who descended upon us in the Son *in bodily form, as a dove* (Lk 3:22). And all of this was accomplished sacramentally in us on the day of our baptism.

97. The mystery of Jesus' Baptism reminds us of the serious obligation we have to remain faithful to our baptismal promises, by which we profess the Holy Catholic faith and pledge ourselves to renounce the devil. It also reminds us of our serious obligation to remain faithful to the promises of religious profession.

98. It must also be an incentive to fully live the virtue of humility, since Jesus did not shirk from being thought of as another sinner. He wanted "to purify the waters and, cleansed by the contact with the flesh of Christ, that didn't know sin, they had the virtue of baptizing";[133] and "he left them sanctified for those that then had to be baptized";[134] at the same time, he left us an example of how to practice the virtue of justice: ...*It is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness* (Mt 3:15).

Fasting

99. The practice of penance, essential to the Christian life, must also be essential in our spirituality: *Unless you repent you will all likewise perish* (Lk 13:3); especially internal penance – *metanoia*[135] –

131 PC 5.
132 Cf. Acts 11:26.
133 SAINT AMBROSE, *Commentary to Saint Luke*, 2, 21.
134 PSEUDO-CHRYSOSTOM, *Homilies on the Gospel of Matthew*, 4. MG 56,657.
135 Cf. Mk 1:15.

the intimate, total change and renewal of the whole man in all his feelings, judgments and tendencies.

100. In the mystery of Christ we can see both the sanctity of God and the gravity of sin.[136] By His word we are invited to conversion and to receive pardon from sin, gifts that we receive fully in baptism and which we must "embody" by denying ourselves, carrying our cross and participating in the sufferings of Christ.

101. The holy sacrament of Reconciliation or Penance holds a preeminent place in the spiritual life of our small Religious Family. We therefore advise that one receive the sacrament weekly. We should be devoted to frequent confession, since many fruits come from it: "By it [Reconciliation] genuine self-knowledge is increased, Christian humility grows, bad habits are corrected, spiritual neglect and tepidity are resisted, the conscience is purified, the will strengthened, a salutary self-control [of the conscience] is attained, and grace is increased in virtue of the Sacrament itself."[137]

102. We must also greatly appreciate external penance with regard to: eating and drinking, sleeping, "inflict[ing] sensitive pain on [the flesh]"[138] by means of cilices,[139] self-flagellation, etc. The fact that penance has primarily an interior and religious character does not exclude or attenuate the external practice of such virtue in any way, but rather encourages it all the more. The norms given by Saint Ignatius should regulate its practice.[140]

---

136 Cf. Lk 5:8; 7:36-50.
137 PIUS XII, *Mystici Corporis Christi*, 88.
138 SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Spiritual Exercises*, 85.
139 Cf. Lv 16:31.
140 Cf. SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Spiritual Exercises*, 82-89.

103. According to the precept of our Holy Mother Church,[141] the penitential days and seasons of Advent and Lent should always be paramount. During those times the religious must especially devote himself to prayer, to the practice of charity and piety, to denying oneself, to a better fulfillment of his duties, etc.

104. The example of Our Lord withdrawing into the desert for forty days should lead us to highly value the practice of the spiritual exercises, especially those of Saint Ignatius of Loyola, and the typical thirty-day exercises given at the end of the novitiate and every ten years thereafter. Also, making the annual eight-day spiritual exercises is laudable. We also believe that the monthly retreat is highly important.

105. This clear understanding of the irreplaceable value of the Spiritual Exercises for the renewal of Christian life – teaching each person to conquer himself and to arrange his own life according to God's order – should bring us to know the Exercises deeply, to prepare ourselves to preach them fruitfully, and to have the necessary disposition so as not to miss any opportunity to preach them.

Temptations

106. The Lord's example while enduring the devil's attacks in the desert will forever be an inexhaustible source of encouragement for religious. Wanting to give us strength against temptations, He conquered "our temptations with his,"[142] so that no one would think He is free from temptations, despite His holiness: *My son, if you come forward to serve the Lord, prepare yourself for temptation* (Eccl 2:1). His example teaches how firmly, quickly and righteously we must conquer the temptations of the devil: "The

[141] Cf. CIC, cc. 1249 ff.
[142] SAINT GREGORY THE GREAT, *Homilies on the Gospels*, 16, 1.

devil is conquered… by righteousness, not by power."[143] His example also teaches us to trust in His mercy more: *For we have not a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin* (Heb 4:15). Since "the matter of all sin"[144] is found in three temptations, religious, by their three vows, totally oppose all sin and all temptations that lead to sin. All temptations can be summarized in the three Our Lord experienced. In our opposition to sin, we make a fourth vow – slavery to the Virgin Mary – by which we take her side in that enmity created by God: *I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your seed and her seed; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel...* (Gn 3:15).

107. It does no good to be frightened or concerned by big and grievous temptations, for two reasons: 1st. "The whole Christ was tempted by the devil since in Him you are tempted… [Recognize] yourself tempted in Him and also recognize yourself victorious in Him… our progress is carried out by means of temptation, and nobody can know oneself if he is not tempted, nor be crowned if he has not conquered, neither can he conquer if he has not struggled, neither can he struggle if he lacks an enemy and temptations";[145] 2nd. No temptation has overtaken you that is not common to man. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your strength, but with the temptation will also provide the way of escape, that you may be able to endure it (1 Cor 10:13).

108. It is worth being mindful of some of the most common states-of-temptation that we notice among ourselves, that can cause damage to our spiritual and pastoral life. Among these are: the **egocentric** priest who looks for human glory, looking to

[143] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Holy Trinity*, 13, 14, 18.
[144] SAINT AMBROSE, *Commentary on Saint Luke*, 4, 35.
[145] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Expositions on the book of Psalms*, 60, 3.

please men more than God.[146] He worries only about what affects him personally. He is envious, especially when young priests are more gifted than he. The **clerk** priest has a spirit of a bureaucrat. He multiplies the red tape and places mounting requirements on people, whom he sees as customers, for the reception of Church sacraments and services. He thinks he is obedient because he fulfills the formalities, yet he doesn't set ablaze, nor is he himself ablaze, with the fire of the Holy Spirit. He doesn't know about taking risks for Christ. He is not creative and does not embark upon new apostolates. He doesn't make things happen. He doesn't realize that the priest should be a poet and an artisan. The **petty** priest does the least possible with the excuse of not falling into over-activity, or because "we live in bad times," or because the family doesn't raise children as it used to, or because of the "unhealthy action of the media." He only knows how to complain: "There's nothing you can do." The **fickle** priest begins many things but never finishes any of them. The **boring** priest: he is as orthodox as he is boring. He has the strange ability to make the truth boring. The bottom line is that he does not have love: "The soul that walks in love doesn't tire, nor does it grow tired."[147] The **improviser** priest does everything without foresight. He does not prepare sermons. He has no goals; when he does, he doesn't know how to use available resources. He does not think about how to achieve anything. He is unable to do pastoral planning. He is disorganized and lacks self-mastery. He ends up being irresponsible. He does not fulfill his promises. He does not know how to prioritize or choose ministries. The **frivolous** priest trivializes everything – all is superficial for him. He thinks he is smart. He does not respect the essences of things. He has to touch everything. He lacks self-mastery and ignores hierarchies. He delights in being the "hip one," especially with female youth. He is incurably childish and superficial. The **glum**

[146] Cf. Gal 1:10.

[147] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Maxims on Love*, 18.

priest sees everything as serious. He is always distant, inaccessible and tense. He does not know how to laugh. He finds all healthy distraction a frivolity. A bad word sounds like a serious sin for him, and eutrapelia is not a virtue. By seeing the tree, he forsakes the forest, and he usually makes "tempests in teapots." The **mediocre** priest excuses himself under a false pretext, considering himself "middle of the road." All magnanimity seems prideful to him. He finds all heroism extreme, all generosity exaggeration. He makes everything mediocre – be it retreats, camping trips, mission-outreaches, catechesis, even his own spiritual life, etc. The **localist** priest worries only about his immediate world. He lives buried in his little works, and has a "ghetto spirit." It seems like the Church ends at his parish, city, state, or country. If he is a diocesan clergy member, he thinks it is a sin if a young person wants to be a religious. If he is a religious priest, he suffers if someone wants to enter a congregation other than his own. He does not understand that the Church is "missionary by her very nature."[148] His only problems concern the associate pastor, the little old woman, the neighboring parish priest or his own bishop. He does not see "the invasion of sects"[149] as a problem, nor militant atheism, nor the dechristianization of the culture. The **affected** priest. He is all elegant and clean, a lovely thing; but everything is an external show: he focuses only on details. This is his "world." He lacks "sacredness" when he presides at liturgy. He lacks courage, fortitude and "worldly wisdom" in the good sense of the word. The **greedy** priest chooses his apostolates according to economic profit, being more interested in the stipend than in the salvation of souls. He believes that the expenses of mission-outreaches, spiritual exercises, etc., are an unforgivable waste. He does not invest in the pastoral, but in the financial. All the poor who knock on his doors are only charlatans. He does not understand that we must have *purses that*

[148] AG 2.
[149] DP 419.

do not wear out (Lk 12:33). The **moody priest** is always impatient, gloomy and available only when he is in a good mood. He is sterile. He sees only black. He is single, not celibate. He ignores that a pound of grace weighs more than all the sins of the world, even if squared to the umpteenth power. The **secularized** priest adopts lay customs, life and spirituality. It seems that he lacks the sacrament of Holy Orders. He is identified by his layman's clothing, by a layman's way of dealing with others, by the number of hours he spends watching television, by his worldly criteria, etc. The **fearful** priest worries what people will say about him. He distrusts everything; he interprets the simplest gesture as if it were a serious critique of himself; he makes up stories that feed his phobias; he lacks the courage of the Holy Spirit. The **timid** priest is a softer version of the previous one. He thinks he isn't worthy and that he doesn't know how to preach, that people make fun of him. He does not deal with learned people. He is timid – falling into false humility. He doesn't do enough to overcome this. The **climber** priest associates with authority, praising it in order to ascend. He sees the priesthood as a ladder of ranks. He takes great care of his image. He usually has a feminine psychology, and therefore, he schemes. He is incapable "of blooming where he has been planted." He is all "show." The **loner** priest manages by his own spirit. He is unable to join with others for a common task. He is not integrated with others and so he always winds up with a bad result. The **ubiquitous** priest is in all places except where he must be, going in all directions at the same time. He confuses the pilgrim Church with the nomadic Church. He doesn't know how to "restrain his wanderings"[150] and therefore does little and wastes time. In summary, these examples suffice to make us realize that we need holy priests and religious who are poets, metaphysicians, and soldiers, who sing, contemplate, and fight.

[150] Cf. THOMAS A KEMPIS, *Imitation of Christ*, 3, 54.

Teaching and Works

109. *Jesus began to do and teach* (Acts 1:1). Therefore, in our spirituality we should never dialectically separate teaching from work, nor work from teaching. We must always unite the integrity of doctrine with an upright life, and orthodoxy with orthopraxis. In the whole revelation word and work – *dabar* and *barah* – are inseparably united.

110. The principles of the "spirituality of teaching" must be inspired by our blessed Savior's examples, especially in this time of revitalization of evangelization and catechesis. We believe that the fundamental characteristics of Jesus' eloquence are: originality, authority, serenity and universality. The members of our Institute dedicated to teaching – and in some way, all members – have to capture these characteristics very deeply in prayer in order to transmit them to others.

111. We must have the firmest of convictions that the strongest, liveliest, freshest, and most grace-filled originality can be found only in the strictest fidelity to the doctrine of Jesus, as understood in the Church. Jesus' listeners said of Him: *No man ever spoke like this man!* (Jn 7:46). Anything separated from Jesus is out-of-date, quickly aging, and will regrettably be like a boring song. Here it is also worth quoting the old adage: "Appearances can be deceiving."[151]

112. When we are certain of the contemplated truth, we can teach with astonishing certainty and authority – according to the degree of theological certainty of that truth – participating in the authority of Christ: *They were astonished at his teaching, for he taught them as one who had authority, and not as the scribes* (Mk 1:21). Teaching one's own doctrines, demanding undue consent, emphasizing the accidental, having a doubtful attitude concerning everything,

[151] Cf. THOMAS A KEMPIS, *Imitation of Christ*, 3, 54.

remaining in insinuations or approximations, making problems out of the simplest things, overshadowing the clear points and not clarifying the dark ones, seeking oneself when teaching, preferring confusion to order, being embellished instead of sober, opaque instead of transparent, confusing instead of precise, wordy instead of concise, churning the waters so that others believe they are deep... is not to have the spirit of Christ who said: *Let what you say be simply "Yes" or "No"; anything more than this comes from evil* (Mt 5:37).

113. Serenity and sweetness are other characteristics of evangelical teaching that are not opposed to – but rather demanded of – the quick-witted reply, the intelligent polemic, the effective rebuttal and the academic or apologetic discussion. The religious should never lose spiritual peace, moderation, courtesy, or religious fervor.

114. We must let ourselves be penetrated by the universality of Christ's teaching. Intellectual sectarianism is neither evangelical nor intellectual. Those who, because of close-mindedness are incapable of being understood by simple-minded people, don't comprehend the universality of Jesus' message. Only the contemplative and the authentic intellectual do not forget, "There exists, there must be a fundamental union which is before all pluralism, and which alone enables pluralism to be not only legitimate but desirable and fruitful."[152]

115. We must be anxious to preach the Word in every way, following St. Paul's advice: *Preach the word, be urgent in season and out of season, convince, rebuke, and exhort, be unfailing in patience and in teaching* (2 Tm 4:2). We must not be *dumb dogs that cannot bark* (Is 56:10). We must look for the sheep, using the method of dialogue,

[152] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Participants in the Assembly organized by the Italian Episcopal Conference on "From Rerum Novarum to our days", October 31, 1981; OR (12/6/1982) Spanish Edition.

testimony and solidarity,[153] to correct sinners, to teach doctrine: *Faith comes from what is heard* (Rom 10:17), to visit the sick and to bring souls to the sacrament of Reconciliation. "Show by the depth of your convictions and by the consistency of your behavior that Jesus Christ is our contemporary."[154]

Works

116. Our Lord not only "said," but also "worked," particularly in the act of becoming flesh in the Incarnation (Cf. Jn 1:14) and in the act of becoming sin in His death on the Cross[155] as sacrifice for our sins. So numerous are the "works" of Jesus that Saint John says, *if every one of them were written, I suppose that the world itself could not contain the books that would be written* (Jn 21:25).

117. What is common to all His works is that He did not do anything by Himself, *but only what he sees the Father doing; for whatever he does, that the Son does likewise* (Jn 5:19). This is the essential work of Jesus: *My food is to do the will of him who sent me* (Jn 4:34). He also says: *I can do nothing on my own authority... I seek not my own will but the will of him who sent me* (Jn 5:30). This is the true greatness of the Christian and religious vocation: union with God.

118. The Father's will becomes concrete primarily in the Kingdom: *He made us a kingdom...* (Rev 1:6). This should be our first concern: *seek first his kingdom...* (Mt 6:33). In order to build the Kingdom Jesus called men to make them disciples: *making and baptizing more disciples* (Jn 4:1). By teaching, mainly by example, He formed them to do as He did: *For I have given you an example, that you also should do as I have done to you* (Jn 13:15). Likewise, as an integral part of our spirituality, we need to know how to call,

153 Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Bishops of Colombia in Ad Limina Visit, February 22, 1985; OR (3/3/1985) Spanish Edition.

154 BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Youth of Brescia, October 3, 1982; OR (10/3/1982) Spanish Edition.

155 Cf. 2 Cor 5:21.

teach, direct, accompany and select vocations: priestly, diaconal, religious, missionary and secular. Knowing that "vocation is in seed in the heart of most Christians,"[156] we should comply with the mandate of the Pope: "With passion and discretion, be one who awakens vocations."[157] We need to know how to detect the action of the Holy Spirit who pushes the soul to irresistible demands of sacrifice for the love of Christ, in an integral act of faith and total surrender. In this vocational work we need an explicit decision not to make a pact with, compromise with, capitulate with, negotiate with, surrender to or give in to the spirit of the world.

119. The words of these Constitutions will be dead words if we do not train generous youth who will hand down to the new generations of our Religious Family the charism that the Holy Spirit granted to our founder.

120. Christ also taught us to work for purification and renewal: *And making a whip of cords, he drove them all, with the sheep and oxen, out of the temple* (Jn 2:15); for reconciliation: *who has made us both one* (Eph 2:14); and not to lose sight of the eminently supernatural character of the faith and of the Christian life, for which He performed works *that no one else ever did* (Jn 15:24). He did so that we might attain a sacrificial and Eucharistic attitude, imitating Our Lord who *did this once for all* (Heb 7:27). He taught us to try to do things in the best possible way, and not haphazardly, since Jesus *has done all things well* (Mk 7:37); as the good thief confessed: *This man has done nothing wrong* (Lk 23:41).

121. The miracles worked by Our Lord are irrefutable evidence of the credibility of our holy religion and a most eloquent manifestation of the divinity of Our Lord Jesus Christ,

---

[156] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to Women Religious in Turin, April 13, 1980; OR (4/20/1980) Spanish Edition.

[157] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Weekly Meeting with Pilgrims, March 16, 1983; OR (3/27/1983) Spanish Edition.

God from God and Light from Light. He performed miracles in all beings of creation: angels (good and bad), celestial bodies, human beings and irrational creatures. He did this as proof and argument of the faith He taught: that it was He who had come to free men from the power of demons; that it was He who was the Savior of mankind; and that it was He who was the Master and Lord of all creation. Thus, He built up the Kingdom on a solid and indestructible base. Upon this solid base we must build our spirituality: solidified by trials, purified by tribulations, perfected by persecutions, and unshakable in the face of all the violent furies of hell, even if we must live in the time of the Antichrist. We follow the One who, today as yesterday, has all power. Therefore, there is no room for fear. Nothing can make us reject the revealed truth and love of Christ.[158]

122. The miracle of the transfiguration, by which Christ showed His disciples the glory and beauty of His body, encourages us to tolerate difficulties by that brief contemplation of eternal joy... It also reminds us of the specific end of our small Religious Family: **to evangelize the culture** – to transfigure it into Christ. Therefore, on every August 6th, Feast of the Transfiguration of the Lord, we will always solemnly commemorate what constitutes our Religious Family, and what must distinguish us from among the Church's various religious families.

F. PRIESTHOOD OF CHRIST

123. Jesus Christ, because of both the union of the Word with human nature and His capital grace, is truly High and Eternal Priest. No one is so true a priest as Christ; all others are priests in His image. No one is more of a High Priest than He, from whom all others participate by derivation. No one is Eternal Priest but

[158] Cf. Rom 8:39.

He, who perpetuates His sacrifice on the altars until the end of the centuries, and who will consummate His priesthood in Heaven: *You are a priest forever...* (Ps 110:4), *Great High Priest* (Heb 4:14), *Priest forever* (Heb 6:20).

124. He was at the same time priest and victim of His own sacrifice: He *gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God* (Eph 5:2).

125. His priesthood has a superabundant power to expiate all the sins of men: *With his stripes we are healed* (Is 53:5).

126. He is the most perfect mediator between God and men: *For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men* (1 Tm 2:5), *the covenant he mediates is better* (Heb 8:6).

127. Jesus Christ communicates His own priesthood to His disciples, in different degrees, making them participants in a true and real way. In the liturgy, Christ's mystical Body performs public worship: "The whole public worship is performed by the Mystical Body of Jesus Christ, that is, by the Head and His members. Because it… is a sacred action surpassing all others; no other action of the Church can equal its efficacy by the same title and to the same degree."[159]

128. In the liturgy the Incarnate Word intercedes **for us** because He is our Priest, and in us because He is our Head. **To Him we pray** – He is our God. We must recognize our voice in Him and His in us. We ought to pray with Him, since He prays with us; to pray in Him, since He prays in us.[160]

129. This participation in the priesthood of Christ is the essence of the sacramental character that begins with Baptism, is

[159] SC 7.
[160] Cf. SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Expositions on the Book of Psalms*, 85, 1.

perfected with Confirmation and achieves its plenitude in Holy Orders.

130. a) The baptismal character empowers us to receive the other sacraments. It empowers the lay faithful to act as their own proper ministers in the sacrament of matrimony which is the supreme fulfillment of the common priesthood. How we should nurture our soul with the reality of our Baptism! How we should teach this reality to the Christian lay faithful!

131. b) The baptismal character empowers all the baptized to offer the Eucharistic sacrifice. This grandiose and impressive prerogative should be taught insistently to all members of our Institutes who are not ministerial priests. Though they do not carry out the liturgical rite themselves, the baptized participate– in the oblation to the Father of the altar's Victim in two ways: 1st. They offer the sacrifice **by means** of the visible priest, since he offers on behalf of all the members when acting in the person of Christ as head and shepherd. 2nd.**Together with the visible priest**, they unite their acts of praise, supplication, and atonement.

132. c) The character of Confirmation, as it gives us the comforting or corroborative grace, empowers us to profess the faith of Christ with courage and fortitude, and to defend it against its opponents with greater ease and "ex officio," as it were.

133. d) The character of Holy Orders configures the one ordained with Christ the Head, giving the ministerial priest power over Christ's physical Body and over His mystical Body. It allows him to act *in persona Christi*[161] – his main act is the immolation and oblation of the sacrifice of the Mass[162] – and also to bless, preside, preach, baptize, hear confessions, etc. The members of our Institute who are ministerial priests should return again and again

[161] EUGENE IV, *Exsultate Deo*. DS 1321, DZ 698; Council of Florence, *Decree against the Armenians.*

[162] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 22, 4.

to this ineffable reality which produced an ontological change in them by making them like Christ-the-Head. No "secular spirituality" can reduce their "priestly spirituality."

ARTICLE 3: HIS EXIT FROM THIS WORLD

A. PASSION

134. According to the plan of the most Holy Trinity, it was necessary for Jesus Christ to suffer in order to save all men: *As Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life* (Jn 3:14-15). *Was it not necessary that the Christ should suffer these things and enter into his glory?* (Lk 24:26). *And he began to teach them that the Son of man must suffer... and be killed, and after three days rise again* (Mk 8:31). If in the actual salvific economy Christ's Passion was necessary, then it will also be necessary for us to suffer. If there were another way to Heaven, Jesus Christ would have followed it, and moreover, He would have taught it. However, He did not. Christ went by means of the royal road of the Holy Cross, and He taught us to go by it as well: *If any man would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me* (Lk 9:23). Saint Cyril of Jerusalem teaches: "Jesus, the Sinless, was crucified for you; and will not you be crucified for Him who was crucified for you?"[163]

The Cross in Our Life

135. Therefore, we must love the living cross of toils, humiliations, insults, tortures, pains, persecutions, misunderstandings, annoyances, disgraces, scorn, shame, slanders, death... and be able to say with Saint Paul: *I die every day* (1 Cor

[163] SAINT CYRIL OF JERUSALEM, *Catechesis*, 13.

15:31), in order to nail in our hearts the One who was nailed to the cross for us.[164]

136. We must have an intense desire for the cross: "Grant that we may be ready to die for love of your love, as you died for love of our love."[165] We must pray for this grace: *For it has been granted to you that for the sake of Christ you should…suffer for his sake* (Phil 1:29); and, especially, to ask for the grace of knowledge and joy of the cross which are only achieved in the school of Jesus Christ.

Love of the Cross

137. Therefore, we need a great devotion to the Passion of Our Lord Jesus Christ: "Everything is in the Passion. There one learns the knowledge of the saints."[166] Love that is not borne from the cross of Christ is weak, "for any part that we look at, either on the part of the person that suffers, or of the things that one suffers, or for the end one suffers them, the cross is the event which is the highest, the most divine and secret that has happened in the world since God created it, neither will it happen until the end of the world."[167] The Cross "was the pulpit of the Preacher, the altar of the Sacrificing Priest, the arena of the Combatant, the workshop of the Wonder-worker."[168] This devotion is realized: with knowledge and love of the gospel stories of the Passion (Mt 26; 27; Mk 14; 15; Lk 22; 23; Jn 18; 19); in the theology of the Passion and Redemption; in the contemplation of the Holy Places of Jerusalem, the crucifixes, the Way of the Cross, the beautiful texts of the "Imitation of Christ" which speak about it,[169] the Eucharistic perpetuation of the Passion and Cross – second act of

---

164 Cf. SAINT AUGUSTINE, *De Sancta Virginitate*, 54-55.

165 SAINT FRANCIS OF ASSISI, *The "Absorbeat" Prayer*.

166 SAINT PAUL OF THE CROSS, *Letters*, 52.

167 LUIS DE LA PALMA, *Historia de la Pasión*, Preamble.

168 SAINT ROBERT BELLARMINE, *Book of the Seven Words*, Preamble.

169 Cf. especially 3, 11: "Few love the cross of Jesus", and 12: "The Royal Road of the Holy Cross."

the one drama of the Redemption, the cross in our life that is so well explained in the "Letter to the Friends of the Cross" by Saint Louis-Marie Grignion de Montfort; in the fervor to bring the grace of Redemption to all reality: to man, to the whole man and to all men, to married couples and family, to the culture, to political, economic and social life, to the international life of peoples – especially to the problem of peace; in summary, to all the great contemporary problems analyzed in the second part of the Pastoral Constitution Gaudium et Spes.[170]

138. In the Sacred Scriptures we are taught that many men *live as enemies of the cross of Christ* (Phil 3:18). This is because they reject the cross: *and he who does not take his cross and follow me is not worthy of me* (Mt 10:38); they reduce[171] and diminish it: *Let him come down now from the cross, and we will believe in him* (Mt 27:42); they avoid *being persecuted for the cross of Christ* (Gal 6:12); they do not preach the entire message: *But if I, brethren, still preach circumcision… In that case the stumbling block of the cross has been removed!* (Gal 5:11).

139. The Incarnate Word teaches us to love the Cross: *And he said to all…let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me* (Lk 9:23). We have examples of this from the saints who always carried the sufferings of Jesus in their own bodies,[172] completing in themselves what is lacking in the Passion of Christ.[173]

140. We should not want to know anything *except Jesus Christ and him crucified* (1 Cor 2:2). This doctrine of the Cross[174] must be what we preach: *the folly of what we preach... Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and foolishness to Gentiles* (1 Cor 1:21-23). In this cross we must boast, in imitation of the Apostle: *But far be it from me to*

170 Cf. GS 11-90.
171 Cf. 1 Cor 1:17.
172 Cf. 2 Cor 4:10.
173 Cf. Col 1:24.
174 Cf. 1 Cor 1:18.

glory except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by which the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world (Gal 6:14).

141. This Cross prepares for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison (2 Cor 4:17), because *the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us* (Rom 8:18). That is why the Lord Himself encourages us: *Blessed are you when men revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account. Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven, for so men persecuted the prophets who were before you* (Mt 5:11-12).

142. There is no school greater than the Cross, in which Jesus Christ teaches His disciples how they should be: the Cross is "for us the supreme Pulpit of the truth of God and of man."[175] That is why "in the school brought forth from the Incarnate Word, we understand that accepting his Cross with love is divine wisdom: the cross of the humility of reason in the face of mystery; the cross of the will in the faithful fulfillment of all moral, natural, and revealed law; the cross of one's own arduous, and at times less than gratifying, duty; the cross of patience in illness and in everyday difficulties; the cross of the tireless zeal to respond to our own vocation; and the cross of the struggle against the passions and attacks of evil."[176] The cross is the Pulpit because in it "the glory of the Love disposed to all has been revealed."[177] The Cross is the only way of life, the sign of the predestined, the scepter of the kingdom of holiness and "the fountain of all blessings; it is the cause of all graces; through it, those who believe

[175] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Meeting with Youth, April 6, 1979; OR (4/29/1979) Spanish Edition.

[176] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily in Saint Thomas Parish, at Castel Gandolfo, September 15, 1991; OR (9/20/1991) Spanish Edition.

[177] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily during the Eucharistic Concelebration in the Basilica of Saint Francis, Assisi, December 3, 1982; OR (3/21/1982) Spanish Edition.

receive strength instead of weakness, glory instead of shame, life instead of death."[178]

143. The saints of all time, true words of God,[179] show us the necessity of the cross in our lives: "Those who suffer for Christ are justly glorified along with Christ as long as they suffer with Him."[180] "Whoever wishes to lead a perfect life needs only to despise what Christ despised on the Cross and to desire what He desired."[181] "Jesus is loved and served on the Cross and crucified with Him, not by any other way."[182]

144. Those same saints burned with desire for the Cross: "If the Head is crowned with thorns, can the members expect to be crowned with roses? If the Head is jeered at and covered with dust on the road to Calvary, can the members expect to be sprinkled with perfumes on a throne?"[183] "Those who truly love the cross of Christ our Lord find rest when they encounter these trials, and they die when they flee from them or are without them."[184] "To die, Lord, or to suffer."[185] "I want and choose poverty with Christ poor rather than riches, opprobrium with Christ replete with it rather than honors; and to desire to be looked upon as worthless and a fool for Christ, Who first was held as such, rather than wise or prudent in this world."[186] "[This] is for my benefit… Let fire and the cross; let the crowds of wild beasts; let breaking, ripping, and separation of bones; let cutting off of members; let bruising to pieces of the whole body; and let

---

[178] SAINT LEO THE GREAT, *Sermon on the Passion of the Lord*, 6, 8. PL 54,340-342.

[179] Cf. Rev 22:6.

[180] SAINT AMBROSE, *Letters*, 35, 4-6.

[181] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on the Creed*, 4, 60.

[182] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of June 24, 1937*.

[183] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *Letter to the Friends of the Cross*, 27.

[184] SAINT FRANCIS XAVIER, *Letter of September* 20, 1542.

[185] SAINT TERESA OF JESUS, *Book of Life*, 40, 20.

[186] SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Spiritual Exercises*, 167.

the very torment of the devil come upon me: only let me attain Jesus Christ."[187] "Permit me to be an imitator of the passion of my God."[188] In a word, "Never the Cross without Jesus, nor Jesus without the Cross."[189]

145. The saints remind us of the joy that is the fruit of this cross: "I have not been able to suffer, but to me all suffering is sweet."[190] Our hope should be that all pain would give us comfort. Pain "is the fulcrum on which one becomes a lever in order to serve man, as well as to transmit to many others the immense joy of being a Christian."[191]

146. The Cross of Christ demands a generous response from us: "[The Passion and the Cross] are a persevering and inflexible aspiration and a cry: an immense cry from the heart."[192] "Jesus, who had never sinned, was crucified for you; and you, won't you crucify yourself for Him who was nailed to the cross for the love of you?"[193] That is why the cross is also "a crown, not an ignominy"[194] – because it implies an imitation of Christ. This is the resounding idea: to sacrifice oneself. This is the way history is directed, yet silently directed and in secret.

Benefits

147. From the many benefits that Christ's Redemption has brought us by His Passion, we should discover:

---

[187] SAINT IGNATIUS OF ANTIOCH, *Letter to the Romans*, 5, 3.

[188] SAINT IGNATIUS OF ANTIOCH, *Letter to the Romans*, 5, 3.

[189] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *The Love of Eternal Wisdom*, 14, 1.

[190] SAINT THÉRÈSE OF THE CHILD JESUS, *Story of a Soul*, 12, 21.

[191] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Meeting with Youth, April 2, 1979; OR (4/19/1979) Spanish Edition.

[192] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Celebration of the Passion of the Lord in the Basilica of Saint Peter and the Way of the Cross in the Coliseum, April 4, 1980; OR (4/13/1980) Spanish Edition.

[193] SAINT CYRIL OF JERUSALEM, *Catechesis*, 13, 23.

[194] SAINT CYRIL OF JERUSALEM, *Catechesis*, 13, 22.

148. a) how much God loves us, and therefore, how much we should love him: *God shows his love for us in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us* (Rom 5:8); *I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me* (Gal 2:20).

149. b) the example of the many virtues needed for the salvation of humanity, such as obedience, humility, perseverance, justice and scorn of worldly things. *Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, that you should follow in his steps* (1 Pt 2:21).

150. c) not only how He redeemed us from sin, but the magnitude of sanctifying grace and of eternal glory that He won for us.

151. d) the great need to be immune from sin: *You were bought with a price!* (1 Cor 6:20).

152. e) the great dignity of man: though man was conquered by the devil, the devil was conquered by man. *Thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ* (1 Cor 15:57).

153. Briefly, we find a thousand mysteries in the Passion of the Lord, such that its abundance is inexhaustible.

154. We should also attentively consider that Christ wanted to freely suffer all the scathing pains of His Passion and Death; He did not impede them, although He could have: *I lay down my life… no one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have power to lay it down, and I have power to take it up again* (Jn 10:17-18). Manifesting all the bodily vigor He had conserved until the last moment, He cried out *with a loud voice, and said, "Father, into your hands I commend spirit"; and when he had said this he breathed his last* (Lk 23:46).

155. He freely subjected Himself out of obedience to fulfill His Father's command: *So by one man's obedience, many will be made righteous* (Rom 5:19). Certainly *obedience is better than sacrifice* (1 Sm

15:22), but sacrifice carried out through obedience is supreme perfection. This should teach us how to freely live the vow of obedience, and to never succumb to the false dialectics raised between freedom and obedience, or freedom and authority, or vice versa.

156. Therefore, taking everything into proper consideration, there are two things that are manifested in the Passion: the severity of God who refused to forgive without appropriate satisfaction: *He who did not spare his own Son*; and His infinite goodness: *He handed him over for us all*. An unlimited trust in the Father's overflowing generosity must spring from this: *Will he not also give us all things with him* (Rom 8:32)?

Example

157. Jesus' Passion is His second great humiliation: the *kenosis* of the Passion. In the Passion His humility shines forth. We must imitate it: …*but in humility count others better than yourselves* (Phil 2:3). In this regard Saint Thomas Aquinas teaches that two things can be considered about man: what is God's (what pertains to man's salvation and perfection), and what is man's (his defects). Now, humility properly considers the reverence whereby man is subject to God. Therefore, every man, with regard to what is his own, should subject himself to every neighbor with regard to what his neighbor has of God: in this subjection, humility shines brightly.[195]

Ways

158. Contemplating the different ways in which the Passion of the Lord accomplishes its end, that is, the salvation of all people, leads us to admire the following: His infinite wisdom which *has*

[195] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 161, 3.

done all things well (Mk 7:37); the exquisiteness of His love, *He loved them to the end* (Jn 13:1); and the magnanimity and generosity of His work, *Where sin increased, grace abounded all the more* (Rom 5:20). This masterpiece is the Savior's most marvelous and exuberant work. It evokes absolute certainty in the salvation carried out by Him, by way of merit, satisfaction, sacrifice, redemption and effectiveness. These five ways of causality that brought about our redemption, far from dismembering it, make us see it with more strength and unity, like fingers that perfect the hand.

159. Christ merited all graces, present and future, without exception, for all people of all ages. His merit is universal: *He is the expiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world* (1 Jn 2:2). His merit is superabundant, infinite and strictly just.

160. Christ made satisfaction for the sins of all men, offering to the Father a superabundant, universal reparation in strict justice. *He bore the sin of man* (Is 53:12); *God made the sinless one into sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God* (2 Cor 5:21); *having become a curse for us* (Gal 3:13); *paying for all: Christ Jesus... who gave himself as a ransom for all* (1 Tm 2:6).

161. Christ saved us by the sacrifice of the Cross, a unique oblation: *We have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all* (Heb 10:10); a definitive sacrifice: *instituted... by the power of an indestructible life* (Heb 7:16); an eternal sacrifice, since *He holds his priesthood permanently, because he continues forever* (Heb 7:24). The Victim is perfect: *Consequently he is able for all time to save those who draw near to God through him* (Heb 7:25). He was simultaneously a sin offering, a peace offering and a holocaust: *Christ loved us and gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God* (Eph 5:2). Should we not recall here that religious are those who consecrate

themselves totally to the service of God by offering themselves to Christ in holocaust?[196]

162. Christ redeems us from all slavery, since He came *to give his life as a ransom for many* (Mt 20:28), *as a ransom for all* (1 Tm 2:6), *who gave himself for us to redeem us from all iniquity* (Ti 2:14), freeing us from all slaveries of sin, from the punishment due to sin, from death, from the power of the devil and from the mosaic law.

163. Christ is the efficient cause of the objective redemption carried out at Calvary, and of the application of the fruit of the redemption for us (subjective redemption) by faith and the sacraments. He is the most efficient cause of our salvation because He is God, the Word of God, and because His humanity is an instrument united with divinity. Therefore all of Christ's actions and sufferings instrumentally cause the salvation of mankind.

Effects

164. The effects of His Passion are unfathomable:

1. it frees us from sin: *[He] has freed us from our sins by his blood* (Rev 1:5);

2. it frees us from the power of the devil: *Now shall the ruler of this world be cast out* (Jn 12:31);

3. it frees us from the grief of sin: *[He] has borne our grief and carried our sorrows* (Is 53:4);

4. it reconciles us with God: *We were reconciled to God by the death of his Son* (Rom 5:10);

[196] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST II-II*, 186, 7.

5. it opens the doors of Heaven for us: …*we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of Jesus* (Heb 10:19);

6. it exalts Christ: *God has highly exalted him* (Phil 2:9).

165. We now want to highlight an aspect already hinted at. Saint Paul teaches: …*In my flesh I complete what is lacking in Christ's afflictions* (Col 1:24). Certainly we do not add anything substantial to the sacrifice of Christ, but in the operative order we somehow complete it. In His sacrifice, Christ-the-Head offered to the Father His own pains and those of all the members of His mystical body; He took upon Himself not only the sins of all men, but also all their pains, which were the sufferings that His members would suffer for His love; these members would be persecuted because they served Him.[197] Christ "suffered as our head, and He continues to suffer in his members, that is to say, in us."[198] Therefore, "Christ will be in agony until the end of the world" since "the total measure of all the sufferings of men will not be filled until the end of the world."[199]

Suffering

166. Since God chooses suffering to redeem us, it is precious and invaluable when it is endured with patience, accepted as coming from God, and sanctified by uniting it to the pain of Christ. This is the deepest motive for our ministry to the sick, which constantly validates our Christian authenticity. The sick should always be our favored ones!

167. All our sufferings entered into the heart of Christ on Calvary. Those sufferings were offered by Christ, Priest and Victim, in advance. They need to be completed in our flesh.

---

197 Cf. Jn 15:20.
198 SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Exposition on the Book of Psalms*, 61, 4.
199 SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Exposition on the Book of Psalms*, 61, 4.

Christ's sacrifice, prophetically completed in Him, will in fact be completely fulfilled when the number of the elect is completed. We are co-redeemers!

168. The co-redemptive efficacy of our sufferings depends on their union with the Cross, and in the measure and degree of that union. We live from Christ's sacrifice: no act of virtue is worthy if it is not offered by our Head on the Cross; no sin is forgiven if Christ on Golgotha had not begged mercy for it; no pain is redeeming unless it is united to Christ's Passion. If we do not learn how to be victims with the Victim, all our sufferings are useless.

169. We must learn how to complete what is missing in the Passion of Christ[200] with **affective reparation** – by prayer and love; **effective reparation** – fulfilling one's own duties, apostolate, etc.; and **afflictive reparation** – by sanctified suffering, for our own spiritual welfare and for the Mystical Body's.

170. Thus, our Institutes benefit most from their sick members whom we should consider privileged members and for whose good we should be willing to sell "the chalices"[201] if necessary.

B. DEATH ON THE CROSS AND BURIAL

171. Christ kills death with His death; *Death is swallowed up in victory. O death, where is your victory?* (cf. 1 Cor 15:54-55). Therefore, His death gives life, is a step to His resurrection and our resurrection – both spiritual and corporal.

[200] Cf. Col 1: 24.
[201] SRS 31.

172. True Christians consider that *if we have died with Him, we shall also live with Him* (2 Tm 2:11). In baptism we die, and that death ensures our resurrection, *if we have been united with him in a death like his, we shall certainly be united with him in a resurrection like his* (Rom 6:5); offering daily sufferings with Him: sharing in *his sufferings, becoming like him in his death* (Phil 3:10); and to be able to exclaim, *For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain* (Phil 1:21).

173. We "must lead a dying life,"[202] or as the poet chants: The one who does not know how to die while he is living / is vain and fool / to die a little every hour / is the way to live / …from death I receive / new life and if I live /I live of so much dying. This is the secret of all supernatural fruitfulness! Everything is in knowing how to die! This is the great science! *Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit. He who loves his life loses it, and he who hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life* (Jn 12:24-25).

174. The cross offers us another magnificent lesson. As we all sinned and perished **together** in Adam, since *sin came into the world through one man… because all men sinned* (Rom 5:12), so now in Christ, the new Adam, by the principle of *koinonia*, we all find salvation and life: *Those who receive the abundance of grace and the free gift of righteousness reign in life through the one man Jesus Christ* (Rom 5:17).

175. Jesus Christ in Himself assumes the representation of all men: "He suffered for me, he paid for me, and he died for me."[203] In Him we are recapitulated and "concentrated." Because of this intimate, mysterious identification of Christ with each one of us, He assumes and makes our sins His own: *He became sin.*[204]

176. Not only did Jesus die on our behalf, but we also have died, and are represented and contained in Him. Christ and us, us

[202] THOMAS A KEMPIS, *Imitation of Christ*, 2, 12.
[203] SAINT JOHN OF AVILA, *Sermons of Third Sunday after Pentecost.*
[204] Cf. 2 Cor 5:21.

and Christ, form a unique oneness, a compact whole: *You are all one in Christ Jesus* (Gal 3:28). By this mystical identification of persons, we also die on the Cross. Because of this mysterious solidarity or ineffable communion of men with Christ, we have died *in radice* in Christ.

177. Christ truly died representing all men, so it was necessary that we all, somehow, die in Him and with Him: *One has died for all; therefore all have died* (2Cor 5:14). Everyone has died in Him. That everyone-dies-because-One-dies supposes that everyone is in that One, and that the One and everyone are the same: *We all are one*... We should accomplish in deed what was accomplished *in radice* on the Cross: we must die to our former selves, to sin, to sinful affections and even more, to the very appearance of evil.

178. We must die totally to ourselves. There are three stages for perfect self-denial: external mortification, spirit of sacrifice and total death to oneself. Reaching this third stage is very difficult. We achieve it by means of **persistent** work. It is **to die to live**: *For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God* (Col 3:3). The life of Christ was a continuous death whose last act and consummation was the Cross. Christ's mystical life establishes itself in us by diverse degrees of death:

- death to sins, even to the slightest and the smallest imperfections;

- death to the world and all external things;

- death to the senses and the immoderate care of one's own body;

- death to one's character and natural defects: by not speaking or working according to one's own mood or caprice, by always remaining in peace and in possession of oneself;

- death to one's own will and spirit: subjecting the will to reason, not being led by one's own desires or fantasies; not becoming obstinate in one's own judgment; knowing how to listen; being always cheerful with what God gives us;

- death to esteem and love of ourselves: to self-love;

- death to spiritual consolations: one day God will withdraw them completely, and then everything will bother the soul, sicken it and tire it, until one's nature screams, complains, and becomes furious;

- death to everything that gives support to our soul and to any assurance about the state of our soul: to experience the abandonment of God;

- death to any property concerning holiness: total nakedness. Neither gifts nor virtues are seen, only sins, one's own nothingness.

179. We should learn how to discover ourselves and others in the Heart and the wounds of Christ. Then we will understand what we pray for when we say, "Within your wounds, hide us,"[205] since "we are made Christ."[206]

Folly of the Cross

180. In addition, we should keep in mind another reality: the folly of the Cross, *for the foolishness of God is wiser than men* (1Cor 1:23.25). This folly consists of living "more" and "above", where all balance, all calculation, all tit-for-tat ceases. This folly begins when there is no longer counting, calculating, weighing, or measuring. Do you only love the one who loves you? Do you only give to the one who can return it to you? Do you only do favors

[205] SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Anima Christi*.
[206] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Gospel of Saint John*, 21, 8.

to those who thank you? How great is all that? *Do not even the Gentiles do the same*? (Mt 5:47).

181. The folly of the Cross consists of living the beatitudes. Blessed be the fools for Christ! They will be pushed around, laughed at and regarded as awkward, slow and even mentally weak. Theirs is the Kingdom of God. Blessed be the fools for Christ! They have stripped themselves and stand before God in their nakedness. Blessed be these fools for Christ! No worldly wisdom will ever be able to deceive them. It is the folly of limitless and immeasurable love. It is to bless those that curse us,[207] to repay no one evil for evil (Rom 12:17). When the world says to us, "Look at the fools! They are stoned, and they kiss the hands of those who stone them. They are laughed at and made fun of, and they laugh like senseless children. They are beaten, persecuted and martyred, but they give thanks to God who found them worthy. When the world says all of this, it is a sign that we are doing well. The folly of love! "But the folly of the Cross makes wiser than the wisdom of all men."

C. THE DESCENT TO HELL

182. Saint Peter teaches that Christ *went to preach to the spirits in prison* (1 Pt 3:19), and that *the gospel was preached even to the dead* (1 Pt 4:6).

183. The *kenosis* of the Incarnation of the Word is extended through His Passion and Death, and reaches its fullness when He descends into hell, in such a way that if we stopped believing this truth of our faith, we would somehow be diminishing the reality of the Incarnation.

184. In this mystery Christ showed the fruit of His Passion to the saints of the Old Testament, the Patriarchs and Prophets,

[207] Cf. Rom 12:14.

Saint Joseph, Saint John the Baptist, the Holy Innocent Martyrs, the good thief... and communicated its glorious holiness to them.

185. He also consoled the souls in Purgatory, taking those that were sufficiently purified. In our preferential option for the poor, we ought to always keep in mind these blessed souls in Purgatory to atone for them.

ARTICLE 4: HIS GLORIOUS LIFE

A. RESURRECTION

The Fact

186. The resurrection of Our Lord Jesus Christ is a Mystery and a twofold miracle. It is a theological miracle that surpasses the capacity of all created intelligence: *If Christ has not been raised, then our preaching is in vain and your faith is in vain* (1 Cor 15:14). At the same time, it is an apologetic miracle since the empty tomb and Jesus' appearances fulfill the prophecies, and the truth of the divinity of Jesus Christ is certified. He is *the first-born from the dead* (Col 1:18), *and the first fruits of those who have fallen asleep* (1 Cor 15:20). He is the **first** to resurrect gloriously to an immortal life. He is the beginning of the new creation – re-creation of the world – infinitely superior to the first creation.

Effects

187. The resurrection of Our Lord gave us two main benefits: our future corporeal resurrection and our present spiritual resurrection. We are taught that *as by a man came death, by a man has come also the resurrection of the dead* (1 Cor 15:21), and that He *was put to death for our trespasses and raised for our justification* (Rom 4:25). It is then evident that justification is the resurrection of souls, who are

spiritually dead by sin, dead to the life of grace. Saint Thomas teaches: "The good of grace in one is greater than the good of nature in the whole universe."[208]

188. The importance of **grace** in the saving economy of the New Covenant and the reason why grace is the "only formal cause"[209] of our salvation are seen more clearly in the Lord's resurrection. Sanctifying grace makes us *partakers of the divine nature* (2 Pt 1:4). As theologians say, it is a physical and formal – though analogous – participation in the divine nature itself. *And we were raised up with him* (Eph 2:6), becoming "by grace what He is by nature,"[210] children of God,[211] brethren of Christ. Jesus Christ is the *first-born among many brethren* (Rom 8:29), and therefore, we are co-heirs with Him, *heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ* (Rom 8:17). Along with grace we receive the instilled virtues and the gifts of the Holy Spirit.

Sending Forth of the Holy Spirit: The New Law

189. On the very day of His Resurrection, Jesus Christ did privately what He would do publicly on the day of Pentecost: He sent the Holy Spirit. *He breathed on them and said to them, Receive the Holy Spirit* (Jn 20:22). The Holy Spirit is the main component of the New Law, also known as New Covenant or Gospel. He is the "abundant life" (Cf. Jn 10:10) that Christ came to bring to the earth. He is the *law of Christ* (Gal 6:2), the *principle of faith* (Rom 3:27), the spiritual law,[212] *the perfect law* (Jas 1:25), *the law of liberty* (Jas 2:12), *the law of the Spirit* (Rom 8:2), *the Gospel of grace* (Acts 20:24), and *the law of Christ* (Gal 6:2). He is the law infused into the

---

[208] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST I-II*, 113, 9, 2: "bonum gratiae unus maius est quam bonum naturae totius universi."

[209] COUNCIL OF TRENT, *On the Justification*. DZ 799.

[210] SAINT CYRIL OF ALEXANDRIA, *On the Gospel of Saint John*, 1, 13. MG 73,153.

[211] Cf. Rom 8:16.

[212] Cf. Rom 7:14.

heart that Jeremiah prophesied: *I will put my law within them, and I will write it upon their hearts* (Jer 31:33). He is "whereon all… [the law's] efficacy is based… the grace itself of the Holy Spirit, which is given to those who believe in Christ."[213] Only this law justifies and saves man: *The gospel is the power of God for the salvation to every one who has faith* (Rom 1:16). The new law, the Gospel, saves and justifies only as infused – inwardly communicated – not presented as a written text. For that reason Saint Paul says that *the letter kills, the Spirit gives life* (2 Cor 3:6). By "letter," Saint Paul means whatever thing or writing exterior to man, even involving spiritual and heavenly matters, like the Gospel writings. Saint Thomas says, "Wherefore the letter, even of the Gospel, would kill, unless there was the inward presence of the healing grace of faith."[214] If this applies to the Holy Gospels authored principally by the Holy Spirit, how much more is this true for this Directory! Without faith in Christ, without the Holy Spirit, without the love of God, without sanctifying grace, all these writings would kill souls since they would remain merely in external things.

190. Living according to the New Law means to live according to the reality that *God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit which has been given* (Rom 5:5). It is to live according to *faith working through love* (Gal 5:6), and *love never ends* (1 Cor 13:8).

Freedom

191. The Resurrection and the sending of the Holy Spirit call us to freedom,[215] because *for freedom Christ has set us free* (Gal 5:1).

192. Freedom implies "building a communion and a participation... upon three inseparable aspects:

---

[213] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST I-II*, 106, 1.

[214] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST I-II*, 106, 2; cf. SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Spirit and the Letter*, 14. 17. ML 44,215.219.

[215] Cf. Gal 5,13.

- the relation of man with the world, as lord;

- with people, as brother;

- and with God, as son."[216]

193. "Today they have extended in a great way the range of the abuses of freedom, and this leads to new forms of slavery, very dangerous ones, because they are disguised under the appearance of freedom. This is the paradox, the profound drama of our time: in the name of freedom, slavery is imposed."[217]

194. Saint Peter already warned against these abuses, and exhorted the faithful to be truly free *without using your freedom as a pretext for evil* (1 Pt 2:16), and Saint Paul admonished us not to use freedom as an excuse to serve the flesh.[218]

195. Authentic freedom identifies with holiness, with the New Law, with the Christian faith and with charity. It is *liberty of the children of God* (Rom 8:21). Freedom has truth as its foundation as Our Lord showed when He said, *the truth will set you free* (Jn 8:32). Freedom is characteristic of those who allow the Holy Spirit to lead them: *The Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom* (2 Cor 3:17). This is why Saint Augustine teaches, "Love, and do what you will."[219] Saint John of the Cross places freedom at the summit of the mount of perfection, "There is no road here, for there is no law for the righteous man."[220]

---

[216] DP 322.

[217] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Sunday Homily, June 28, 1992; OR (7/24/1992) Spanish Edition. Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, OR (3/25/1979) Spanish Edition. "The true liberation of man, the liberation which Christ brings him, is also liberation from appearances of liberation, namely, from appearances of freedom which are not true freedom."

[218] Cf. Gal 5:13.

[219] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Homilies on the First Letter of John*, 7, 8.

[220] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Drawing of the Mount of Perfection.*

196. Christian freedom "is to be able to avoid sin and to do meritorious works, without anything having the power to prevent [it]… from reaching the last end."[221]

197. We must be free and must know how to form free men and women: "Free... free... free... free... free... free with your freedom... that you may go everywhere with... the holy Gospel in your mouth and the holy Rosary in your hand, to bark like dogs, to burn like embers and to illuminate the darkness of the world like suns."[222]

198. Saint Thomas teaches: "Free is he who is the cause of his own action; a servant is he whose cause of action is his master. Therefore, he who acts by his own decision acts freely; he who acts by another agent, does not. Thus, he who avoids evil not because it is evil, but because it is God's command, is not free; but he who avoids evil because it is evil, that one is free. The Holy Spirit, who makes the soul perfect interiorly through the good habit, accomplishes this. The result is that the soul abstains from evil because of love, as if it were God's command. Therefore it is called free, not because it rejects divine law, but because it is inclined by good habits to do what is required by the divine law."[223]

The New Man

199. The New Law brings us to the New Man by essence, Jesus Christ Himself, *that he might create in himself one new man* (Eph 2:15) and the new man by participation, namely, all those who are incorporated into Jesus Christ through grace: *and put on the new nature, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness*

[221] SAINT ROBERT BELLARMINE, *Opera oratoria postuma*, 115.

[222] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *Ardent Prayer*.

[223] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on the Second Letter to the Corinthians*, 3, 112.

(Eph 4:24). The new man is opposed to the *old man which…is corrupt through deceitful lusts* (Eph 4:22),[224] of whom the Apostle prophesied, *People will not endure sound teaching, but having itching ears they will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own likings* (2 Tm 4:3).

200. The new man is the "interior man," *strengthened with might through his Spirit* (Eph 3:16).[225] The new man is also identified with the *spiritual man* (1 Cor 2:15). He is the man who sings the "new song," "This new song does not belong to the old man. Only the new man learns it: the man restored from his fallen condition through God's grace, and now sharing in the new covenant, that is, the kingdom of heaven. To it all our love now aspires and sings a new song. **Let us sing a new song not with our lips but with our lives**… Every one of us tries to discover how to sing to God. You must sing to him, but you must sing well. He does not want your voice to come harshly to his ears… When will you be able to offer him a perfect performance that you will in no way displease such a supremely discerning listener? See how he himself provides you with a way of singing. Do not search for words, as if you could find a lyric which would give God pleasure. Sing to him 'with songs of joy.' This is singing well to God, just singing with songs of joy [which means by] understand[ing] that words cannot express the things that are sung by the heart… Now, who is more worthy of such a cry of jubilation than God himself, whom all words fail to describe? … You must not remain silent, what else can you do but cry out for joy? Your heart must rejoice beyond words, soaring into an immensity of gladness, unrestrained by syllabic bonds."[226]

---

[224] Cf. Rom 6:6; Col 3:9.

[225] Cf. Rom 7:22; 2 Cor 4:16.

[226] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Exposition on the Books of Psalms*, 32; Sermon 1, 7-8. CCL 38,253-254.

201. Jesus Christ, the supreme and eternal New Man, wants us to assimilate His doctrine, to imitate His examples, to unite ourselves wholeheartedly with His Person and to frequent His sacraments. The modern immanentist conceptions that propose a "new man" – who is no more than a human wretch – detest Jesus by denying man the supernatural dimension of grace. The only thing authentically new that there is, has been, and will be in the world is Jesus Christ who "brought all [possible] novelty, by bringing Himself…"[227]

202. The new man, the Christian, sings his own song: "The song springs from happiness, and if we look at it well, it is borne from love: working is characteristic of love. The one who knows how to love the new life, also knows how to sing the new song."[228] "For to sing and to intone psalms is the business of those who love."[229] The Christian pilgrimage must be accompanied with song, with manifestations of joy: "So then, my brothers, let us sing now, not in order to enjoy a life of leisure, but in order to lighten our labors. You should sing as wayfarers do sing, but continue your journey. Do not be lazy, but sing to make your journey more enjoyable. Sing, but keep going. What do I mean by keep going? Keep on making progress. This progress must be in virtue; for there are some, the Apostle warns, whose only progress is in vice (Cf. 2 Tim 3:13). If you make progress, you will be continuing your journey, but be sure that your progress is in virtue, true faith and right living. Sing then – but keep going."[230]

[227] SAINT IRENAEUS, *Against the Heresies*, 4, 34, 1.
[228] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Sermon* 34, 1. ML 38,210.
[229] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Sermon* 33, 1. ML 38,207.
[230] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Sermon* 256, 3. ML 38,1193.

Joy

203. From the Resurrection of the Lord arises an essential element of our spirituality, and of all Christian spirituality: joy. For us, joy must be manifested in special ways: in the celebration of the Lord's Day, Sunday; in having a sense of feasting; and in the recreation that we call *eutrapelia*.

204. Joy, the Christian's gigantic secret, is spiritual and supernatural, and arises from meditating on the mystery of the Incarnate Word. The angel Gabriel said to Mary, *Rejoice*, be glad. She would say, *My spirit rejoices* (Lk 1:47) after Elizabeth had witnessed that *the babe in my womb leaped for joy* (Lk 1:44). The angel said to the shepherds, *I bring you good news of a great joy which will come to all the people* (Lk 2:10). Joy is also borne from witnessing the mystery of the Resurrection of the Lord: *So they departed quickly from the tomb with fear and great joy* (Mt 28:8). Likewise, the disciples of Emmaus experienced joy: *Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road?* (Lk 24:32). *They could not believe for sheer joy and wonder* (Cf. Lk 24:41), *and returned... with great joy* (Lk 24:52). *The disciples were glad when they saw the Lord* (Jn 20:20). Saint Paul insists: *Rejoice in the Lord always; again I will say, rejoice* (Phil 4:4).

205. Therefore, the Christian must always be joyful in everything: *The kingdom of God is… joy in the Holy Spirit* (Rom 14:17); *may the God of hope fill you with all joy* (Rom 15:13); *fill you with all joy* (Rom 15:32); *rejoice* (2 Cor 13:11); *rejoice in the Lord* (Phil 3:1); *rejoice always* (1 Thes 5:16).

206. The Christian has to be joyful in the practice of virtues: *He who does acts of mercy, with cheerfulness* (Rom 12:8); *rejoice in your hope* (Rom 12:12); *strengthened with all power, according to his glorious might, for all endurance and patience with joy* (Col 1:11).

207. The Christian also has to be joyful in sufferings: *With all our affliction, I am overjoyed* (2 Cor 7:4); *as sorrowful, yet always rejoicing* (2 Cor 6:10); *I rejoice in my sufferings* (Col 1:24).

208. The Christian must also rejoice in the community of followers of the Risen One: *I rejoice over you* (Rom 16:19); *that my joy would be the joy of you all* (2 Cor 2:3); *we work with you for your joy, for you stand firm in your faith* (2 Cor 1:24); *always in every prayer of mine for you all making my prayer with joy* (Phil 1:4); *my brethren… my joy and crown* (Phil 4:1); *you are our glory and joy* (1 Thes 2:20).

209. The Christian must rejoice in the proclamation of Christ: *Christ is proclaimed; and in that I rejoice* (Phil 1:18); *I shall remain and continue with you all, for your progress and joy in the faith* (Phil 1:25); *complete my joy* (Phil 2:2); *you received the word in much affliction, with joy inspired by the Holy Spirit* (1 Thes 1:6).

210. Ultimately, joy springs from believing that God *is*;[231] that Christ *is*, *Take heart, it is I* (Mk 6:50); that truth prevails over lies, good over evil, beauty over ugliness, love over hate, peace over war, mercy over vengeance, life over death, grace over sin... in short, being over nothingness, the Virgin over Satan, Christ over the Antichrist, God over all. "God is infinite joy."[232]

Sunday

211. Derived from the Paschal Mystery and from the Lord's Day, on Sunday – the feast day par excellence – feasts should arise among us, because authentic feasting is born from worship – praise given to the Creator for the goodness of existence. On the seventh day *God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good…and he rested* (Gn 1:31, 2:2-3). Saint Augustine teaches that worship takes place by means of the "offering of praise and

[231] Cf. Ex 3:14.
[232] SAINT TERESA OF THE ANDES, *Letters*, 101.

thanksgiving."[233] Since sacrifice is the main act of worship, it is the "soul" of the feast. How much more meaningful this becomes under the light of the Lord's Resurrection and the perpetuation of His Sacrifice on the altars! Indeed, by the Incarnation of the Word and His Paschal Mystery, man is elevated to a super-eminent plane, the plane of grace that absolutely exceeds the order of nature. Therefore the Paschal Mystery with Sunday, its continuation, is the source of authentic feasting. On Sundays we celebrate the goodness of this "superior existence" brought by the Word, *grace and truth came through Jesus Christ* (Jn 1:17), as well as the hope of being able to finally enter Eternal Life, the true Feast. The Paschal Mystery and Sunday signify and anticipate this true Feast. The name Eucharist, given by Christian tradition to the Holy Sacrifice of the Mass, refers to this action of thanksgiving. Sunday already immerses us into the true and eternal feast. For us who live here, our feasts are an opening to that life. We go from feast to feast toward the Feast.[234]

Feasting

212. All feasts participate from the Lord's Resurrection and from Sunday, since the motive of the feast is joy: "Feast is joy and nothing else."[235] But joy supposes a foundation, something that makes one joyful; it is the response of a lover who possesses what he loves. One becomes joyful because he possesses the good that is appropriate to him, either in reality, or in hope, or at least in memory. Only the one who is joyful in love is truly joyful: "Where charity is joyful, there is festivity."[236] Therefore, there is no greater motive for joy than the Resurrection of the Lord because His

[233] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Spirit and the Letter*, 13, 22.

[234] Cf. SAINT ATHANASIUS, *Festal Letters*, 5, 1-2: "*ab uno ad aliud festum pervenire*."

[235] SAINT JOHN CHRYSOSTOM, *Homily on the Pentecost*, 1, MG 50.

[236] SAINT JOHN CHRYSOSTOM, quoted by JOSEF PIEPER, *Una Teoría de la Fiesta*, Madrid 1974, 33.

triumph is our triumph, His victory is our victory. The Paschal Mystery is the manifestation par excellence of the love of God for men: *He loved them to the end* (Jn 13:1). We must be joyful in this mystery, and our joy must be permanent. Therefore our Institutes must appropriately celebrate the great solemnities, especially the Octave of Easter, Sundays, and the feast days of Our Lady and of the Apostles.

213. There is another kind of minor feast: recreation, where the virtue of *eutrapelia* has to be practiced. The soul, like the body, becomes tired and has to rest. Delectation is rest for the soul, by remedying its fatigue. It gives pause to the tension of the spirit. Therefore, we must grant this rest to the soul by means of games and feasts, whose moderation springs from the virtue of *eutrapelia*, practiced during the times of recreation.

214. Whoever does not practice the virtue of *eutrapelia* with gladness will hardly persevere. It is necessary to guard oneself against those, who under the appearance of virtue, do not want to practice the virtue of *eutrapelia*. They are usually led by their selfishness, they offend their neighbor and are very judgmental. And what is worse, they go against the truth of man, who is intelligent and therefore has to be playful.

Sending Forth and Mission

215. As the four evangelists point out, the Resurrected Christ commands us to mission: *As the Father has sent me, even so I send you* (Jn 20:21). This mission requires us to testify, *You are witnesses of these things* (Lk 24:48); to address, by the power of the Lord, all nations of the world: *Go therefore and make disciples of all nations* (Mt 28:19), *all the world* (Mk 16:15); to preach the Gospel; to teach others to observe what He ordered us; to baptize in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, so that he who believes

will be saved, with Christ accompanying us *to the close of the age* (Mt 28:20).

216. So as not to dodge the missionary adventure[237] and at the same time, to move many others toward it, we need to be like poets, for only poets move people. What bigger poet is there than Jesus Christ?! What greater poetry is there than shouting, "Put out into deep water – *Duc in altum*!"[238] What profound words, with such deep content, a deep mystical resonance that impels one toward great ideals. These words are understood by men of action, with broad vision and with decisive and generous hearts. They are understood by men who, because of their soul's nobility, smile with joy in knowing that Jesus Himself tells them: *Duc in altum*! It is an invitation to accomplish great works, extraordinary undertakings involving a great deal of adventure, vertigo, danger, where the waves shake the boat, the salty water sprinkles the face, the prow makes way for the first time, where there is no trail and stars are the only reference, where the keel of a ship is shaken by the whirling waters, where the deployed sails endure the wind's furor, where the masts crack… and the soul shivers. Into deep water! Far from the shore and the mainland of mere human calculations and cold thoughts… where the water moves, the heart beats quickly, where the soul knows celestial bliss and fascinating joys. To "put out into the deep" is to take the demands of the Gospel seriously and thoroughly: *Go, sell what you possess* (Mt 19:21). It is the longing of our restless heart, yearning to possess the Infinite. It is the impetus of the saints and martyrs who gave everything for God. It is characteristic of fishermen, humble, hardworking men who do not fear dangers; vigilant and patient during long vigils, consistent in repeating their outings on

[237] As was said of Saint Toribio of Mogrovejo. "He was a Bishop who would easily ride his horse and go off on the missionary adventure." Cf. V. RODRIGUEZ VALENCIA, *Santo Toribio de Mogrovejo, Organizador y Apóstol de Sur América*, Ed. CSIC, Madrid 1957, 128.

[238] Cf. Lk 5:4.

the sea, prudent to catch fish, hardened by the salt and the sun. It is being willing to die, like the grain of wheat, in order to see Christ in all things. We make ours the ardent words of Blessed Louis Orione: "Whoever does not want to be an apostle leaves the Congregation: today, whoever is not an apostle of Jesus Christ and the Church is an apostate."[239]

B. ASCENSION

217. Christ's Ascension to Heaven moves us to always look for the essential things, invisible to the eyes of the body, that do not pass away and do not die: *Seek the things that are above, where Christ is… Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth* (Col 3:1-2).

218. In these times of crude temporalism, when many contemporaries are infected with secularism, we must give the clear testimony of men who are not encased within the horizons of this world, even when we are involved in the unavoidable commitment of the promotion of justice.

219. The Lord's Ascension must fill us with unshakable hope. He assured us, *In my Father's house are many rooms… I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and will take you to myself, that where I am you may be also* (Jn 14:2-3). "The members must follow whither the Head has gone."[240] His Ascension is the cause of ours. "Christ with us is a single thing."[241] All with Christ "form a single Christ."[242] *Our commonwealth is in heaven* (Phil 3:20).

220. *While he was going…they were gazing heavenward* (Acts 1:10). Our Institute will always have a preferential place for the contemplative branches. The contemplative life, as Blessed John

[239] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of August* 2, 1935.
[240] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 57, 6.
[241] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Exposition on the Book of Psalms*, 122, 1.
[242] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Merits and Forgiveness of Sinners*, 31, 60.

Paul II teaches, is "the nucleus starting from where you prepare to give a full sense to your religious life, as ambassadors of Christ[243] amidst this world."[244] This is because life implies a permanent dedication to God and to believing and loving His mystery and His plan of salvation for all men, as Saint Paul writes: *Seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God… you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God* (Col 3:1-3). Blessed John Paul II says: "To be devoted to God is... the noblest and highest form of activity for the human being, insofar as this concentrates completely on the adoration of the Infinite Being who desires the salvation of all humanity... you have here, thus, the precise form of collaboration that... you offer to the Church for the good of souls."[245] Saint John of the Cross says: "Let those men of zeal, who think that by their preaching and exterior works they convert the world, consider that they would be much more edifying to the Church, and more pleasing unto God, by setting aside the good example they would give and spending at least one half their time in prayer… Certainly they would do more, and with less trouble… To act otherwise is to beat the air, to do little more than nothing, sometimes nothing and occasionally even mischief."[246] In the words of Saint Teresa of the Child Jesus: "Only this Jesus claims of us. He doesn't need our works, but only our love."[247] Thanks to the prayer and the sacrifice of those who consecrate themselves to God in contemplative life, the Lord raises up preachers, confessors, spiritual directors, etc., who transmit the truth to men. We can truly say that other people transmit what the contemplatives contemplate.

---

[243] Cf. 2 Cor 5:20.

[244] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the General Council of the Order of Augustinian Recollects, April 28, 1979; OR (5/13/1979) Spanish Edition.

[245] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Monastery of Camaldolese Nuns in Aventino, February 28, 1979; OR (3/11/1979) Spanish Edition.

[246] SAINT JOHN OF THE CROSS, *Spiritual Canticle*, 28, 3.

[247] SAINT THÉRÈSE OF LISIEUX, *Story of a Soul*, 11, 5.

C. TO THE RIGHT HAND OF THE FATHER

221. *He sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high* (Heb 1:3), which, according to Saint John Damascene, means "the glory and the honor of the divinity."[248] In other words, Christ reigns together with the Father and has judicial power over the living and the dead. Knowing that the Lord is at the Father's right hand should make us trust in Him greatly: *I can do all things in him who strengthens me* (Phil 4:13). Another magnificent expression of total trust is Saint Paul's *I know the one in whom I have put my trust* (2 Tm 1:12).

D. THE KINGSHIP OF CHRIST

222. The Lord is King over all humanity in a strict, literal and proper sense since He received from the Father *dominion and glory and kingship* (Dn 7:14). He is *King of kings and Lord of lords* (Rev 19:16). The foundation of this kingship is four-fold: first, it belongs appropriately to Him as God, the Incarnate Word. Saint Cyril of Alexandria says: "Christ obtains the dominance over all creatures, not taken by force nor taken by any other reason, but by his very essence and nature."[249] Second, it belongs to Him by virtue of Redemption, by right of conquest, since He bought us with His blood: *You know that you were ransomed….. not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ* (1 Pt 1:18-19). Third, it belongs to Him because He is the Head of the Church and by the fullness of grace: *full of grace and truth* (Jn 1:14). Fourth, it belongs to Him by right of inheritance: *whom he appointed the heir of all things* (Heb 1:2). His royal authority includes the fullness of the threefold power: legislative, judicial and executive.

---

[248] SAINT JOHN DAMASCENE, *On the Orthodox Faith*, 4, 2. MG 94,1104.

[249] SAINT CYRIL OF ALEXANDRIA, *On the Gospel of Saint John*, 12, 18, 38. MG 74,632.

223. The scope of His reign is twofold: personal and social. He reigns over all intelligence because He is the Truth, "and it is from him that truth must be obediently received by all mankind."[250] He reigns over all will because He is Goodness, "and further by his grace and inspiration he so subjects our free will as to incite us to the most noble endeavors."[251] In addition, He reigns over all hearts because He is Love. His reign is also a social one. "There is no difference in this matter between the individual and the family or the State; for all men, whether collectively or individually, are under the dominion of Christ. In him is the salvation of the individual, in him is the salvation of society."[252]

224. His Kingdom is neither temporary nor earthly, *My kingship is not of this world* (Jn 18:36), but eternal, *and of his kingdom there will be no end* (Lk 1:33), and universal, *all authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me* (Mt 28:18); His is a kingdom of truth and life, of sanctity and grace, of justice, love and peace.[253]

225. All missionary and apostolic work is based on the conviction that *Christ must reign* (1Cor 15:25).

ARTICLE 5: HIS MYSTICAL LIFE

A. THE CHURCH, THE MYSTICAL BODY

226. Beginning with His Resurrection, and forever thereafter, the sacred humanity of Jesus Christ lives a glorious and immortal life; from the moment of the Ascension, His humanity is in Heaven and will return with His Second Coming.

---

[250] PIUS XI, *Quas Primas*, 4.
[251] PIUS XI, *Quas Primas*, 4.
[252] PIUS XI, *Quas Primas*, 16.
[253] MR, Preface of Christ the King.

227. Meanwhile, in the intervening centuries between His Ascension and His Second Coming, Jesus lives His mystical life on earth. The Word assumed a human nature to accomplish the design of salvation. He now chooses other human natures in order to extend that design through time, so that salvation may reach all men of all times. The Church is Jesus Christ continued, diffused and communicated. The Church is the extension of the redemptive Incarnation, by means of the three-fold function: prophetic, priestly and royal. She is the new People of God. She is "in Christ, the nature of sacrament – a sign and instrument, that is, of communion with God and of unity among all men"[254]; she is an organically structured community;[255] "a people united in the unity of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit."[256] The Church is mystery, communion and mission.[257] Belonging to Her – by faith and baptism – must be our seal of honor. By the light of the Word of God, the Church always celebrates the mysteries of Christ for the salvation of the world.[258]

B. HER "HISTORY"

228. The reality of the Church-mystery precedes the creation of the world, as Saint Clement of Rome says: "The Church is not now, but from before,"[259] and the Shepherd of Hermes: "She was created... before all things... by reason of her the world was ordered."[260]

229. In a mediate manner, "This Church was prepared in marvelous fashion in the history of the people of Israel and in the

[254] LG 1.
[255] Cf. LG 11.
[256] SAINT CYPRIAN, *On the Lord's Prayer*, 23. ML 4,553.
[257] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, ChL 18; 19; 32.
[258] Cf. Final Version from the Synod of Bishops of 1985.
[259] SAINT CLEMENT OF ROME, *Second Letter to the Corinthians*, 14, 2.
[260] Shepherd of Hermes, Second Vision, 4, 1.

ancient Covenant";[261] in an immediate way "established in this last age of the world"[262] by Jesus Christ. He gave her the doctrine, the sacraments, and the hierarchy; in a special way in Peter, by whom He begins her constitution when professing: *You are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church* (Mt 16:18). Jesus culminates her preparation on Calvary, when blood and water flowed from the wounded side of Christ crucified; "as often as the sacrifice of the cross by which *Christ our Passover is sacrificed* (1 Cor 5:7) is celebrated on the altar, the work of our redemption is carried out."[263] The Church was openly "made manifest in the outpouring of the Spirit"[264] in the Jewish Pentecost[265] and in the pagan Pentecost.[266] She "will be perfected gloriously at the end of times,[267] when all the just, "from Abel the Just until the last elect,"[268] are united before the Father in one Universal Church.

230. We must always keep this in mind so that we do not succumb to the temptation of thinking that the Church begins with us. Not only are there 2,000 years of history on our shoulders, but also the world's entire past and future.

C. HER "SOUL": THE HOLY SPIRIT

231. The Holy Spirit plays a constitutive, fundamental, essential role in the Church. Indeed, the Holy Spirit accomplishes our incorporation into the mystical Body of Christ, which we belong to through baptism. We must be reborn of water and Spirit;[269] *by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body* (1 Cor 12:13).

---

[261] LG 2.
[262] LG 2.
[263] LG 3. Cf. RM, Opening Prayer of the Second Sunday in Ordinary Time.
[264] LG 2.
[265] Cf. Act 2:1ff.
[266] Cf. Act 10:44ff.
[267] Cf. Act 10:44ff.
[268] SAINT GREGORY THE GREAT, *Homily on the Gospels*, 19, 1.
[269] Cf. Jn 3:5.

232. The Holy Spirit was already revealed in the Old Testament, though not as a Divine Person. He was revealed under different aspects which related both to the life of Israel, and to the life of its individual members. The Holy Spirit acts in creation.[270] He is the source of life: I will pour my Spirit upon your descendants…they shall spring up like grass amid waters (Is 44:3-4). He is the guiding principle of both Israel as well as the prophecy of the future Messiah: *Then the Lord came down in the cloud and spoke to him, and took some of the spirit that was upon him and put it upon the seventy elders* (Nm 11:25); *And the Spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the spirit of wisdom and understanding, the spirit of counsel and might, the spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord. And his delight shall be in the fear of the Lord* (Is 11:2-3); *I have put my Spirit upon him* (Is 42:1). By His action the prophets spoke: *And when the spirit rested upon them, they prophesied* (Nm 11:25). His action renews, purifies the heart, and sanctifies: *Take not thy holy Spirit from me ... put a new and right spirit within me… purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow* (Ps 51:9.12.13).

233. In the New Testament all these aspects are taken up and acquire new meaning in the light of Jesus' revelation of the Holy Spirit as a Divine Person, who is present in the very life of the Incarnate Word in a most special way. The Spirit is author of the hypostatic union which is called "grace of union";[271] therefore, the Incarnation is His work: *The Holy Spirit will come upon you* (Lk 1:35). Henceforth, Christ "is the supreme wonder carried out by the Holy Spirit."[272] As we profess in the Creed, "He was conceived by the Holy Spirit"[273] – "by the power of the Spirit."[274] This same Spirit is the author of Jesus' holiness: *Therefore the child to be born will be called holy* (Lk 1:35). The response of the Blessed Virgin, from

[270] Cf. Gn 1:1.

[271] Cf. SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 7, 13.

[272] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Catechesis during the General Audience, March 28, 1990.

[273] Apostle's Creed. DZ 7.

[274] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 32, 2, 1.

which the Incarnation followed, is a fruit of the Holy Spirit's action in her soul.[275] His action establishes a most personal relationship, a spousal and nuptial union with Her. That union is a model for us,[276] since the Spirit dwells in us (Cf. 1 Cor 3:16), and in every soul in grace. The Spirit is also present in Jesus' prayer and messianic preaching. Christ applies the fulfillment of the prophecy of Is 61:1 to Himself: *The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed, to proclaim the acceptable year of the Lord* (Lk 4:18.19). The Spirit is the source of Christ's joy: *In that same hour he rejoiced in the Holy Spirit* (Lk 10:21). From the Holy Spirit Christ has the power to expel demons: *But if it is by the Spirit of God that I cast out demons, then the kingdom of God has come upon you* (Mt 12:28). The Spirit is present in His redeeming Sacrifice, which Jesus calls "baptism": *Are you able to drink the cup that I drink, or to be baptized with the baptism with which I am baptized?* (Mk 10:38); *I came to cast fire upon the earth; and would that it were already kindled! I have a baptism to be baptized with; and how I am constrained until it is accomplished!* (Lk 12:49.50). John the Baptist had already announced that *he who is coming after me…will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and with fire* (Mt 3:11); and we are taught that *through the eternal Spirit [He] offered himself without blemish to God* (Heb 9:14). Finally, the Holy Spirit is author of the Resurrection of Christ: *Being put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit* (1 Pt 3:18). Here, the Holy Spirit manifests Himself as Life-Giver, "Lord and giver of life,"[277] as we profess in the Nicene Creed. The Gospel, the New Law, consists of the Holy Spirit's grace; that is why it is "the law of

[275] Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Catechesis during the General Audience, April 18, 1990; OR (4/22/1990) Spanish Edition.

[276] Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Catechesis during the General Audience, April 18, 1990; OR (4/22/1990) Spanish Edition.

[277] COUNCIL OF CONSTANTINOPLE I, The Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed. DZ 86.

life": *The law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set me free from the law of sin and death* (Rom 8:2).

234. After Jesus' Resurrection and Ascension into Heaven, the Spirit is sent to the Church, according to the promise of the Lord: *When the Counselor comes, whom I shall send to you from the Father, even the Spirit of truth, who proceeds from the Father, he will bear witness to me* (Jn 15:26). "Once the Lord Jesus was exalted on the cross and glorified, the Spirit that had been promised was poured out, by the one which called and congregated in unity of faith, hope, and charity to the people of the New Testament which is the Church."[278] This sending forth was fulfilled on the day of Pentecost: *All were filled with the Holy Spirit* (Acts 2:1-4). Therefore, the Holy Spirit is a gift given by God to the Church: *You will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit* (Acts 2:38). The Holy Spirit is a gift that vivifies the Church: *Jesus answered her, "If you knew the gift of God, and who it is that is saying to you, 'Give me a drink,' you would have asked him, and he would have given you living water"* (Jn 4:10). The Holy Spirit vivifies the Church so much so that it is correctly called the "Soul of the Church." The Spirit "gives life to, unifies and moves the whole body. The Church Fathers compared His work to the function that the soul, principle of life, fulfills in the human body."[279] Therefore, the Holy Spirit is the source of the Church's unity: *By one Spirit we were all baptized into one body* (1 Cor 12:13); this unity is based on charity, also a fruit of the Spirit's action: *God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit which has been given to us* (Rom 5:5). Saint Augustine rightly called the Holy Spirit, "Kiss, Love, Knot of union between the Father and the Son."[280] The Spirit is also the source of the Church's holiness, since He is Holy: *Spirit of holiness* (Rom 1:4), performing the work of sanctification: *God chose you…through sanctification by the Spirit* (2 Thes 2:13).

---

[278] UR 2.
[279] LG 7.
[280] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Holy Trinity*, 6, 5, 7.

235. The Holy Spirit performs this sanctification inwardly in our hearts: *God's Spirit dwells in you* (1 Cor 3:16). By this renewing presence the Holy Spirit transforms us, making us children of God: *Because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, "Abba! Father!" So through God you are no longer a slave but a son, and if a son, then an heir* (Gal 4:6-7). *All who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God* (Rom 8:14ff). The Holy Spirit renews us, makes us new creatures made by God: *You also are built into it for a dwelling place of God in the Spirit* (Eph 2:22). By this renewal and purification, we can have access to the Father in the Holy Spirit: *For through him we both have access in one Spirit to the Father* (Eph 2:18). He is the guarantee of eternal life: *Sealed with the promised Holy Spirit, which is the guarantee of our inheritance* (Eph 1:13-14). He teaches us all things, because *the Holy Spirit examines all*,[281] *He will teach you all the things* (Jn 14:26). He is the *Spirit of Truth* (Jn 14:17). He is our helper: *The Spirit helps us in our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with sighs too deep for words* (Rom 8:26). He enriches the Church with the diversity of His gifts: *All these are inspired by one and the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as he wills* (1 Cor 12:11). Therefore, we must always ask the Lord to grant us His Holy Spirit, and docility to Him, so that we may belong to Christ more and more, and therefore to His mystical Body, since *any one who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him* (Rom 8:9). God never denies this most valuable gift which the whole New Law consists of, and therefore, our salvation consists of: *If you then, who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!* (Lk 11:13). We must then understand that *the kingdom of God is… righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit* (Rom 14:17).

[281] Cf. 1 Cor 2:10-11.

The Word of God

236. The Holy Spirit is the Principal Author of Sacred Scripture because He wants us to have our fill at "the table of the Word."[282] "The Holy Spirit begot Sacred Scripture with more abundant truth than men can understand."[283] The Bible is closely united to the mystery of the Incarnate Word, "For as the substantial Word of God became like to men in all things, 'except sin,' so the words of God, expressed in human language, are made like to human speech in every respect, except error."[284]

237. The wealth of this heavenly treasure[285] of the Word of God is seen, among other things, by the fact that it is:

contained in the Holy Books,
celebrated in the Holy Liturgy,
commented by the Church Fathers,
witnessed by the martyrs,
deepened by the Doctors,
genuinely interpreted by the Church Magisterium,
and lived by the saints of all times.

238. The Word of God must be "deepened in the Church,"[286] with the same Spirit in which it was written.[287] This is precisely

[282] DV 21; SC 51.

[283] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary to the First Book of the Sentences* 12, 1, 2, ad 7.

[284] PIUS XII, *Divino Aflante Spiritus*; Enchiridium Biblicum 559. Same words are found in DV 13.

[285] Cf. SC 51.

[286] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Bishops of Mali, March 26, 1988; OR (4/24/1988) Spanish Edition; cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the International Council of the Bishop of Our Lady, September 19, 1979; passim; OR (9/30/1979) Spanish Edition.

[287] DV 11.

our Institute's true strength, "as it is its supreme sacramental proclamation in the Eucharistic Sacrifice."[288]

239. Sacred Scripture must be the "soul of our soul," of our spirituality, theology, preaching, catechesis and pastoral work. What Saint Jerome said about an acquaintance should also be said of us, "Indeed by constant reading and long-continued meditation, he had made his breast a library of Christ,"[289] since for us, "The Word of God is nothing less than the Body of Christ."[290]

D. ONE CHURCH

240. "This is the only one Church of Christ, which in the Creed we profess to be one, holy, catholic and apostolic."[291]

241. The Church of Christ is one and only. The idea of *koinonia* (communion) adequately expresses the profound nucleus of the Church's Mystery, because it is the mystery of the personal union of each man with the Holy Trinity and with other men, beginning with faith and baptism.

242. This common union includes both a vertical dimension – communion with God – and a horizontal dimension – communion with men. This unity is a gift from God, a fruit of the divine initiative accomplished in the Paschal Mystery.

243. Ecclesial communion is both invisible and visible. As the invisible reality, it is the communion of each man: with the Father through Christ in the Holy Spirit; with other men, who

[288] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Bishops of the Episcopal Conference of Pakistan, March 16, 1985; OR (3/24/1985) Spanish Edition.

[289] SAINT JEROME, *Letter to Heliodorus*, 60, 10.

[290] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Sermo Suppositus*, 300.

[291] LG 8.

also participate in sanctifying grace;[292] in the Passion of Christ;[293] in the same faith;[294] in the same Spirit.[295] This invisible reality maintains an intimate relationship with the visible communion founded upon the doctrine of the Apostles, the sacraments and the hierarchical order. This relationship between the visible and invisible aspects of ecclesial communion is a constitutive element of the Church "as the universal Sacrament of salvation."[296]

244. This hierarchical and mystical reality – visible and spiritual, terrestrial and celestial, canonical and charismatic, human and divine – resembles "the mystery of the Incarnate Word"[297] by way of a deep analogy since "the same Christ is embodied in his Body, the Church."[298] Therefore, we who are proud to call ourselves religious *of the Incarnate Word* would gravely betray our charism if we did not work to have an authentic ecclesial spirituality that incorporates us fully into the Church of the Incarnate Word. We do not want to know anything apart from her.

245. The most solid unity goes hand-in-hand with a diversity that does not block unity and makes it a communion. The Church's universality in "the unity of faith and [its] only divine structure,"[299] accepts the plurality of ministries, charisms, ways of life and apostolate, diverse liturgical and cultural traditions, theologies, spiritualities and disciplines. This reality admirably shows "the catholicity of the undivided Church."[300]

---

[292] Cf. 2 Pt 1:4.
[293] Cf. 2 Cor 1:7.
[294] Cf. Eph 4:13.
[295] Cf. Phil 2:1.
[296] LG 48.
[297] LG 8.
[298] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse during the Prayer Meeting in Toronto, September 15, 1984; OR (9/30/1984) Spanish Edition.
[299] LG 23.
[300] LG 23.

246. We must be fervent promoters "of the unity that does not block diversity, as well as... a diversity that does not block unity, but enriches it."[301] We are called daily to edify, respect and safeguard this unity-in-diversity, especially by means of that love which is the bond of perfection (Col 3:14). As the Angelic doctor said, "The Church is one... by the unity of charity, since all are united in loving God, and bound to one another in mutual love."[302]

247. Religious institutes are an expression of this unity-in-diversity, and we wish to be numbered among them. Although they do not belong to the Church's hierarchical structure, they belong "undeniably to her life and holiness."[303] When institutes have a supra-diocesan character, rooted in the Petrine ministry, they also work together for communion among the various local Churches. Our experience has allowed us to see the importance of this truth for our spirituality.

Agree With One Another

248. We aspire, according to the words of Saint Paul, to *agree with one another* (2 Cor 13:11) *in the Lord* (Phil 4:2). This unanimity or concordance we seek means unity in the judgment of reason about what must be done and unity in the will so that all may want the same thing. This concordance is born of the same faith by which we know what must be done, and from charity by which we all love the same goods and share the same burdens like good soldiers of Jesus Christ.[304] This union exists because we all feel the same about God, since wisdom – the sweet-tasting knowledge of divine things – reigns among all. *It is not a wisdom of this age or of the*

[301] CONGREGATION FOR THE DOCTRINE OF THE FAITH, Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on some Aspects of the Church understood as Communion, 15.

[302] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on the Creed*, IX, 116.

[303] LG 44.

[304] Cf. 2 Tm 2:3.

rulers of this age… But we impart a secret and hidden wisdom of God (1 Cor 2:6-7). Only the crucified Jesus Christ can grant this wisdom, *to those who are called… the power of God and the wisdom of God* (1 Cor 1:24).

249. The Kingdom of God becomes present in this *harmony with one another* (Rom 12:16), since "the kingdom's nature, therefore, is one of communion among all human beings with one another and with God."[305]

250. This supposes that each member of our Religious Family not only rejoices *in the Holy Spirit* (Rom 14:17) with the good he possesses, but also that each tends unceasingly toward a greater perfection: *Brethren, I do not consider that I have made it my own; but one thing I do, forgetting what lies behind and straining forward to what lies ahead* (Phil 3:13).

251. This also presumes that everyone casts aside everything that impedes or distorts this unanimity of agreement. The first thing we must cast aside is pride, a pride that drives us to inordinately seek our own excellence, and to refuse to submit to others or to recognize their excellence. Pride produces discord: *By insolence the heedless make strife* (Prv 13:10). Another obstacle to this unanimity of agreement is the presumption of wisdom, thinking oneself to be self-sufficient, thereby refusing other's teachings, which is contrary to St. Paul's example: *I went up by revelation; and I laid before them (but privately before those who were of repute) the gospel I preach among the Gentiles, lest somehow I should be running or had run in vain* (Gal 2:2).

252. The Holy Spirit poured into our hearts – the New Law – makes us *maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace* (Eph 4:3). Through love, He removes us from selfishness, individualism, a spirit of opposition and distrust, a spirit of unwillingness, of non-

[305] RMs 15.

participation, of non-consent with others. The Spirit of Christ is the Spirit of communion: *Live in harmony with one another* (Rom 12:16), in such a way that we will truly care for others: *that the members may have the same care for one another* (1 Cor 12:25). Hence, in our communities, which must demonstrate a unity among people and a body full of thinking members – no one should behave as if he is all on his own, as a self-sufficient "nomad." We should learn to act like the parts or members of a whole.

253. Submissiveness and servility are also destructive of this union. These traits sacrifice truth and one's own conscience by seeking a false peace, or by not admonishing a friend, or by avoiding some problem or, on occasion, by taking advantage of a situation by silence or applause. Whoever does such things resembles those Jews that *believed in him, but for fear of the Pharisees, they did not confess it, lest they should be put out of the synagogue: for they loved the praise of men more than the praise of God* (Jn 12: 42-43).

254. The fruit of this "**agreement-in-the-Lord**" is peace: *The harvest of righteousness is sown in peace by those who make peace* (Jas 3:18). True peace, given by Christ,[306] is tranquility in order. It arises naturally when everyone, by faith and charity, is ordained to God. Along with peace, another fruit of this *harmony with one another, in accord with Christ Jesus* (Rom 15:5) is the unity that reigns among all, even in the least details of daily life or any decision. This is possible because each person has the certainty that in everything we do, we will seek the glory of God, with a single heart and a single soul.[307]

[306] Cf. Jn 14:27.
[307] Cf. Act 4:32.

E. THE HOLY CHURCH

255. The Church is the Communion of Saints.[308] It is a common union attained by visibly participating in the holy goods, especially the Eucharist, the root of the common, invisible union of the participants, the saints. There is a spiritual *koinonia* among members of the same Body that leads to an effective union in charity and prayer. This *koinonia* exists not only among the pilgrims still on Earth, but also between them and those who have arrived in Heaven or are in Purgatory, on their way to Heaven.

256. There is a mutual relationship between the diverse stages of the one Church. This mutual relationship is founded on: the intercession of Christ for us: *He always lives to intercede for us* (Heb 7:25); the intercession of the saints to whom "we are most closely united";[309] the example of the saints who "spur us to seek the future city… the perfect union with Christ, holiness";[310] the intercession of the Holy Virgin Mary in "whose protection the faithful take refuge together in prayer in all their perils and needs."[311] This is why a profound devotion to the saints responds to the reality of the Church as mystery-of-communion.

257. The saints are eloquent signs of the Church's vitality. By embodying the Church's mark of holiness, they are an apologetic asset of the truth of our faith. They are the best members of the mystical Body of Christ, the best and most complete fruit of the Incarnation and the Redemption. Therefore, they transform the world with their example and with the power of their intercession. They constantly remind us of Heaven, eternal life, and the reward of merits: God Himself! In honoring them, we honor God, because the saints are His masterpieces, and by "crowning their

[308] Council of Constantinople I, The Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed. DZ Schon. 19; 25-30.

[309] LG 50.

[310] LG 50.

[311] LG 66.

merits, the Lord crowns His own gifts."[312] Even after their death, they fulfill posthumous missions, pushing whole generations to the heroism of following Jesus Christ, *being not only to the young but to the great body of his nation.... example of nobility and a memorial of courage* (2 Mac 6:31). That is why there is no historical record more complete, more magnificent, and more beneficial than the Litany of the Saints, which evokes and invokes all the great souls who have illuminated our earth and who have advanced humanity with their virtues. We must venerate their relics, which never stop working.

258. Therefore, for our part, we must do everything possible to assure that the face of the Church be *without spot or wrinkle or any such thing, that she might be holy and without blemish* (Eph 5:27). We must always remember the irreplaceable importance of sanctifying grace, given by the worthy reception of sacraments, the "divine relics of the Incarnation."[313]

F. CATHOLIC CHURCH

259. The Church of Christ is the universal community of the Lord's disciples that extends to all times, places, races, languages and cultures. This is what "Catholic" means.

260. The Church is "Catholic" also in her doctrine. Some people emphasize the teachings of Saint John, others emphasize those of Saint Paul, etc. There is a variety of theological schools. There are different venerable liturgical rites, and we wish our Institute to have an "Oriental Branch" to help our brothers of the Eastern Churches, since they are part of the "undivided heritage of the universal Church."[314] We must not succumb to localism, reductionism, partialities, or unilateralism that threaten catholicity.

---

[312] Cf. SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Letter* 194, 5, 19.
[313] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Sententiae ad Annibaldum*, 1, 4.
[314] OE 1. Nowadays, by God's grace we have two Oriental Branches.

The Catholic Church breathes with two lungs: "One cannot breathe like a Christian, or better said as a Catholic, with a single lung; it is necessary to have two lungs, that is to say, the Eastern and the Western."[315]

261. The universal Church is "a corporate body of Churches";[316] therefore, it is a communion of local Churches. They are "parts... of the only Church of Christ";[317] they are constituted "after the model of the universal Church";[318] in them "is found and operates the true Church of Christ, which is One, Holy, Catholic, and Apostolic."[319] They have a special relationship of "mutual interiority"[320] with the universal Church. The universal Church, in its essential mystery, is both an ontological and chronological reality, prior to each specific and concrete Church. The Church-mystery is mother of the specific Churches, her daughters.

262. We do not belong to the universal Church through the mediation of a particular Church. By faith and baptism we are **directly** incorporated into the One, Holy, Catholic and Apostolic

---

[315] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Representatives from the Non-Catholic Christian Communities, May 13, 1980; OR (6/8/1980) Spanish Edition. "As he professed the Catholic credo in the Basilica of Saint Peter in Rome on 17 March 1926 Ivanov was aware, as he wrote to Charles du Bos, of feeling for the first time orthodox in the full meaning of this word, in the full possession of the sacred treasure which was mine since my baptism, and whose enjoyment have never for all these years been free from a feeling of uneasiness, which gradually became suffering caused by my being severed from the other half of this living treasury of holiness and grace, and of breathing, so to speak in the manner of a consumptive, with only one lung" [Ivanov, Letter to Charles du Bos 1930, in V. IVANOV AND M. GARSEHENSON, *Correspondance d'un coin a l'autre*, Laussane 1979, 99]: BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Participants to the International Symposium on "Ivanov and the Culture of his Time", May 28, 1983; OR (7/24/1983) Spanish Edition.

[316] LG 23.

[317] CD 6.

[318] LG 23.

[319] CD 11.

[320] Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Roman Curia, December 20, 1990; OR (12/28/1990) Spanish Edition.

Church, although entrance and life in the universal Church are necessarily carried out in a specific Church. Therefore, no one is a stranger in the Church.[321] He who belongs to a particular Church belongs to all the Churches – without disrupting canonical dependence.[322] Belonging to the Communion of the Church is never exclusively specific, but rather – due to its nature – is in itself always universal: "He who is in Rome deems the Indians as her members."[323]

Missionary and Ecumenical Church

263. Since the universal Church is "the universal Sacrament of salvation,"[324] she is open – not closed – to missionary and ecumenical dynamics; she has been sent to announce and to testify, to enact and to extend the mystery of the communion that is constitutive of her; to gather all and everything in Christ.[325] As an image of the Church, our small Religious Family must never be closed off, but rather must be open like the arms of Christ on the Cross that were "dislocated" for love's sake.

264. The Holy Spirit, present and acting in every time and place, acts "in the heart of every person, through the 'seeds of the Word,' to be found in human initiatives – including religious ones – and in mankind's efforts to attain truth, goodness, and God Himself."[326] Our mission, therefore, is to joyfully and respectfully discover these seeds, so that men may awaken to a stronger desire of truth and charity,[327] since "the Holy Spirit in a manner known

321 Cf. Gal 3:28.
322 Cf. CIC, can. 107.
323 SAINT JOHN CHRYSOSTOM, *Homilies on the Gospel of John*, 65, 1. MG 59,361.
324 LG 48.
325 Cf. Mt 28:19-20; Jn 17:21-23; Eph 1:10; LG 9.13.17; AG 1.
326 RMs 28.
327 Cf. AG 11.

only to God offers to every man the possibility of being associated with this paschal mystery."[328]

265. This presence of the Spirit "affects not only individuals, but also society and history, peoples, cultures, and religions… [it] is the Spirit who sows the 'seeds of the Word' present in various customs and cultures, preparing them for full maturity in Christ,"[329] because the Holy Spirit already worked in the world before Christ was glorified.[330]

266. This work of the Holy Spirit is an evangelical preparation and "can only be understood in relation to Christ, the Word who took flesh by the power of the Spirit."[331] Consequently, it "is not to be separated from His particular activity within the body of Christ, the Church."[332]

267. Therefore, the teaching of Saint Ambrose, "all that is true, said by any person, comes from the Holy Spirit,"[333] will forever be like a torch that illuminates our work. The saints affirmed and believed that, "Whatever things were rightly said among all men, are the property of us Christians";[334] "that all good Christians understand that whatever truth, wherever truth may be found, belongs to his Master";[335] "no one can say anything true [of his own accord], but only moved by the Holy Spirit who is Spirit of Truth";[336] "there is no knowledge of the truth but only in the Holy Spirit who works in the intelligence and preserves

[328] GS 22.
[329] RMs 28.
[330] Cf. SAINT LEO THE GREAT, *Sermon* 76.
[331] RMs 29.
[332] RMs 29.
[333] Quoted by SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *De Veritate*, 1, 8 s. c.
[334] SAINT JUSTIN, *Apologia* 2, 13.
[335] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *On the Christian Doctrine* II, 18.28.
[336] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Super I ad Cor* 11, 12, 1.

it";[337] "all which is good and all which is true is from the Holy Spirit."[338]

268. Thanks to the teaching of Christ, we know that there is a humanity that opposes faith and the gift of grace, called the "world"[339] by the Lord Himself. Facing this "world" – to which Christ sends us *as sheep in the midst of wolves* (Mt 10:16) – Saint Paul admonishes: *Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind* (Rom 12:2). However, this difference from the "world" does not mean that we are afraid of the "world," or contemptuous of it,[340] since if one is conscious of what the Lord wants, the duty of evangelization and the urgency of the mission become apparent. Therefore, a merely conservative attitude is not enough, but rather the diffusion and the announcement of the deposit of the faith are necessary, according to the command of Christ. **Dialogue** is the name we give to "this internal drive of charity which seeks expression in the external gift of charity."[341]

269. This dialogue, which is a spiritual communication, has its transcendent origin in God Himself: "In the Incarnation and in the Gospel, it is God's Word that speaks to us."[342] Such a dialogue of God with men is born from divine love and is directed to all men without forcing anyone.

270. We must know and "adopt the way of life of ordinary people in all that is human and honorable",[343] without succumbing to the danger of weakening or diminishing the truth, since "an immoderate desire to make peace and sink differences at all costs (irenism and syncretism) is ultimately nothing more than skepticism about the power and content of the Word of God

337 SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on the Book of Sentences*, 28, 3, 1.
338 SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *Reportationes ineditae Leoninae*, 3, 12, 3.
339 Cf. Jn 15:18-22.
340 Cf. ES 63.
341 ES 64.
342 ES 70.
343 ES 87.

which we desire to preach."[344] "The effective apostle is the man who is completely faithful to Christ's teaching. He alone can remain unaffected by the errors of the world around him, the man who lives his Christian life to the full."[345]

271. Preaching has particular importance. It must always be "skillfully expressed, carefully thought-out, and zealously imparted. May it be supported by the evidence of real virtue. Progress must be its aim. It must concern itself with imparting a sure faith."[346]

272. Although this dialogue embraces all men, four environments, or "circles," are distinguished in which this spiritual communication is carried out, according to the different attitudes of people:

273. The first circle is of those with whom we share human values, in order to elevate them to the supernatural and Christian level.[347] Most striking in this environment is the problem of atheism, founded on false theories and not consisting of "a liberating force, but a catastrophic one, for it seeks to quench the light of the living God."[348] Dialogue is especially difficult in these circumstances, and "we must come to a prudent decision about them, and answer them effectively,"[349] and we must know that there are many situations that are occasions for such dialogue.

274. The second circle is of those who worship one God. Among them are Jews, Muslims and the faithful from African and Asian religions. Aware that the true religion is Christianity, and yearning for all those who seek God to recognize it as such, we must recognize the many spiritual and moral values that they

344 ES 88.
345 ES 88.
346 ES 91.
347 Cf. ES 97.
348 ES 100.
349 ES 104.

possess, and the ideals that can be promoted and defended in common.[350]

275. The third circle "comprises all those who take their name from Christ. In our dialogues, we should first stress what unites us, and then what divides us." We must demonstrate how those elements of the Church that may look like obstacles for union are fruits of the will of Christ for the benefit, unity and freedom of all. In particular, we need to demonstrate that the Primacy of Peter perpetuated in the Pope is not an obstacle: "Take away the sovereign Pontiff, and the Catholic Church would no longer be Catholic."[351] Without the Roman Pontiff "we shall have as many schisms in the Churches as there are priests."[352]

276. Finally, the fourth circle of dialogue is carried out among the Catholic faithful, children of God's house. This dialogue "does not mean that the virtue of obedience is no longer operative. The right to command and the duty to obey must be present."[353] Rather, it presumes obedience, because "the very exercise of authority becomes, in the context of this dialogue, an exercise of obedience, the obedient performance of a service, a ministry of truth and charity."[354]

277. In order to be men of authentic dialogue, we must learn how to practice the following virtues: "**Clarity** before all else; the dialogue demands that what is said should be intelligible. We can think of it as a kind of thought transfusion… **affability**… It would indeed be a disgrace if our dialogue were marked by arrogance, the use of harsh words or offensive bitterness. What gives it authority is the fact that it affirms the truth, shares with others the gifts of charity, is itself an example of virtue, avoids

350 Cf. ES 107-108.
351 ES 110.
352 SAINT JEROME, *Dialogue against the Luciferians*: ML 23, 164.
353 ES 114.
354 ES 115.

peremptory language, makes no demands… **Confidence** is also necessary, confidence not only in the power of one's own words, but also in the good will of both parties to dialogue. Hence dialogue promotes intimacy and friendship on both sides… **Prudence** of a teacher who is most careful to make allowances for the psychological and moral circumstances of his listener…[355] The person who speaks always takes pains to learn the sensitivities of his audience, and if reason demands it, he adapts himself and the manner of his presentation to the susceptibilities and the degree of intelligence of his listeners."[356] "Moreover, the very fact that he engages in a dialogue of this sort is proof of his consideration and esteem for others, his understanding and his kindness. He detests bigotry and prejudice, malicious and indiscriminate hostility, and empty, boastful speech… True dialogue respects a man's freedom and dignity… we nevertheless try to help him and to prepare him for a fuller sharing of ideas and convictions… Our dialogue, therefore, presupposes that we have a state of mind… that is characteristic of the man who realizes the seriousness of the apostolic mission…"[357]

278. We must also embrace the holy cause of ecumenism. There is a promise-prophecy of the Lord: *There shall be one flock, one shepherd* (Jn 10:16), and a prayer of the Lord, *That they may all be one* (Jn 17:21). By prayer, penance, study, dialogue, and collaboration, we must strive to reach full communion in the unity of the Church "which Christ bestowed on his Church from the beginning. We believe that this unity subsists in the Catholic Church as something she can never lose, and we hope that it will continue to increase until the end of time,"[358] in order "that in a renewed conversion to the Lord, the following may become possible to all: to recognize the permanency of the Primacy of

[355] Cf. Mt 7:6.
[356] ES 81.
[357] Cf. ES 79-80.
[358] UR 4.

Peter in his successors, the Bishops of Rome, and that the Petrine ministry may be carried out just as it is understood by the Lord, as universal apostolic service, present in all the Churches **from the inside**, and that, preserving the substance of the Petrine ministry as a divine institution, it can be expressed in diverse ways..."[359] The ecumenical commitment is to "pray and to work for reconciliation and for ecclesiastic unity according to the mind and heart of our Savior Jesus Christ."[360]

G. THE APOSTOLIC CHURCH

279. Another exciting reality of the immeasurable mystery of the Church of the Incarnate Word is its apostolicity: founded upon the Apostles and perpetuated by apostolic succession.

280. Besides being based on faith, baptism and Eucharist, the communion among the particular Churches in the universal Church is based on the Episcopacy. Church unity is also rooted in the unity of the Episcopacy: in order that the Church "might be one and undivided, Christ put Peter at the head of the other apostles, and in him He set up a lasting and visible source and foundation of the unity of both faith and communion."[361]

281. "The individual bishops are the visible source and foundation of unity in their own particular Churches, which are established after the model of the universal Church."[362] For this to exist, the Church's supreme authority, the College of Bishops "together with their head, the Supreme Pontiff, and never apart

[359] CONGREGATION FOR THE DOCTRINE OF THE FAITH, Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on some Aspects of the Church understood as Communion, 18.

[360] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse during the Ecumenical Meeting at the Cathedral of Canterbury, May 29, 1982; OR (6/6/1982) Spanish Edition.

[361] LG 18.

[362] LG 23.

from him"[363] must be present in the particular Church as a proper component. The Primacy of the Bishop of Rome and the College of Bishops are proper elements of the universal Church; they are not derived from the particular Churches, but are internal to each particular Church. "In the Pope we see Jesus Christ, we follow Jesus Christ, we love Jesus Christ. And in the Bishops? In the Bishops we see, we continue, we venerate and we love the successors of the Apostles."[364] Each one of the members of our Religious Family "wants to belong entirely to the Pope, the Bishops and the Church: worthless things, servants and obedient children of the Church, the Bishops and the Pope, in humility, with fidelity, with love without limits."[365]

282. Therefore, we must have eyes of faith to always recognize those whom *the Holy Spirit has made… overseers, to care for the church of the Lord* (Acts 20:28). We must make the advice of Saint Ignatius of Antioch our own: "Neither do anything without the bishop and presbyters,"[366] and even less so, something against them.

283. The Saint Louis Orione also advised: "The Bishop's state is the most perfect of all, even more than the religious state; to him the fullness of the priesthood; to him more than to any other is given the spirit of Faith, Wisdom and Fortitude... The Bishop doesn't have enemies; to him all are but children. The smallest ones, the most humble and the most disgraced ones are dearer to him. He prays for everyone. He has words of everlasting life for everyone. For everyone he goes to the altar and offers the blood of the Immaculate Lamb that takes away the sins of the world… The Bishop is the Good Shepherd who watches over, who tends the sheep, who evangelizes, who knows how to suffer in silence, who knows how to give his life up for his sheep."[367] Church

[363] LG 22; cf. LG 19.
[364] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of July 15, 1936*.
[365] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of July 15, 1936*.
[366] SAINT IGNATIUS OF ANTIOCH, *To the Magnesians*, 7, 1.
[367] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of February 6, 1935*.

history offers us numerous examples of glorious figures of the Episcopate: bishops who evangelized and founded nations, defended and organized peoples, keeping the deposit of faith entrusted to them[368] amid the cruelest of persecutions, and who reinforced the Church's sound doctrine in the face of a multitude of errors and confusions. For this reason, "Let us love the Bishops!"[369]

284. Not only is communion with the Bishop necessary, but we must also strive for communion with other priests "under the authority of the bishop,"[370] who is *God's steward* (Ti 1:7). This communion forms a single presbytery based on the common participation of Christ's Priesthood: "In virtue of their sacred ordination and of their common mission, all priests are united together by bonds of intimate brotherhood, which manifests itself in a spontaneously and gladly-given mutual help, whether spiritual or temporal, whether pastoral or personal."[371]

285. Unity with other priests, both diocesan and religious, is primarily obtained in the "intimate sacramental brotherhood";[372] and from this we wish to establish close collaboration in pastoral work, since "even though they have diverse occupations, they exercise a single priestly ministry in the service of men."[373] For this reason, "Between the secular clergy and the religious communities, a renewed brotherhood and a bond of cooperation must be encouraged; having in great esteem certain mutual help

368 Cf. 1 Tm 6:20.
369 SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of Pentecost*, 1912.
370 AG 20.
371 LG 28.
372 PO 8.
373 PO 8.

and certain contacts... that help mutual trust, apostolic unanimity and fraternal concord in such a great way…"[374]

286. This unity and cooperation which we want to establish with other members of the presbytery to whatever degree possible, leads us to preach Jesus Christ without any division,[375] by word and example of life, and allows us to be aware that we are *ministers of a new covenant, not in a written code but in the Spirit* (2 Cor 3:6), and therefore it leads us to *bear one another's burdens* (Gal 6:2) in this serious ministry.

287. Paraphrasing the Apostle,[376] we want to do good always, to everyone, whenever possible, especially to our brothers in the priesthood bestowed by the laying on of hands.[377]

288. God's marvelous gift of consecrated life – priests, deacons, religious, missionaries and consecrated lay people – "affects the whole Church in her fundamental mark of apostolicity."[378]

289. The foundation of this essentially supernatural work resides in God's very choice and call: *You did not choose me, but I chose you and appointed you that you should go and bear fruit* (Jn 15:16); when choosing the Twelve, the Lord *went up the mountain and summoned those whom he wanted, and they came to him* (Mk 3:13). Vocations are God's property: *I pray for them. I do not pray for the world but for the ones you have given me, because they are yours, and everything of mine is yours and everything of yours is mine* (Jn 17:9-10).

---

[374] SACRED CONGREGATION FOR RELIGIOUS AND FOR SECULAR INSTITUTES AND SACRED CONGREGATION FOR BISHOPS, Directives for the Mutual Relations between Bishops and Religious, 37.

[375] Cf. 1 Cor 1:10.

[376] Cf. Gal 6:10.

[377] Cf. 1 Tm 4:14.

[378] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Regina Coeli Message, April 23, 1989; OR (4/23/1989) Spanish Edition.

290. We would want God to give us the gift of being able to discover and to guide so many vocations that we would fill all the good seminaries and novitiates in the entire world, according to the Pope's recommendation: "God calls who he wants, by his free initiative of love. But he wants to call through us... There shouldn't be any fear in directly proposing the Lord's call to a young person."[379] Therefore, vocational ministry should be active, constant, full of energy and vitality, undertaken and spurred forward by the charity of Christ,[380] and definitely opposed to a mentality of "ordinary administration or bureaucratic slowness,"[381] which carelessly hopes that vocations knock upon its door. God "sows seeds of vocation to full hands by grace."[382]

291. The vitality of a community, and of the Church herself, can be measured by the vocations that God raises in it. Inseparably united with promoting vocations is the proper formation of those chosen; hence, we must recognize the importance "of making intense efforts to encourage vocations and to offer the best possible priestly formation in seminaries. An abundance of vocations and an effective formation of seminarians are two tests of the Church's vitality."[383]

292. The task of discovering and guiding vocations is achieved not only through an enthusiastic pastoral action, but essentially through prayer: *Pray, therefore, the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into his harvest* (Mt 9:38); *I planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the growth* (1 Cor 3:6). One's example and life testimony go together with prayer: "Where there is faith, prayer, charity, apostolate,

---

379 BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Message to the XX World Day of Prayer for Vocations, April 24, 1983; OR (4/17/1983) Spanish Edition.

380 Cf. 2 Cor 5:14.

381 BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to Priests and Religious at the Cathedral of Siena, April 14, 1980; OR (4/21/1980) Spanish Edition.

382 Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Message to the XXIX World Day of Prayer for Vocations, May 10, 1992; OR (12/20/1991) Spanish Edition.

383 BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Homily during the Mass celebrated at the Major Regional Seminary in Seoul, May 3, 1984; OR (5/13/1984) Spanish Edition.

Christian life, there the gifts of God multiply,"[384] because "the religious and priests who live their vocation calmly day by day, faithful to their commitments, humble and hidden builders of the Kingdom of God from whose words, behavior, and life irradiates the luminous joy of the choice that they made... are in fact... those that by their example will stimulate many to welcome in their hearts the charism of vocation."[385]

293. Hence all anti-testimony, all incoherence between expressing values or ideals and living them, all looking out for oneself and not for the Kingdom of God and its justice,[386] all falsification of the word of God,[387] "are often strong obstacles for those who feel the call of Christ: *Come and follow me*."[388]

H. IN THE "THREE WHITE THINGS"[389]

The Eucharist

294. Ecclesial communion has its root and its center in the Holy Eucharist. The Eucharist is the source and creative force of communion among the Church's members because it unites each one with the same Christ: "Really sharing in the body of the Lord

---

[384] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Message to the XX World Day of Prayer for Vocations, April 4, 1983; OR (4/17/1983) Spanish Edition.

[385] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the National Council and Regional Secretaries for the Work of Vocations, February 16, 1980; OR (3/23/1980) Spanish Edition.

[386] Cf. Mt 6:33.

[387] Cf. 2 Cor 4:2.

[388] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Discourse to the Bishops of the United States, February 22, 1980; OR (4/30/1989) Spanish Edition.

[389] Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Message on the 500th Anniversary of the first Mass in America, December 12, 1994; OR (1/14/1994) Spanish Edition. "Missionaries fostered the three great loves that have characterized the Catholic faith of your peoples: love to the Eucharist, love to the Mother of the Savior, and love to the Church in the person of the successor of Peter. In these three great loves you will find [the] light, strength and inspiration needed to carry out the huge work of the New Evangelization that lies ahead of you."

in the breaking of the Eucharistic bread, we are taken up into communion with Him and with one another. *Because the bread is one, we, though many, are one body, all of us who partake of the one bread* (1 Cor 10:17)."[390] "The common spiritual good of the whole Church is contained substantially[391] in the sacrament of the Eucharist itself," "which is Christ."[392]

295. The Church is the Body of Christ. This means that in the Eucharist, in which the Lord gives His Body and transforms us into one Body[393], the Church permanently expresses herself in her most essential form: present everywhere at the same time, **one** like Christ.

296. In the Eucharist all the faithful find themselves "in their own Church", since in all valid Eucharistic celebrations, the One, Holy, Catholic and Apostolic Church becomes present. The faithful are indeed "in their own Church" even though, from a canonical point of view, they may or may not belong to the particular diocese, parish or community where the celebration is being carried out.

297. Besides being based on faith, Baptism and Episcopacy, – the communion of specific Churches in the universal Church is fundamentally based upon the Eucharist. Since in the Eucharist we receive the Lord and His gift of salvation, the Eucharistic Sacrifice never belongs to a particular community. Each community is thereby manifested – beyond its visible particularity – as an image and true presence of the One, Holy, Catholic and Apostolic Church.[394]

---

390 LG 7.
391 SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 65, 3, 1.
392 SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST III*, 79, 1; Cf. PO 5.
393 Cf. LG 3; 11.
394 Cf. LG 26.

298. The unity and indivisibility of the Eucharistic Body of the Lord implies the unity and indivisibility of the mystical Body of the Lord. Each Eucharist makes us surrender to the Lord, and integrates us into His one and undivided Body. That is why the Petrine ministry – the foundation of unity between the Episcopate and the universal Church – corresponds deeply with the Church's Eucharistic dimension.

299. Since Eucharist and Episcopate are realities essentially linked[395] by the institution of Christ, the unity of the Eucharist and the unity of the Episcopacy "with Peter and under Peter"[396] are not independent roots of the Church's unity. The liturgy manifests this reality, since all Eucharistic celebrations are carried out in union with one's own Bishop, the Pope, the universal Episcopate, the clergy and all the members of the People of God.[397] All valid celebrations of the Eucharist either express this universal communion with Peter and with the whole Church, or at least claim it objectively, as in the case of the Churches separated from Rome.

300. Therefore, in the Eucharist, the perpetuation of the sacrifice of the Cross, we will always find the deepest foundation of our unity as a Religious Family. The Eucharist must be one of our great loves, since it is the undeniable sign of God's immeasurable love for men, it is the sign of a God who wants to remain among men and who gives Himself up to man totally: "In the Sacrament, the logic of the Incarnation reaches its extreme consequences."[398]

---

[395] Cf. LG 26. AG 38.

[396] AG 38.

[397] Cf. RM, Eucharistic Prayer III.

[398] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Angelus Message, July 19, 1981; OR (7/26/1981) Spanish Edition.

301. The primary role of a priest is sacrifice: "A holy and unblemished sacrifice,"[399] "acceptable... which brings salvation to the whole world"[400] that "opens a way" toward the Father for us,[401] "unique,"[402] "of perfect reconciliation,"[403] "ours,"[404] "living."[405] Therefore, in the Eucharistic Liturgy Christ speaks, above all, with the strength of His Sacrifice. His speech is very concise but ardent. We must know how to listen to it attentively.

302. Every month a Holy Mass must be offered for the deceased members of the Institute, another one for the intentions of the General Superior, and a third one requesting the grace of final perseverance for all the members of our Institutes.

The Virgin Mary

303. The Virgin Mary should be another one of our great loves because of her union with Christ and with the Church. Since She gave birth to the Head, She gave birth to us members as well. She was given to us as Mother when She was standing at the foot of the Cross: *Behold, your son* (Jn 19:26).

304. The Holy Virgin Mary is model of ecclesial communion "in the order of faith, charity, and perfect union with Christ";[406] She "is the image and beginning of the Church… She shines forth

[399] RM, Eucharistic Prayer I.

[400] RM, Eucharistic Prayer IV.

[401] RM, Eucharistic Prayer V. (Translation taken from the Roman Missal Spanish Edition).

[402] RM, Eucharistic Prayer for Reconciliation I. (Translation taken from the Roman Missal Spanish Edition).

[403] RM, Eucharistic Prayer for Reconciliation II.

[404] RM, Eucharistic Prayer for Masses with Children II. (Translation taken from the Roman Missal Spanish Edition).

[405] RM, Eucharistic Prayer III.

[406] LG 63.

on earth, as a sign of sure hope and solace to the people of God during its sojourn on earth."[407]

305. She is in the midst of the Apostles, at the very heart of the newborn Church: *All these with one accord devoted themselves to prayer, together with the women and Mary, the mother of Jesus, and with his brothers* (Acts 1:14), and She is in the heart of the Church for all ages.

306. Indeed, "The Church was congregated in the upper part (of the cenacle) with Mary, who was the Mother of Jesus, and with his brethren. We cannot therefore speak of the Church unless Mary, the Mother of the Lord, is present there, with the Lord's brethren."[408] The Marian dimension is as essential to the one Church of Christ as are the Eucharistic and Petrine dimensions.

307. We must be apostles of Mary giving ourselves up to Her in a filial slavery of love, and doing everything "through Mary, with Mary, in Mary and for Mary."[409]

308. Always keep a memory of the Blessed Virgin in mind during *eutrapelia* and during cultural activities, because, after Jesus Christ, no one has done as much for the evangelization of culture as She did.

The Pope

309. Our third great love must always be the "white figure" of the Pope. "Wherever Peter is, the Church is there,"[410] and "Peter has spoken thus through Leo"[411] (at the moment of the writing of

---

[407] LG 68.

[408] SAINT CHROMATIUS OF AQUILEIA, *Sermons*, 30,1.

[409] SAINT LOUIS-MARIE GRIGNION DE MONFORT, *TD* 257.

[410] SAINT AMBROSE, *Writings about the Psalms*, 40, 30.

[411] Acclamation of the Conciliar Fathers of Calcedonia (451), concluding the reading of Saint Leo the Great's *Tomus ad Flavianum*.

this Directory, through Blessed John Paul II). After Simon gives testimony of Christ, *You are the Christ, the Son of the living God* (Mt 16:16), Christ gives testimony of Simon: *And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church* (Mt 16:18).

310. The idea of a Body of Churches demands the existence of a Head of these Churches. It is the Church of Rome, which "presides over the universal communion of love."[412] Peter's Successor "is the perpetual and visible source and foundation"[413] of the unity of the universal Church and of the unity of the Episcopate. Hence the Petrine ministry is not a service that reaches to the particular Churches "from outside," but one "already belonging to the essence of each particular Church from inside."[414] The ministry of Primacy implies an Episcopal power – both as universal Bishop and as Bishop of the Diocese of Rome – and not merely an episcopal dignity, so that everything a Bishop can do in his parishes, the Pope can do in all of the local Churches. This ministry is a supreme power: no one possesses equal or greater power; it is a full power, not merely a principal part; it is immediate – the Pope can exercise this power over the Bishops and the faithful; it is universal, over all without excluding anyone; it is ordinary, derived directly from Jesus Christ; and "he can always exercise it unhindered."[415]

311. The primordial task of the Roman Pontiff for the whole Church is to promote unity that is not contrary to promoting the diversification needed for proper communion.

312. We make the teaching of Saint Ignatius of Loyola our own: "If we wish to proceed securely in all things, we must hold

---

412 SAINT IGNATIUS OF ANTIOCH, *To the Romans*, prologue. MG 5,685.

413 LG 23.

414 Cf. BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Address to the Bishops of the United States at the Minor Seminary of Our Lady of Los Angeles, September 16, 1987; OR (10/18/1987) Spanish Edition.

415 LG 22.

fast to the following principle: What seems to me white, I will believe black if the hierarchical Church so defines."[416] Therefore, being certain that this is the will of Jesus Christ, "Let us remain deaf when someone speaks to us disregarding the Pope, or not explicitly in favor of the Pope, and when one is not in favor of the Church's wholesome and precise doctrine; these are not fruits of the Heavenly Father, but wicked sprouts of heresies that produce murderous fruit."[417] Let us always remember "that the Pope should be loved in the cross; and whoever does not love him in the cross, does not seriously love him. To be in everything with the Pope means to be in everything with God; to love Jesus Christ and to love the Pope is the same love,"[418] since "to love the Pope, to love the Church, is to love Jesus Christ."[419]

ARTICLE 6: HIS SECOND COMING

A. ANTECEDENT SIGNS

313. Jesus Christ came for the first time in humility and poverty. However, He will come a second time in power, greatness, dignity and majesty to demand an account and to judge.

314. The major signs of His second coming are three:

1. the Gospel will be preached to the whole world;[420]

2. there will be a universal apostasy;[421]

3. the Antichrist will make His appearance.[422]

---

416 SAINT IGNATIUS OF LOYOLA, *Spiritual Exercises* 365.
417 SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of Pentecost of 1912*.
418 SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letters*, 1. cit.
419 SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Letter of July 1, 1936*.
420 Cf. Mt 24:14.
421 Cf. 2 Thes 2:3.

315. There will come a time when men will go astray from the truth and *will delight in iniquity*,[423] a time in which the majority will not have true faith in Jesus Christ. The certainty that this universal apostasy will happen one day must prevent us from joining the triumphant march of any movement or ideology that is set apart from Christ, although it may seem that the whole world is following it. We must always follow Christ, and even though the enemies seem to be in the majority, we must say: "We are surrounded everywhere, don't let them escape." "All creatures appear small to the soul that contemplates God."[424]

B. THE FINAL AND UNIVERSAL RESURRECTION

316. At the end of time the resurrection of the body will take place. All men and women will resurrect by the power of God. We believe in the resurrection, and we are not afraid of persecutors who stalk the Church: *Do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul* (Mt 10:28).

317. The time of this resurrection is hidden and "all those who had been misled to calculate the aforesaid time have so far proved to be untruthful."[425]

318. The soul will take up its own entire body, and will enjoy the gifts of impassibility, subtlety, agility and clarity – or beauty.

319. Our trust and happiness from knowing that death has already been conquered should be so great! It has been conquered by the Incarnation of the Word and His redeeming Sacrifice. The Incarnation of the Word is the condition and guarantee for the whole universe: "The lack of life and salvation from despair for all

---

[422] Cf. 2 Thes 2:3-10.

[423] Cf. 2 Thes 2:12.

[424] SAINT GREGORY THE GREAT, C 35; ML 66,200.

[425] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST, Supplementum*, 77, 2; cf. SAINT AUGUSTINE, *The City of God*, 18, 53.

men, the condition *sine qua non* and the guarantee for the whole universe are locked in the words, *The Word was made flesh* and the faith in these words."[426] "The Incarnation of the Son of God is the foundation, the source and the pattern of a new supernatural order of existence for all men; in fact, from this mystery they obtain the grace that sanctifies and saves them, and it is a foundation of Christian anthropology that is also projected in the natural sphere of thought and life, with its exaltation of man as person, placed in the center of society and, you can say, of the whole world."[427]

C. THE PAROUSIA AND THE FINAL JUDGMENT

320. Then, the Parousia of the Lord will happen: *For the hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice* (Jn 5:28). *And then they will see the Son of man coming in a cloud with power and great glory* (Lk 21:27); *the sign of the Son of man* [the sign of the Cross] *in heaven will appear* (Mt 24:30). At that moment the universal judgment will take place. Christ, together with His chosen ones – *you who have followed me will also sit on twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel* (Mt 19:28) – will separate the sheep from the goats; some will be put to His right, and others to His left; and He will say, *Come, O blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom…* (Mt 25:34), and *depart from me, you cursed, into the eternal fire* (Mt 25:41). *And they will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life* (Mt 25:46).

321. We must increasingly convince ourselves that we do not work for ephemeral or fleeting things, but "for the most divine work among the divine ones,"[428] which is the eternal salvation of souls and the glorious resurrection of bodies. Aware that we are

---

[426] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Speech to the Participants of the Colloquy about the "Common Christian Roots of the European Peoples", November 5, 1981; OR (11/15/1981) Spanish Edition.

[427] BLESSED JOHN PAUL II, Catechesis of the Pope in a General Audience, March 26, 1988; OR (3/27/1988) Spanish Edition.

[428] PSEUDO-DIONYSIOS, quoted by SAINT ALPHONSUS LIGUORI, *Selva*, 9, 1.

working for eternal life, we must say with Blessed Louis Orione, "Place me, Lord, on the mouth of hell, so that I, by your mercy, may close it."[429]

D. THE INNOVATION

322. Then, the renewal of the entire material universe will take place. There will be *a new heaven and a new earth* (Is 65:17; Rev 21:1), so that the man resurrected in glory will be able to clearly see divinity with His senses, and somehow, he will see it in the corporeal world. The following words will be entirely true: "The heaven, and earth, and all that is therein, behold, on every side; they say that I should love You."[430]

323. The quantity and mode of this renewal "is known to Him alone Who will bring it about."[431] There *God…[will] be everything to everyone* (1 Cor 15:28); matter will reach maximum dignity, manifesting the Divine Spirit, because it will be a perfect mirror of God.

324. We only need to pray, work and wait, knowing that *this world is passing away* (1 Cor 7:31).

[429] SAINT LOUIS ORIONE, *Points from February*, 1939.
[430] SAINT AUGUSTINE, *Confessions*, 10, 4,6.
[431] SAINT THOMAS AQUINAS, *ST, Supplementum*, 91, 3.

CHAPTER 3
EPILOGUE

325. We finish this part of our fundamental code by summarizing what we want to be our spirituality:

Not Jesus or Mary; not Mary or Jesus.
Neither Jesus without Mary; nor Mary without Jesus.
Neither only Jesus, but also Mary; not only Mary, but also Jesus.
Always Jesus and Mary; always Mary and Jesus.
To Mary through Jesus: *Behold, your mother!* (Jn 19:27).
To Jesus through Mary: *Do whatever he tells you* (Jn 2:5).
First Jesus, the God man; then Mary, the Mother of God.
He, the Head; She, the Neck; we, the Body.

Everything through Jesus and through Mary;
with Jesus and with Mary;
in Jesus and in Mary;
for Jesus and for Mary.

In short, simply: Jesus and Mary; Mary and Jesus.

And through Christ, to the Father, in the Holy Spirit.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

CONSTITUTIONS.....9

CONTENTS.....11

PART 1 INTRODUCTION 13
Our Religious Family: General Principles or Our "Way".....15

PART 2 NATURE AND PURPOSE OF THE INSTITUTE 23
Article 1: Nature 25
Article 2: Common, Proper, and Specific End.....26
Article 3: Character.....28
Article 4: Charism.....29
Article 5: Mission.....29
Article 6: Spirit 30

PART 3 SPIRITUALITY.....31

PART 4 CONSECRATED LIFE.....37
Article 1: General Principles 39
Article 2: The Vow of Chastity.....41
Article 3: The Vow of Poverty.....43
Article 4: The Vow of Obedience 48
Article 5: Consecration to Mary.....52
a. Filial Slavery of Love.....*53*
b. "Marianizing" Life.....*54*

PART 5 COMMUNITY LIFE.....57
CHAPTER 1 THE COMMUNITIES 59
Article 1: Importance 59
Article 2: Essence 59
Article 3: Justice 60
Article 4: Joy.....60
Article 5: Peace.....61
Article 6: Chapter of Faults 63
Article 7: Fraternal Correction.....63
CHAPTER 2 THE SUPERIORS.....67
Article 1: One Governs Many.....67
Article 2: Characteristics of the Superior.....67
Article 3: Spiritual Fatherhood.....69
CHAPTER 3 THE SUBJECTS 73
Article 1: General difficulties 73
Article 2: Particular Difficulties 74
CHAPTER 4 BUILDING THE COMMUNITY.....77

Article 1: Human Virtues 77
Article 2: Life of Prayer 78
Article 3: Intellectual Life 81
Article 4: Life of Discipline 82
a. Dialogue with the Superior *83*
b. Recreation *83*
c. Leave of Absence *83*
d. Use of Media *84*
e. Enclosure *85*
f. Habit *85*
Article 5: Pastoral Life 86

PART 6 APOSTOLATE 89
Article 1: Sending 91
Article 2: Proclamation of the Kingdom 91
Article 3: Witnessing 92
Article 4: Apostolic Commitments 94
Article 5: Second and Third Orders 95
Article 6: Educational Apostolate 96
Article 7: Pastoral Work in Parishes 97
Article 8: Preachers 98
Article 9: Selection of Ministries 99
Article 10: Rest 102
Article 11: Keystones 102

PART 7 FORMATION OF MEMBERS 105
CHAPTER 1 DIMENSIONS OF THE FORMATION 107
Article 1: Human Formation 107
Article 2: Spiritual Formation 110
Article 3: Intellectual Formation 116
Article 4: Pastoral Formation 120
CHAPTER 2 STAGES OF FORMATION 123
Article 1: Minor Seminary 123
Article 2: Postulancy 125
Article 3: Novitiate 125
Article 4: Profession 129
a. Temporary Profession *129*
b. Perpetual Profession *132*
Article 5: Religious Seminary 134
a. Seminary for Religious Who Are Candidates to the Priesthood *134*
b. Seminary of the Coadjutor Brothers *135*
Article 6: Ongoing Formation 135
Article 7: Those Responsible for the Formation 138
Article 8: Re-admission 139

PART 8 GOVERNMENT OF THE INSTITUTE 141
Introduction: The Religious Family of the Incarnate Word 143
Article 1: Female Branch: The Institute of the Servants of the Lord and the Virgin of Matará 143
Article 2: Contemplative Branch 144
Article 3: Third Order 144
Article 4: Central Coordinating Board 145
CHAPTER 1 DIVISION OF THE INSTITUTE 147
CHAPTER 2: GENERAL CHAPTERS 149
Article 1: Convocation of the Chapters 149
Article 2: Celebration of the Chapter 150
CHAPTER 3 GENERAL GOVERNMENT 155
Article 1: Superior General 155
Article 2: Members of the General Council 159
a. Vicar General 159
b. Secretary General 160
c. Treasurer General 161
d. Other General Councilors 161
CHAPTER 4 THE OFFICE OF THE GENERAL COUNCIL 163
Article 1: Faculties 163
Article 2: Meetings of the General Council 165
CHAPTER 5 THE PROVINCIAL GOVERNMENT 169
Article 1: Provinces 169
Article 2: Provincial Superior 169
Article 3: Members of the Provincial Council 172
a. Provincial Vicar 172
b. Provincial Secretary 172
c. Other Provincial Councilors 173
d. Provincial Treasurer 173
Article 4: Provincial Councils 174
CHAPTER 6 CANONICAL VISITS 175
CHAPTER 7 THE LOCAL GOVERNMENT 177
Article 1: Local Superior 177
Article 2: Local Councilors 179
PART 9 ADMINISTRATION OF GOODS 181
PART 10 SEPARATION FROM THE INSTITUTE 185
PART 11 OBLIGATION TO OBSERVE THE CONSTITUTIONS 189

DIRECTORY OF SPIRITUALITY ... 193

CONTENTS ... 195

CHAPTER 1 THE MYSTERY OF THE WORD ... 197

Introduction ... 197
Article 1: Primacy of Jesus Christ ... 198
Article 2: Love for the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit ... 199
Article 3: Preexistence of the Word ... 199

CHAPTER 2 THE MYSTERY OF THE INCARNATE WORD ... 203

Article 1: His First Coming ... 203
a. The Divinity of Jesus ... 205
b. The Humanity of Jesus ... 206
c. The Union of Both Natures ... 217
d. The Purpose of the Incarnation ... 222
Article 2: His Earthly Life ... 224
a. On Becoming Flesh ... 224
b. In the Womb of the Virgin ... 228
c. Childhood ... 230
d. Hidden Life ... 232
e. Public Life ... 234
Baptism ... 234
Fasting ... 235
Temptations ... 237
Teaching and Works ... 242
Works ... 244
f. Priesthood of Christ ... 246
Article 3: His Exit From This World ... 249
a. Passion ... 249
The Cross in Our Life ... 249
Love of the Cross ... 250
Benefits ... 254
Example ... 256
Ways ... 256
Effects ... 258
Suffering ... 259
b. Death on the Cross and Burial ... 260
Folly of the Cross ... 263
c. The Descent to Hell ... 264
Article 4: His Glorious Life ... 265
a. Resurrection ... 265
The Fact ... 265
Effects ... 265
Sending Forth of the Holy Spirit: The New Law ... 266
Freedom ... 267
The New Man ... 269

Joy....272
Sunday....273
Feasting....274
Sending Forth and Mission....275
b. Ascension....277
c. To the Right Hand of the Father....279
d. The Kingship of Christ....279
Article 5: His Mystical Life....280
a. The Church, the Mystical Body....280
b. Her "History"....281
c. Her "Soul": the Holy Spirit....282
The Word of God....287
d. One Church....288
Agree With One Another....290
e. The Holy Church....293
f. Catholic Church....294
Missionary and Ecumenical Church....296
g. The Apostolic Church....302
h. In the "Three White Things"....307
The Eucharist....307
The Virgin Mary....310
The Pope....311
Article 6: His Second Coming....313
a. Antecedent Signs....313
b. The Final and Universal Resurrection....314
c. The Parousia and the Final Judgment....315
d. The Innovation....316

CHAPTER 3 EPILOGUE....317


IVE Press